

Delhi Cabinet meets LG Sandhu, discusses Govt initiatives

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and her cabinet colleagues called on Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu at Lok Niwas on Tuesday and shared with him the ongoing initiatives of the Delhi Government aimed at achieving the Centre's Viksit Bharat vision.

The LG underlined the key challenges and opportunities and the collective resolve to develop Delhi as a "global capital" aligned with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision, the Lok Niwas said in a post on X.

The Chief Minister, in a post on X, said that she paid a courtesy visit to the LG along with her Cabinet colleagues. She said the meeting was a positive step towards further strengthening the shared commitment to the inclusive development of Delhi and public service.

"Sustained dialogue and coordination between the



Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta along with Cabinet colleagues meets Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu at Lok Niwas in New Delhi

government and administration serve as the strong foundation for the state's progress and good governance," she said. In the meeting with the Lt Governor, a meaningful and extensive discussion was held on key schemes for public welfare and the vision to develop Delhi as a modern and world-class capital, she said.

The Delhi government is working with complete dedication and commitment for

the bright future and all-round development of every citizen of Delhi, she added.

Senior officers of the Delhi government, including Chief Secretary Rajeev Sharma, also met Sandhu. The LG reviewed key governance and administrative matters concerning Delhi with the officers, the Lok Niwas said.

The LG, in a meeting with the police commissioner and special commissioners of the Delhi Police, appreciated

their efforts and the challenges involved in policing in the national Capital.

He encouraged them to further enhance policing to ensure safe and secure Delhi, according to the city's status as the country's national capital, the Lok Niwas said in another post on X.

Cabinet Minister Kapil Mishra described the meeting as a constructive engagement, noting that discussions covered both ongoing development projects and emerging opportunities under the Chief Minister's leadership.

Education Minister Ashish Sood also termed the meeting significant, saying it would give new direction and momentum to development efforts in the Capital.

Within a week after taking charge as the Delhi Lt Governor, Sandhu has held a series of meetings with top officers of different departments and discussed with them governance and development-related matters.

Speaker urges LG Sandhu to install audio traffic signals to help vulnerable pedestrians

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta has urged Lt Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu to install audio traffic signals to help vulnerable pedestrians like senior citizens and persons with disabilities.

In a letter dated March 16, Gupta expressed concern over the daily challenges faced by vulnerable pedestrians and cited visibility issues faced by a large number of people in the city.

Citing alarming data from the Dr Rajendra Prasad Centre for Ophthalmic Sciences at AIIMS, Gupta highlighted that nearly 60 lakh people in Delhi suffer from various vision impairments. With an estimated 12 to 18 lakh people living with significant low vision, many of whom are senior citizens, the Speaker emphasised that current traffic systems are inadequate for those who cannot rely on visual cues. The letter stresses that the lack of accessible crossing



aids poses a constant risk of accidents and limits the mobility of a vast section of the population.

The Speaker pointed toward successful international models where sound-based cues, such as beeps or ticking tones, are standard features at intersections.

He noted that countries like Japan, the United Kingdom, the United States, Hong Kong, Singapore, France, Sweden, Brazil, and Australia have successfully integrated these systems to improve pedestrian accessi-

bility. Gupta specifically mentioned the use of "melodic" or bird-like sounds, as seen in Japan, which help pedestrians easily recognise when it is safe to cross, thereby creating a more empathetic and user-friendly urban environment.

The speaker underlined that the installation of audible signals at major traffic intersections is not just a technical upgrade but a necessity for human dignity and safety. By implementing these measures, Delhi can significantly reduce road

accidents and move toward becoming a truly inclusive "smart city" that caters to all its residents regardless of their physical abilities. The Speaker has requested the LG to examine the proposal and expedite the implementation on a priority basis to transform Delhi's roads into a safer space for every citizen.

Delhi Traffic Police conducted a survey in March 2024 in which the problem of traffic congestion was found in 134 locations/stretches, primarily due to ongoing construction works by various civic agencies, encroachment and heavy volume of traffic. These were shared with concerned agencies in March 2024 for taking up necessary remedial measures.

Besides this, Delhi Traffic Police also shared the lists of 128 bad-conditioned/potholed roads and 97 damaged/encroached footpaths with the respective civic agencies in October 2024 for necessary remedial measures.

Jamia introduces 30 new programmes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Jamia Millia Islamia (JMI) has introduced 30 new programmes for the upcoming academic session, significantly expanding its academic offerings across disciplines, university officials said on Tuesday.

The university has also set March 25, 2026, as the deadline for applications to its undergraduate, postgraduate, diploma, and certificate courses, urging prospective students to complete the process in time.

The online application process commenced on February 20, with the release of the university prospectus.

The new programmes include BA (Hons) Japanese Studies, BA (Hons) German Studies, BA (Hons) Uzbek Language, Literature & Culture; BA (Hons) Human Resource Management, MSc (Renewable Energy); BTech (Robotics & Artificial Intelligence); BTech Civil Engineering (Construction Technology), among others. "Significantly, there has



been no increase in course fees across all programmes for 2026-27. In line with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, admissions under the multiple entry mode for Four-Year Undergraduate Programs (FYUP) will commence from the academic session 2026-27, offering enhanced flexibility to students," a university official said.

To improve accessibility for candidates across the country, Jamia has added three new test centres in Jaipur, Dehradun, and Kishanganj, taking the total number to 11. Existing centres include Delhi, Lucknow,

Guwahati, Patna, Kolkata, Srinagar, Calicut, and Bhopal.

In line with the central government's agenda for internationalisation of higher education and to increase the intake of foreign students in Indian universities, Jamia has substantially reduced fees for foreign students under the general and supernumerary categories, the official said.

A region-wise differential fee structure has been introduced for students from SAARC countries, West Asian countries, and African and Latin American countries across eligible UG, PG, and diploma programmes, he said.

Woman killed after crane rammed into their scooter

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

A 28-year-old woman was killed and a man seriously injured after a crane rammed into their scooter and ran them over in east Delhi's Shahdara area on Monday night. The driver was caught on the spot by locals and handed over to the authorities.

The incident took place near the Shyamal College flyover under the jurisdiction of Shahdara police station when the victims were returning home around 10 pm.

According to police, the crane hit the scooter from behind with force, throwing both riders onto the road. The heavy vehicle then ran over them, leading to critical injuries. The woman, identified as Nisha (28), was declared dead at the hospital, while the injured man, Shabir, is undergoing treatment at Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital.

Nisha, a resident of Nand



Nagri, lived with her parents in the B-5 block area and ran a beauty parlour in Ashok Nagar. She had been married for less than five years but was living separately from her husband due to personal differences.

Family members said she had stepped out in the evening with Shabir to buy some items from the market and was on her way back home when the accident took place.

Given that the woman had been married for less than seven years, a probe is also being conducted by the Sub-Divisional Magistrate (SDM) as per legal procedure.

Budget to have key initiatives for women, girls: CM Rekha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday announced that the upcoming Delhi Budget, to be presented on March 24, will include key initiatives for women and girls.

Highlighting the importance of Self-Help Groups (SHGs), she said women in Delhi will be provided employment and entrepreneurship opportunities through small group-based models. She also stressed the need to expand platforms like 'Mahila Haat' to help women showcase and sell their products.

Rekha Gupta made these assertions after attending the 'Nari Utsav' programme held at the Nirmal Chhaya Complex, where she paid tribute to the strength and contribution of women in nation-building.

She said women, through their dedication, selfless service and sense of duty,



are playing a leading role across sectors and driving the country towards the goal of Viksit Bharat 2047.

During her visit, the Chief Minister toured the Nirmal Chhaya campus and reviewed various schemes, services and facilities. She also launched and assessed several initiatives of the Department of Women and Child Development, reiterating the Delhi government's commitment to the holistic empowerment of women and children.

She noted that under Prime Minister Narendra

Modi's leadership, women are scaling new heights from rural industries to corporate sectors and from politics to the armed forces and said the Delhi Government is working in the same direction to make women more empowered and self-reliant.

Emphasising safety, dignity and self-reliance as the three pillars of women's empowerment, Rekha Gupta said every woman deserves a secure environment, respect in all circumstances, and opportunities to become financially independent.

NORTHERN RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE
The Dy.Chief Electrical Engineer (Const), Northern Railway, Shivaji Bridge, New Delhi for and on behalf of the President of India invites open e-tender for the following work:

1.	Name of work and location	Comprehensive Annual Maintenance Contract (CAMEC) of Window Type and Split Type Air Conditioners, Storage Type Water Coolers, Refrigerators/Deep Freezers and Desert Coolers installed in various Construction Offices and Rest Houses in Delhi/New Delhi area and CAMEC of 2 x 16 HP VRF Air Conditioning Plant installed at CAO/C Office Complex, Kashmiri Gate, Delhi
2.	Completion period of the work	36 Months
3.	Approx. Cost of work	Rs. 50,92,960/-
4.	Security to be deposited	Rs. 1,01,900/-
5.	Date & Time for submission of E-tender and opening of tender	Tenders may be uploaded upto 15:00 hrs on 08.04.2026 date on IREPS web site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in The bidders can participate in the e-tender, the tender will be opened at 15:00 hrs on 08.04.2026
6.	Detailed Tender Notice & Tender Document	The detailed e-tender notice is available on Northern Railway web site i.e. www.nr.indianrailways.gov.in and tender document is available on www.ireps.gov.in Above tenders document will be available for submission of offer on IREPS web site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in from 25.03.2026 to 08.04.2026. All other terms and conditions in respect of above tenders are given in tender document. The detailed tender notice also can be seen on the Notice Board at the above office.

No. Tender No. 17-Elect/DCYCE/CT/161 Dated: 16.03.2026
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 890/26

The Pioneer
Classified

CHANGE OF NAME
I, Nirmala Betagar W/o No. 14667396P Hav Balesh Betagar, R/o- Vill- Shindihatti, PO- Hidkal Dam, Teh- Hukkeri, Dist- Belagavi, Karnataka- 591107, declare that in my husband's service record my D.O.B is wrongly mentioned as 07/08/1995 whereas my correct DOB is 08/07/1995 which may be amended accordingly.
PD(536)C
I, Vijay Kumari Mother of No.2504923X Hav Vaneet Kumar, R/o- Vill- Khalet, PO- Thakurdwara, Teh- Palampur, Dist- Kangra, H.P- 176102, have changed my name from Vijay Kumari to Vijai Devi, vide affidavit dated 17/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(533)C
I, JC-302593P Ex-Sub P Manibabu Singha R/o Vill- Srihar Awang Leikai, PO- Lalang Pt II, PS- Lakhipur Dist- Cachar, State- Assam, PIN- 788098 have changed my daughter's name & date of birth in my records from Monika Devi DOB- 15 Nov 2002 to P Monika Devi DOB- 28 Dec 2003 vide affidavit dated 16/03/2026 before 1st Class Magistrate, Silchar, Cachar, Assam.
PD(534)C
I, No. 14869812W LNK Ashish Singh Negi R/o- Karchi PO- Regari, Dist- Chamoli, Teh- Joshimath, Uttarakhand- 246483, have changed my Father's name in my service record from Shankar Singh Negi to Shankar Singh, vide affidavit dated 17/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(535)C

CHANGE OF NAME
I/WE ANKIT HOODA S/O SH. SANJIV KUMAR R/O VILLAGE DAYALPUR (86) FARIDABAD, HARYANA-121004 (ADHAR No. 4048 3270 4547) declare That my father's name in my education certificate has been mentioned as SANJEEV KUMAR but his correct name as per my all other document is SANJIV KUMAR & SANJIV KUMAR is the name of one and same person, in future I may be enrolled and called by father name SANJIV KUMAR.
PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the General public on behalf of our client i.e. ICICI Bank Ltd. that Mr. Nipun Jain, is owner of Property /Plot bearing No.86, Block-B, addressing 355.16 sq. mtrs., in Plikhan Estate situated at Sector-Alpha-01, Greater Noida. Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar, U.P (½ share by virtue of Transfer deed dt. 03.08.2017, registration No. 23488, & ¼ share vide Mutation letter dt. 09.01.2025 after demise of his father late Mr. Naveen Jain). All Persons including other surviving members/legal heirs are hereby informed that above owner want to take loan facility from our client against the said property. If anybody has any objections upon the ownership of above owner's title its sale mortgage, and any other kind of objection/lienation, Charge etc., kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 10 days of the present.
Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants)
200, Indir Nagar, 23, Shivaji Marg, Mohi Nagar, Delhi-110028
Tel: 011-4115257-28 Mob: 011-4115257-28

PUBLIC NOTICE
A notice of intended marriage has been received from Mr. Anmol Sinha S/o Mr. Ajeet Kumar Sinha R/o SD-149, Sector-45 Noida, Gautambudh Nagar, (U.P) and Ms. Gabrielle Pearl Bennett D/o Mr. Heath Kenneth Henderson R/o 19 Frances Street, Balclutha, Otago-9230, New Zealand in the Office of The undersigned, any person interested Therein, may file objections to it on any day upto 10-04-2026 in The Office of The undersigned.
Deputy Collector/ I/c City Magistrate/ Marriage Officer Noida
Gautam Budh Nagar

PUBLIC NOTICE
That My Client Dr. Kiran Pal Singh S/o Late Majnu Singh R/o Flats No. 6073/2/GF/Pocket D-6, Vasant Kunj, New Delhi-110070 has instructed me to release Public Notice that Ms Purnima associated with my client through publication dt. 15/2/2015 as pre-condition partner for taking care of Mentally retarded son on 30/4/2015 on production of Election Card depicting indifferent name of husband and date of birth in place of Aadhar Card. Aadhar Card is again having different date of Birth and all documents shows multiple places of residences. Different date of birth is mentioned in High School Certificate, considered to be doubtful, later on SDM Saket, New Delhi did not register the re-marriage on 23/10/2015 for want verification of documents of Ms Purnima. Ms Purnima Singh implicated my client in several police complaints on 26/10/2015, 28/3/2016, 30/3/2016 etc. which proved to be false and withdrawn, further Ms. Purnima filed DVC complaint on 26/7/2016 and second complaint on 2/6/2017 on same ground, which are withdrawn and settled on demand of separate house and alimony @ Rs.15,000/- per month vide Gurugram Court's order dt. 9/11/2016 and Dwarka Court's order dt. 6/9/2017. Ms Purnima lodged FIR No.11/2017 dt. 13/1/2017 which was false and quashed by Hon'ble ASJ Court Dwarka on 8/3/2018. Ms Purnima further filed other complaints on 2/5/2019, 26/5/2019, 30/5/2017 which are declared false by Gurugram Police vide RTI No. 37350 dt. 6/11/2019 and 3823 dt. 13/11/2019. Ms Purnima is habitual in filing false and frivolous complaints against my client and there is constant life threat to my client. My client has been attacked several times by suspected persons on 21/1/2016, 26/12/2016, 12/1/2017, 10/3/2019, 24/3/2019, 29/9/2019, 10/9/2019 and 2/5/2019 under criminal cases pending before Distt. Court of Dwarka/ Patiala House/ Saket and High Court of Delhi. Besides the Criminal proceedings of defamation/extortion/ illegal trespassing in the S-11/3, DLF, Ph-3, Gurugram Ms Purnima has been extending constant threats to my client, she has broken open the locks of said S-11/3, DLF property without knowledge of property owners. In view of above, Ms Purnima has been debarrd by this Public Notice & vide earlier press publications dt. 28/5/20198 19/11/2019 from all movable and immovable properties and have no legal claims under prevailing circumstances under HMA Act 1955. My client will not be responsible for misconduct and misdeeds etc. of Ms Purnima since my client is not aware regarding where about of her movements and there is no communication since 22/4/2019 whatsoever with her etc. Therefore my client is not responsible for any acts, misdeeds etc. and my client should not be entangled in any manner. Any person(s) dealing with Ms Purnima in any manner whatsoever will be at his own risk, costs and responsibilities. Moreover my client has developed multiple illness such as chronic disease diabetes type 2, loss of hearing, and poor eye vision besides this high blood pressure, and due to all mentioned above, abnormal mental stress and unwanted harassment for which Ms. Purnima is mainly responsible for cause death of my client Dr. Kiran Pal Singh in future. She would be liable to be prosecuted in the event of my client Dr. Kiran Pal Singh) casually. My client's children would initiate the appropriate criminal proceedings against the said Purnima as per law. This is for information to general public/ Govt. Agencies/ Police and Law enforcing Authorities as last option.
Ajit Singh
Enrl. No. D/204-C/92 Advocate
Ch. No. -246, II Floor, Block -I, Delhi High Court, New Delhi-110003

PUBLIC NOTICE
I, Santan Singh Rawat S/O Keshar Singh Rawat R/O Quarter No. 1929, Ground Floor, Behind Tpdal Grid, Timarpur, North Delhi, Delhi-110054 declare that name of mine has been wrongly written as Santan Singh in my Service Record and name of my father has been, wrongly written as Kalshar Singh in my PAN Card No. ANXP3352R. The actual name of mine and my father are Santan Singh Rawat and Keshar Singh Rawat, which may be amended accordingly.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Shri Vikash Kumar who is purchasing the Plot area measuring 100 Sq. Yards i.e. 83.61 Sq. Meters, related in Khassa No. 53, situated at Village Haibatpur, Pargana & Tehsil Dadri, District Gautam Budh Nagar, U.P.: From Smt. Rani and Shri Ranjeet who have owned the subject property through Sale Deed duly registered in the office of SR-Noida-4, as registration No. 5951, Addl. Book No. 1, Page Nos. 375-384, Volume No. 12785, dated 30.05.2024 which was executed by Shri Neeraj Yadav. Since the property is being sold to Mr. Vikash Kumar, all legal heirs of Teekam hereby confirm that they have no claims or objections regarding this sale. Now, Shri Vikash Kumar, Shri Ashok Singh and Smt. Rajeshwari intend to purchase and mortgage the same against the financial assistance from Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Ltd. To comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any person(s) having any objection regarding ownership and/ or creating mortgage of the said property please hereby requested to intimate in writing to the undersigned about his objections within 07 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. **Lucem Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Saraf Community Centre New Delhi-110048 Contact # 011-40646316 & 41667327**

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mig Dumtech Industries to inform to the public at large that Smt. Kirti Chauhan who Shri Puneet Jaswal is the owner of the M.C.F. Plot No.44, area measuring 173.25 Sq. Yds., part of Khassa No.78, situated at Waka Mauza Saran (Pati Sadakuh), Tehsil Badkhal, District Faridabad vide Sale Deed dated 23.04.2025 (Doc. No.728) and same to be financed & mortgaged by Ujjivan Small Finance Bank Ltd., Raj Nagar, Ghaziabad, U.P. That, Original Transfer Deed dated 08.01.2018 executed by Shri Sandeep Kumar s/o Shri Madan Mohan in favour of Smt. Savitri Devi wife of Mr. Madan Mohan (d/o Shri Punnu Ram alias Punnu Ram Ratna) in respect of portion of plot of land area measuring 173.25 sq. yards, out of total area 346.5 sq. yards, out of Khassa No. 78 (Doc No. 4533) has been lost and an Online FIR already lodged FIR No. 132250807/260020, dated 07.03.2026, PS-Saran, District Faridabad. So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any person having any type of claim right/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 7 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. **Lucem Legal LLP Near Yusuf Saraf Community Centre New Delhi-110048 Contact # 011-40646316 & 41667327**

PUBLIC NOTICE
(UNDER INSTRUCTIONS OF THE PROPOSED PURCHASER - LITIGATION-PROOF NOTICE)
Notice is hereby given to the general public at large, in India and Ontario, Canada, that my client Mr. Shri Kulbushan Sathani S/o Shri Sathik Kumar Sathani R/o 72, Third Floor, Temu Enclave, Pitampura Delhi - 110034 (hereinafter referred to as the "Proposed Purchaser"), has agreed to purchase and acquire all right, title and interest in respect of the property bearing Flat No. SD-7, on third floor, Block No. SD, Pitampura, Delhi-110034, (hereinafter referred to as the "said property") from Mr. Dhamesh Kumar Jain @ Dhamesh Jain, who claims to be the absolute owner in possession thereof.
That the said property was originally conveyed by Delhi Development Authority in favour of Late Shri Hrish Chandra Bhatnagar, who expired on 31/07/2014 at Ontario, Canada, and thereafter the title is claimed to have devolved upon his legal heirs and subsequent transferees through lawful means.
Any person(s), including but not limited to any legal heir(s), successor(s), claimant(s), administrator(s), nominee(s), attorney holder(s), banks, financial institution(s), government authority, tenant(s), occupant(s), mortgagee(s), charge holder(s), beneficiary(ies), trust(s), or any other person(s) having or claiming any right, title, interest, share, claim, objection, lien, charge, mortgage, inheritance, succession, easement, possession or encumbrance of any nature whatsoever in respect of the said property, whether by way of sale, agreement to sell, gift, inheritance, succession, will, trust, family settlement, court order, decree or otherwise, are hereby required to notify and submit their claims with supporting documentary evidence to the undersigned Advocate, within 15 (Fifteen) days from the date of publication of this notice.
Failing which, I shall be conclusively presumed that no such person has any right, title, interest or claim in the said property and the title of the Vendor shall be deemed clear and marketable. Thereafter, my client shall proceed with the purchase and acquisition of the said property in accordance with law, without any further reference to any person.
Further, this public notice shall constitute conclusive notice to the entire world at large, and any subsequent claim shall be subject to the legal defenses available to the Proposed Purchaser, including but not limited to estoppel, acquiescence, waiver and protection as bona fide purchaser without notice.
The claims, if any, must be sent to the undersigned at the following address: **SAKIL AHAMAD** (Advocate for the proposed purchaser) Office Address: G-21, Ground Floor, West Patel Nagar, New Delhi - 110008 Contact: 8285530683 Email: advsaakil@gmail.com
Date: 27.02.2026
Place: New Delhi

IN THE COURT OF 38TH ADDL CHIEF JUDICIAL MAGISTRATE AT BANGALURU (CH-38)
C.C. No. 8329/2023
BETWEEN:
OTDC EXPRESS LTD.,
No. 269, Lahari Towers, Albert Victor Road, 1st Main, Chamaraajpet, Bangalore-560018.
Repled by its Senior Legal Manager
AND
COMPLAINANT.....
1. Lakshya Courier & Cargo
Delvi KI Dhani, Bas Khosla, Shop No: 2, Near Ginger B Mansarovar, Gurgaon, Haryana-122052.
Repled by its Prop: Mr. Himanshu (LF-731)
2. Mr. Himanshu.
Proprietor of Lakshya Courier & Cargo
At: Delvi KI Dhani, Bas Khosla, Shop No: 2, Near Ginger B Mansarovar, Gurgaon, Haryana-122052.
Mobile No: 8130713370
ACCUSED.....
PUBLIC NOTICE
WHEREAS, the Complainant has filed the above complainant before the Hon'ble 38th Addl. Chief Judicial Magistrate at Bangaluru that the Accused Mr. Himanshu is suspected to have committed the offence punishable U/S 138 of N.I. Act 1981 and the Arrest warrant issued thereupon has returned and that the said Accused Mr. Himanshu can not be found. AND WHEREAS it has been shown to the satisfaction of the Hon'ble court of 38th Addl. Chief Judicial Magistrate at Bangaluru that the said Accused has been absconding or concealing themselves to avoid the service of the said warrant.
PROCLAMATION is hereby made that the said Accused Mr. Himanshu is required to appear before the Hon'ble 38th Addl. Chief Judicial Magistrate, Bangaluru to answer the said complainant on 02.05.2026. Given under my Hand and seal of this court this 24 day of January 2026.
Address of Services:
P.K. Venkatesh Prasad, No. 116/6, 11th cross, Mallewaram, Bangaluru-3.
By order of court
Senior Shirsastdar
XXXVII ADDL CHIEF JUDICIAL MAGISTRATE AT BANGALURU CITY

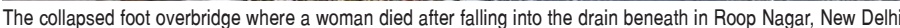
PUBLIC NOTICE
Enrl. No. D/204-C/92 Advocate
Ch. No. -246, II Floor, Block -I, Delhi High Court, New Delhi-110003

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

According to officials, the

Delhi's Irrigation and Flood Control Minister Parvash Sahib Singh Verma announced the formation of a three-member committee to probe the incident. The panel has been asked to submit its report within 48 hours. "We have constituted

hours. "We have constituted



PANKAJ KUMAR

Authorities have cordoned off the area to avoid further risk. Forensic and technical teams have inspected the

Officials said further action in the Roop Nagar case will depend on the findings of the inquiry committee. Residents, meanwhile, have demanded urgent repairs and removal of unsafe structures to prevent more tragedies.

Locals from Gur Mandi, including Vikas Kumar, Ishwar Singh and Kavita, surrounded leaders and asked why no concrete measures were taken to completely restrict access to the bridge despite it being declared unsafe. They questioned why people were allowed to continue using the structure and why no timely action was taken even after several complaints flagged the risk.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

But residents on both sides said those measures rarely

"All the domestic workers and students use this route," a resident said, pointing out that a weekly market and a dairy across the drain see regular footfall from women and families. Students were among the most frequent users.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Responding to a student's query about AI, he advised that one should make AI an assistant rather than a master. He further noted

Responding to queries on Value Addition Courses (VACs) and Skill Enhancement Courses (SECs), the VC said the primary aim of education is to nurture responsible and well-rounded individuals.

Come & Experience
Rich Tribal Heritage

BTF 18 - 30 March 2026 Bharat Tribes Fest

• Rooted • Resilient • Rising

Premium Signature Pavilion &
RISA tribal brand

Authentic delicious tribal cuisine
and Cultural Programmes from
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Highlights:

200+ curated stalls of tribal crafts,
textiles and forest produce

Bharat Tribes Business & CSR
Conclave for national and global
partnerships

Inauguration

by

Shri Jual Oram

Hon'ble Union Minister of Tribal Affairs

In the august presence of

Shri Durgadas Uikey

Hon'ble Union Minister of State for Tribal Affairs

18 March 2026

05:00 pm

Sunder Nursery, New Delhi

CBC 43104/13/0016/2526

“Our Government has been steadfast in its efforts towards empowerment of our tribal communities and preservation of their traditions. We are working tirelessly to transform the tribal-rural economic system.”

Narendra Modi, Prime Minister

Nearest Metro Station - JLN Stadium #BharatTribesFest #Vocal4Local #BuyTribal

IN FOCUS



Actor Bhumi Pednekar performing rituals on the banks of the Ganga during her visit to Parmarth Niketan Ashram, in Rishikesh

Health insurance for all by 2033: FM Sitharaman

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Health insurance is a priority for this Government and it is expected that the country will have insurance for all by 2033, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said in the Rajya Sabha on Tuesday.

Replying to supplementary queries during Question Hour, she said the insurance sector is expanding and during 2024-25 it covered 58 crore lives in the country. "Health insurance is a priority for this Government. In fact, we are hoping that by 2033 we will have insurance cover for all," she said.

In December 2025, the minister said the Government came up with a



Nirmala Sitharaman speaking in the Rajya Sabha during the second part of the Budget session of Parliament in New Delhi

Bill to hike FDI in the insurance sector with an aim to increase its penetration and deepen the market.

She said insurance regulator IRDAI notified rules for the rural social sector and third-party obligations in 2024 to increase penetration in rural

bridging this gap through targeted reforms and affordability measures.

Health insurance is now a clear priority with GST exemption on individual premiums, expansion of coverage and strong regulatory push driving the momentum," the finance minister said. Noting that health insurance is actually rapidly expanding as a market, she said, "today the sector has already scaled significantly, reaching ₹1,17,505 crore in 2024-25 and covering 58 crore lives, with balanced contributions from public, private and standalone insurers." "Public sector insurers particularly through health premiums, give cover of worth ₹42,420 crore, private sector," Sitharaman said.

BJP rejects US body's call to ban RSS, RAW

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Tuesday termed a report by the United States Commission on International Religious Freedom (USCIRF) recommending sanctions on the RSS and RAW as "baseless" and alleged that the Congress has taken a position against India by endorsing it.

The ruling party said the Centre has rejected the report, adding that it lacks "objective facts" and is based on non-credible sources.

"USCIRF in its March 2026 report has recommended imposing sanctions on the RSS and RAW — the Research and Analysis Wing of India. The Indian Government, through the MEA, has responded clearly, stating that this US commission works in a subjective manner



and that its sources are not credible. "It has also said that the report contains no objective facts. In effect, the Government has rejected this report of the US commission," BJP MP and national spokesperson Sambit Patra told reporters in the Lok Sabha house complex.

"It is very unfortunate that in opposing the BJP and Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the Congress party today appears to be standing against India itself," the MP added.

Delhi LG stresses human touch in Digital India

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Tuesday said the future of nation-building is digital but its heart must remain human.

Sandhu, the former diplomat and newly appointed LG, was delivering the keynote address at Global Confluence 2026 organised by the National Association of Software and Service Companies (NASSCOM).

Sandhu recalled his long association with NASSCOM since his role as a diplomat in the USA, and added that it was apt that the Global Confluence organised by the Association was one of his first events in his capacity as Delhi LG.

He was administered the oath as Delhi's 23rd LG on March 11. "History teaches us that nations are built on foundations of stone, steel and sweat. But in 2026, the architecture of nation-building has changed.

"Today, the most vital infrastructure is often invisible. It exists in the pulses of fibre-optic cables, the logic of algorithms and the seamless flow of data," Sandhu said.

In large and diverse democracies such as India, technology becomes particularly important as it enables systems to operate at scale. No one has demonstrated the transformative power of technology better than India,



he asserted. "Under the visionary leadership of Prime Minister (Narendra Modi), we have harnessed this power through initiatives such as Digital Public Infrastructure (DPIs), Atal Tinkering Labs, Start Up India, Digital India, IndiaAI Mission, Semicon Mission and the Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF)," he cited various initiatives of the central Government.

The ultimate aim of any innovation has to be the improvement in the lives of the people, he said, and added, "We see the use of drones for getting our vaccines across to remote areas, the creation of tractor-sharing apps among our farmers and the use of AI to ensure the optimal use of fertilisers and pesticides."

Highlighting India's digital transformation, the LG said that in the past decade, the country has witnessed one of the most remarkable digital transformations.

MACT court 4.59 cr awarded to parents of Italian woman engineer

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Motor Accident Claims Tribunal (MACT) here has awarded over Rs 4.59 crore as compensation to the parents of a 35-year-old Italian engineer who died in a road accident in Rajasthan in 2008 and Rs 1.82 crore to her sister who sustained grievous injuries in the same incident.

Presiding Officer Charu Gupta held that the accident occurred due to the "composite negligence" of the drivers of both vehicles involved, including a tourist car and a truck. On August 10, 2008, Italian nationals Cristina Severi and her sister Maria Claudia Severi were travelling from Jodhpur to Jaipur



when their car collided with a truck on NH-14 in Rajasthan's Pali district. Cristina succumbed to her injuries on the way to the hospital, while Maria Claudia sustained serious injuries and later underwent treatment at AK Hospital,

Beawar, Rajasthan in India. She later continued the rest of the treatment in Italy. "This Tribunal is of the opinion that the petitioner has been able to prove on the scales of preponderance of probabilities that the accident in question took place due to composite negligence on the part of drivers of the offending vehicles," said the court in its judgment dated February 28.

The insurer for the offending truck, Bajaj Allianz General Insurance, refuted its liability to compensate the petitioners on the ground that the driver of the truck committed a breach of the terms of policy by driving without a valid licence. They further argued that the accident occurred due to the sole negligence of the tourist

car carrying the Italian sisters.

The driver of the tourist car denied negligence, rashness or fault on their part as the offending truck was driving on the wrong side of the road and was approaching at a high speed from the opposite side. The insurer of the tourist car, United India General Insurance, argued along similar lines and said only the driver of the offending truck had been chargesheeted by the police, making them solely liable.

During her cross-examination, petitioner Maria said that the tourist car she was a passenger of not only was being driven at a high speed but also in a zig-zag manner, making it obvious to her to sense the carelessness of the driver.

However, she stressed that the truck was equally liable as it came from the wrong side of the road. Neither of the drivers of the car and the truck stepped into the witness box to explain the circumstances under which the accidents occurred, causing the court to draw an adverse inference against them.

The court rejected the argument absolving the insurers of the truck of all liability on the basis of the driver not having a valid licence, as it noted no evidence to substantiate the claim had been placed on record. The insurance company has neither served a notice under the Civil Code of Procedure (CPC) for the production of the driver's licence nor has it examined any witness to prove the claim.

Elderly woman patient dies of alleged rat bite in Govt hospital ICU in Thane

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Thane

An 89-year-old woman admitted to the ICU of a Government-run hospital in Maharashtra's Thane district died after allegedly being bitten by a rat, officials said on Tuesday.

The woman, identified as Suhasini Mathekar, was admitted to the Pandit Bhimsen Joshi Hospital in Mira Bhayandar on March 12 and placed on a ventilator.

According to her family, they discovered on the morning of March 16 that a rat had bitten the octogenarian's right hand, causing a deep wound and significant blood loss. She passed



away later that afternoon. The incident has triggered outrage over hygiene standards at the facility. A senior doctor at the hospital said the woman, prima facie, died of a rat bite in the ICU. "The family has alleged that medical staff failed to notice the rodent

in a highly monitored area like the ICU. We have registered a case of accidental death for now," a local police official said. Responding to the allegations, the hospital management attributed the "rat menace" to ongoing construction activities in the vicinity, claiming that rodent preventive measures were already in place.

As an immediate measure, a doctor and a nurse have been transferred out of the hospital.

The management has ordered a high-level enquiry into the incident to fix accountability and audit the facility's sanitation protocols.

CM Sukhu to present HP Budget on Saturday

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Shimla

The Himachal Pradesh budget for the year 2026-27 will be presented in the assembly on March 21, Speaker Kuldeep Singh Pathania said on Tuesday.

Addressing mediapersons, he said there would be 13 sittings in the second phase of the budget session, to be held between March 18 and April 2. In the first phase of the budget session held between February 16 and 18, three sittings were held.

Discussions on the budget estimates will take place from March 23 to 25, while deliberations on demands for grants and cut motions

are scheduled between March 27 and 30, he said.

The speaker further said a total of 834 questions have been received, including 665 starred and 169 unstarred questions. Eight issues would be raised under Rule 62, three under Rule 101 and five under Rule 130. Most of the questions asked by the legislators pertain to the Indira Gandhi Pyari Behna Sukh Samman Nidhi, the transition of schools from the state board to the CBSE, construction of roads and bridges, detailed project reports for sanctioned roads, and upgradation of colleges, schools, and health institutions within the State.

41.41 lakh fake ration cards deleted in 2025: GOVT

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

As many as 41.41 lakh ineligible ration cards were deleted in 2025, with maximum in Haryana, followed by Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh and West Bengal, according to the government data placed before Parliament on Tuesday.

About 13.43 lakh ineligible ration cards were deleted in Haryana, 6.05 lakh in Rajasthan, 5.97 lakh in Uttar Pradesh, 3.74 lakh in West Bengal, and 2.60 lakh in Madhya Pradesh, as per the data given by the Minister of State for Food Nimuben Jayantibhai Bambhaniya in the Rajya Sabha.

FROM PAGE - 1

7 foreigners caught plotting drone terror

They are being interrogated to ascertain the whereabouts of their seven associates and unearth the entire conspiracy," an NIA official said. The official added that after arriving in India, the suspects flew to Guwahati before travelling to Mizoram without RAP, and allegedly crossed into Myanmar for "pre-scheduled training for Myanmar-based Ethnic Armed Groups (EAGs)." They are also accused of transporting multiple consignments of drones from Europe.

"These EAGs are known to support insurgent organisations operating in India, particularly in drone warfare, operations, assembly, and jamming technology," the NIA stated.

The suspects were produced before a Delhi court on Monday and remanded to NIA custody until March 27. Sources said they were involved in illegally transporting drones from Europe to Myanmar to aid ethnic armed groups, which in turn supply weapons, training, and terror equipment to banned Indian insurgent outfits.

"Their sustained interrogation is underway to trace the routes used by the accused, examine mobile data to identify funding sources, and track down other co-accused persons," the NIA official said. "The Myanmar-based groups support proscribed Indian insurgent groups and pose a serious threat to India's national security."

From RCom to Videocon: Bank of Maharashtra...

Former ICICI Bank CEO Chanda Kochhar and her husband Deepak Kochhar face charges related to alleged quid pro quo in loans extended to the group. Other major defaulters include Siddhi Vinayak Logistics Ltd (₹6,071 crore), Accurate Transformers Ltd (₹4,376 crore), SVOGL Oil Gas and Energy Ltd (₹4,125 crore), VOVL Ltd (₹4,206 crore) and Coastal Projects Ltd (₹4,153 crore).

The Lanco Group, promoted by former Congress MP L Rajagopal, owes ₹3,821 crore to the bank, with total dues across lenders estimated at over ₹30,000 crore. Rajagopal is notorious for using pepper spray inside the Lok Sabha protesting division of Andhra Pradesh in early

2014. Textile firm SEL Manufacturing Company Ltd (₹3,733 crore) and Jay Polychem India Ltd (₹3,700 crore) also feature prominently.

Among other notable defaulters are Ushdev International Ltd (₹3,011 crore), Jogeshwari Breweries Ltd (₹2,482 crore), Metalyst Forgings Ltd (₹2,316 crore), SEW Infrastructure Ltd (₹2,231 crore), Kay Bouvet Engineering Ltd (₹2,193 crore) and Corporate Ispat Alloys Ltd (₹2,127 crore).

Real estate firms Amrapali Group (₹1,753 crore) and Supertech Limited (₹1,653 crore), both facing insolvency and homebuyer fraud cases, are also on the list.

Additional defaulters include Shree Ganesh Jewellery House Ltd, Unijules Life Sciences Ltd, Shripur Gold Refinery Ltd and Gayatri Projects Ltd, among others, each owing over ₹1,000 crore.

In the ₹600-1,000 crore bracket, notable names include Jyoti Structures Ltd, EMC Ltd, Innovative Industries Ltd, Gammon India Ltd and Essel Infraprojects Ltd, promoted by Subhash Chandra. Firms linked to fugitives Mehul Choksi and Nirav Modi, including Gitanjali Exports, also feature. Bankers say a majority of these loans were extended against share pledges and personal guarantees, often with limited recoverable collateral, complicating recovery efforts.

Larijani, Soleimani targeted amid rising...

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has reportedly instructed the military to continue targeting senior Iranian figures.

Larijani, 65, serves as secretary of Iran's Supreme National Security Council and is a long-time political insider. He has previously held positions as nuclear negotiator, culture minister, head of State broadcasting, and parliament speaker for over a decade. Born in Najaf in 1958, he comes from a prominent political family and holds a doctorate in Western philosophy.

He was last seen publicly during Quds Day rallies in Tehran, appearing alongside Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, dismissing Israeli strikes as a sign of weakness. Just a day before the alleged strike, Larijani asserted that Iran would remain "steadfast" against the US and Israel and criticized what he called limited support from Muslim-majority nations during the conflict.

Hours after Israel's announcement, Iranian state-linked media circulated a handwritten note attributed to Larijani commemorating Iranian sailors killed earlier this month. The note, lacking a timestamp, has not been independently verified. Separately, Iranian state media released a statement attributed to Larijani criticizing former US President Donald Trump and disputing claims about the authenticity of anti-US and anti-Israel demonstrations in Iran, further complicating assessments of his status.

The reported strike also targeted Soleimani, who has led the Basij since 2019. The Basij, a volunteer paramilitary force under the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, has been central to internal security, including suppressing protests in recent years. Analysts caution against assuming a decisive impact on Iran's political system. Mohamad Elmasry, a professor at the Doha Institute for Graduate Studies, described the strategy as a "game of whack-a-mole," noting that leadership losses may not translate into systemic collapse, though the psychological and symbolic effects are significant.

The developments come amid escalating hostilities across Iran, with explosions reported in Tehran, Isfahan, Shiraz, and Ahwaz. Iranian health officials report over 1,400 killed and more than 18,000 injured since the conflict began.

India rejects Iran tanker swap reports

"We are in talks with Iran and other countries... It is our intention to work with them to bring those ships back home safely. This is our objective," he said, adding that talks with Iran are also covering humanitarian issues.

Amid continued tensions and disruptions caused by exchanges of drones and missiles between the US-Israel alliance and Iran, the Indian LPG carrier Nanda Devi arrived at Vadinar port in Gujarat's Jamnagar on Tuesday, carrying 46,500 metric tonnes of liquefied petroleum gas for ship-to-ship transfer.

The Government had said on Saturday that two Indian-flagged LPG vessels — Nanda Devi and Shivalik - had safely crossed the Strait of Hormuz. While Nanda Devi anchored on Tuesday, Shivalik reached India on Monday. With both vessels now

back, 22 Indian-flagged ships remain in the Persian Gulf, carrying 611 seafarers, according to official figures released earlier.

Future civil servants advised: Pause, reflect...

"As a future civil servant, you are expected to be a role model throughout," the academy said, adding that their past actions also will be a reflection of their character and personality throughout their career.

"Respect to women is central in Indian ethos. You must be gender sensitive. Maintain punctuality. "Respecting the time of others is very crucial. Do not cause any inconvenience to others in whatsoever manner," the advisory read.

Hundreds feared dead in Kabul hospital airstrike

Afghan Interior Ministry spokesman Abdul Mateen Qanie and Taliban spokesperson Zabihullah Mujahid confirmed figures of up to 408 dead and 265 injured, describing the victims as civilians and patients. Mujahid condemned the attack as "targeting hospitals and civilian sites to perpetrate horrors" and called it "a crime against humanity."

Survivors described scenes of devastation. A 50-year-old patient, Ahmad, said: "The whole place caught fire. It was like doomsday. My friends were burning in the fire, and we could not save them all." Local media and aid groups reported "hundreds of civilians dead and injured," with bodies carried out by Red Crescent volunteers and security forces.

Pakistan rejected the allegations as "false and misleading," insisting the strikes targeted militant infrastructure, including TTP ammunition depots. Information Minister Attaullah Tarar said "visible secondary detonations" confirmed stockpiles, with no hospital or civilian targets hit.

India condemned the strike as reprehensible, especially during Ramadan, and called for restraint, while China urged both sides to de-escalate, return to negotiations, and ensure the safety of regional interests.

The incident escalates clashes that intensified

in late February. Pakistan accuses the Taliban of harbouring TTP militants, a charge Kabul denies. The UN and aid agencies expressed alarm over civilian casualties, urging independent verification and adherence to international humanitarian law.

Supreme Court extends maternity leave to all...

Observing that adoption is part of a woman's reproductive autonomy, the court said maternity benefits cannot be tied to the age of the child. It emphasised that adoptive mothers have the same rights and obligations as biological mothers. "The object of maternity benefit is not associated with the process of childbirth but with the process of motherhood," the bench said, adding that the purpose of maternity protection does not vary based on how a child enters a family.

The court noted that adoptive parents and children undergo similar emotional, psychological and practical adjustments regardless of the child's age. Denying leave based on an "arbitrary age threshold" ignores these realities, particularly in cases involving children with disabilities or single mothers, it said.

"The protection of maternity leave is a basic human right... It embodies an essential component required to promote equality in the workplace and safeguards maternal and child health," the bench observed.

The judgment came on a plea by advocate Hamsaanandini Nanduri, an adoptive mother, who challenged the provision as arbitrary and inadequate compared to the 26 weeks of leave granted to biological mothers.

In its 100-page ruling, the court stressed that children adopted at any age require sustained care and stable parental presence to integrate into a new family environment.

The court also asked the Centre to consider introducing paternity leave as a social security benefit, underscoring the need for broader parental support frameworks.

Emphasising practical realities, the bench said maternity leave is not merely a matter of convenience but a necessary support that enables women to fulfil parental responsibilities while ensuring economic independence.

Suspension of 8 MPs revoked

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Lok Sabha on Tuesday revoked with immediate effect the suspension of eight opposition members who were barred from the House on February 3 for “unruly” behaviour, with Speaker Om Birla stressing that there should be no display of placards, posters, photos or AI-generated images inside the House or in the Parliament complex.

Congress member K Suresh requested the House to consider the revocation of the eight Opposition members, saying whatever had happened in the House was regrettable, and that his party was ready to cooperate in the smooth functioning of the House.

Following the submissions by several Opposition members, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju said there was a need to draw a *Laxman Rekha* for the smooth functioning of the



From left, Congress MPs Prashant Padole, Hibi Eden, and Gurjeet Singh Aujla during the second part of the Budget session of Parliament in New Delhi on Tuesday

House, which both treasury and opposition benches agreed to.

Speaker Birla said there is a need to ensure that no placards, posters, photos or AI-generated images are displayed in the House or inside the Parliament complex.

Birla said that everyone is of the opinion that proceedings in Parliament of the world's largest democracy should be smooth and everyone should cooperate.

Rijiju then moved a

motion to remove the suspension of seven Congress MPs and one CPI-M member, which was adopted by a voice vote. The suspended MPs were Gurjeet Singh Aujla, Hibi Eden, C Kiran Kumar Reddy, Amarinder Singh Raja Warring, Manickam Tagore, Prashant Padole and Dean Kuriakose of the Congress, and S Ventakesan of the CPI(M).

Asked about the revocation of suspension and the call for upholding the dignity

of the House, Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra told reporters, “Dignity should be maintained by both sides.”

The eight MPs were suspended on February 3 for “unruly” behaviour following a resolution passed by the Lok Sabha in the first half of the ongoing Budget session.

They were suspended for the entire duration of the Budget session scheduled to conclude on April 2.

Earlier, after Suresh’s submission, Samajwadi Party member Dharmendra Yadav supported the move, saying his party was ready to cooperate in maintaining the highest standards of Parliament. NCP leader Supriya Sule said efforts should be made by both ruling and opposition members so that the House functions smoothly.

JD(U) leader and Union minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh said the House should function smoothly and both sides should cooperate.

Congress announces first list of 55 candidates for Kerala polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Tuesday announced its first list of 55 candidates for the Kerala Assembly polls, fielding senior party leader Ramesh Chennithala from Haripad seat. The party has also fielded its state unit chief Sunny Joseph from Peravoor seat and Leader of Opposition in state assembly VD Satheesan from Paravur.

According to the Congress’ list, former chief minister Oommen Chandy’s son Chandy Oommen will contest from Puthupally while former Lok Sabha MP Ramya Haridas will be in the fray from the Chirayinkeezhu-SC constituency.

The party has also named former Lok Sabha MP K Muraleedharan, son of former chief minister K Karunakaran, as its candidate from Vattiyoorkavu seat. The names of candidates were decided at a



Ramesh Chennithala

meeting of the Congress’s central election committee headed by party president Mallikarjun Kharge earlier in the day. The Congress is seeking to wrest back power from the LDF alliance, which has been ruling the southern state for the last decade.

The elections to 140-member Kerala Assembly will be held in a single phase on April 9, while the counting of votes is scheduled for May 4.

KC Tyagi quits JD(U), says will decide further course of action soon

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Senior JD(U) leader KC Tyagi on Tuesday said that he has left the party and will decide his further course of action soon. Tyagi was associated with the JD(U) since it came into existence in October 2003 with the merger of the Samata Party and the Janata Dal.

He served the JD(U) in various capacities including

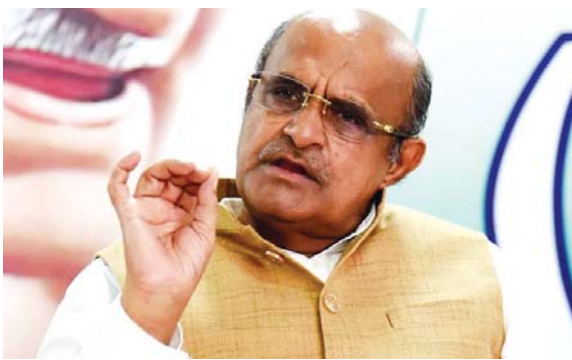
its chief general secretary, chief spokesperson and political adviser. “Yes, I have left the party,” Tyagi said.

In a statement, the former Rajya Sabha member said, “The membership campaign of the party has ended. This time I’ve not renewed the membership of the party.” He, however, asserted that his commitment to the “larger and wider ideological points” concerning the interests of downtrodden, peasants

and agriculturalists including the deprived sections of society “remains as firm as ever”.

“My personal respect for Nitish Kumar who remained my comrade for close to half a century also remains unchanged,” he added. Tyagi said that his “further course of action” will be decided soon in consultation with “all required people”.

“Few of my friends political friends, sympathisers



and activists are organising a meet of like minded persons on March 22, 2026 to discuss the political situation of the country at Mavlankar Hall, Rafi Marg,” he said in the statement.

“We will continue to be inspired by the ideas and ideology of Bharat Ratna Chaudhary Charan Singh ji, Dr Ram Manohar Lohia ji and Bharat Ratna Karpoori Thakur Ji,” the veteran socialist leader added.

India, EU discuss energy security amid escalating West Asia conflict



Union External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, left, exchanges a handshake with EU High Representative for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy Kaja Kallas during a meeting in Brussels, Belgium

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The escalating conflict in West Asia and its ripple effects on global energy security figured prominently in External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar’s high-level talks with his counterparts from the 27 European Union (EU) member States in Brussels.

A day after the talks, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Tuesday that both sides underlined the need for dialogue and diplomacy to resolve the crisis.

Global oil and gas prices have surged after Iran virtually blocked the Strait of Hormuz, a narrow shipping lane between the Persian Gulf and the Gulf of Oman, that handles roughly 20 per cent of global oil and LNG (Liquefied Natural Gas).

The West Asia has been a major source of India’s energy procurement. Jaishankar visited the Belgian capital at the invitation of EU

foreign and security policy chief Kaja Kallas to join a meeting of the Foreign Affairs Council, which comprises the foreign ministers of the bloc.

It was the first high-level visit from India to the Brussels-headquartered EU after the two sides firmed up a landmark Free Trade Agreement (FTA) following summit talks between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the EU leadership in January.

Jaishankar also held separate meetings with European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and his counterparts from EU member states such as Germany and Belgium.

The external affairs minister highlighted the strong momentum following the India-EU Summit in January and called for unlocking the full potential of the FTA, besides deepening defence industrial collaboration and maritime co-operation under the security and defence partnership, the MEA said.

Sonia Gandhi replies to Deve Gowda over Parliament chaos

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress parliamentary party chairperson Sonia Gandhi on Tuesday gave a three-line reply to former prime minister HD Deve Gowda over his concerns about opposition disruptions in Parliament, saying his observations have been noted. She also extended greetings to Deve Gowda on the eve of Ugadi.

Deve Gowda wrote to Sonia Gandhi on Monday, saying

he has been “greatly disturbed by a certain chaos” that has been “unthinkingly” introduced inside Parliament and in its larger premises, “primarily by the Opposition parties”.

“I strongly feel that Congress parliamentarians, led by the Leader of Opposition, have provoked far too many disruptions inside Parliament and in its premises,” the JD(S) Rajya Sabha MP said in the letter, adding that their *dharnas* and blockades outside Parliament were “unprecedented”.

“Parliament, in recent times, has witnessed an excess of slogan-shouting, display of placards and name-calling. There has been an attitude of non-seriousness, which has assaulted my very idea and construct of Parliament and parliamentary democracy,” he added.

Replying to the letter, Sonia Gandhi said, “Dear Shri Devegowda ji, I have just received your letter dated 16th March 2026. I have read it carefully and noted your concerns.”



Recent development has cast shadow future of Chabahar Port’s: Parliamentary panel

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The “recent development” has cast a shadow on the future of Chabahar Port, a vital and strategic port for India, a parliamentary panel on external affairs has said, and welcomed that the Centre “remains engaged” with all concerned parties in order to address the implications of these developments.

The Twelfth Report of the Committee on External Affairs (2025-26) on Demands for Grants (2026-27) of the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), was presented in Parliament on Tuesday. The Committee of External Affairs is headed by Congress MP Shashi Tharoor.

The observation by the panel, assumes significance



as it comes amid the ongoing West Asia conflict and in the backdrop of the recent changes in US sanctions or tariff policies on India’s participation in the Chabahar project.

“The Committee find that for the development of Chabahar Port, an amount of ₹100 crore was allocated at BE (Budget estimate)

ing \$120 million” for the procurement of port equipment, according to the main contract signed in 2024. The committee said it is also aware of the fact that on September 16, 2025, the US State Department, in a press statement, revoked the sanctions exception issued in 2018 under the

“Iran Freedom and Counter Proliferation Act 2012 for Afghanistan’s reconstruction and economic development, effective September 29, 2025. Pursuant to discussions with the US side, the latter issued guidance extending the conditional sanctions waiver until April 26, 2026,” the report says.

The MEA has informed the panel that “no amount has been allocated under the head during 2026-27 as India has already fulfilled its commitment of contributing

Nation Focus



3 lakh girls get HPV vaccine within 15 days of launch

Nearly three lakh 14-year-old girls have been vaccinated within a fortnight of the launch of the HPV vaccination campaign, marking an encouraging start to the critical public health initiative. Health ministry officials said on Tuesday that several States, including Madhya Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, Gujarat, Odisha, and Mizoram, are leading from the front in the nationwide HPV vaccination campaign.

The Human Papillomavirus (HPV) vaccine plays a vital role in preventing cervical cancer, one of the most common cancers affecting women. “The campaign has been strategically rolled out during the academic period, and while examinations are currently underway in many regions, the response has remained strong,” an official said.



Panel seeks cadre review to end CAPF promotion stagnation

Prolonged stagnation at supervisory levels may adversely impact the morale and career progression of Central Armed Police Force (CAPF) personnel, a parliamentary panel noted on Tuesday and recommended “a comprehensive cadre review” of the ranks to examine vacancy position and promotion avenues and timelines. The Committee, chaired by Radha Mohan Das Agrawal, recommended that steps may also be taken to ensure parity in career progression among officials/officers of different CAPFs.

“I extend my greetings to you on the eve of Ugadi,” Gandhi said in her brief reply to Gowda’s two-page letter.

Ugadi is the first day of the year on the Hindu calendar. It is traditionally celebrated by the Kannadigas and Telugu people in the States of Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, in some parts of Tamil Nadu and Kerala.

In his letter to Sonia Gandhi, JD(S) chief Deve Gowda had said his idea of parliamentary democracy has been built on the lessons and guidance

that the founding fathers like Jawaharlal Nehru, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, BR Ambedkar and Moulana Abdul Kalam Azad, among others, have imparted.

“In my long exposure, I have never witnessed Parliament in such chaos and casualness as we have seen recently. Let me tell you, in all my career, even under extreme provocation, I have never entered the Well of the House to protest either in the State Legislature or in Parliament,” he said.

Congress suspends 3 legislators over cross-voting in RS polls

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Allegations of “horse trading” of MLAs erupted as Rajya Sabha elections saw cross-voting in Bihar, Odisha and Haryana, with the Opposition Congress suspending three of its legislators in Odisha and warning some of its MLAs of strict action in Haryana.

The ruling NDA won all five Rajya Sabha seats in Bihar, three of the four in Odisha and one of the two seats that went to polls in Haryana. The NDA, in total, won nine, including one BJP-backed Independent in Odisha, of the 11 seats where elections were held on Monday, while the Congress and BJD got one seat each.

Overall, the ruling NDA alliance bagged 22 of the 37 seats of the Rajya Sabha that are falling vacant on April 2,



which will help increase its tally to its maximum. While nine of BJP’s MPs are retiring next month, the party by itself has won 14 seats.

In the late-night counting for two seats in Haryana that went past midnight, BJP’s Sanjay Bhatia and Karamvir Singh Boudh of the Congress were elected to the Rajya Sabha, amid allegations of violation of vote secrecy by both sides.

EC deploys highest number of observers for West Bengal elections

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Election Commission (EC) has deployed 1,111 observers, with the largest number in West Bengal, across five poll-bound States and ongoing bye-elections, including general, police and expenditure observers. Among these, West Bengal alone accounts for the largest share of general observers (294 out of 557), which is more than 50 per cent of the total general observers deployed nationwide.

Besides, the poll body has stepped up administrative changes in election-bound States, by removing several district police chiefs in both Bengal, Assam and Tamil Nadu including the transfer of 19 senior police officers including two ADGs in Bengal, in another reshuffle on Tuesday with immediate effect. It has also decided to appoint former West Bengal Home Secretary Jagdish Prasad Meena as a poll observer in Tamil Nadu.

According to a notification issued by the EC, the State will be covered by 474 observers including 294 general observers — one for each assembly constituency — a distinction unmatched by any other poll-bound State this election season, 100 financial observers and 84 police observers.

In comparison, other major States fall significantly short of this one-to-one observer-to-constituency ratio. On the other hand, Assam that has 126 seats, has been assigned only 51 general observers, covering roughly 40 per cent of constituencies. Similarly, Kerala, with 140 seats, also has 51 general observers which is just over 36 per cent coverage. Tamil Nadu, despite having 234 constituencies, has 136 general observers — around 58 per cent coverage.

As far as police observers are concerned, West Bengal again records one of the highest figures, with 84 officers deployed to oversee law and order



arrangements during the polls. Though it does not have 100 per cent mark seen in general observers, it remains substantially higher in absolute numbers compared to most other States. The poll body has deployed only 40 Police Observers in Tamil Nadu followed by 35 in Assam

and followed by only 17 in Kerala.

Election officials said the observers will act as the “eyes and ears” of the Commission on the ground, ensuring that polling is conducted in a free, fair, and transparent manner.

All observers have been instructed to reach their assigned constituencies by March 18 and will hold daily grievance hearings with candidates, political parties, and the public. The scale of deployment in West Bengal is being seen as a direct response to past concerns over electoral malpractices and violence.

By assigning a dedicated general observer to each constituency, the Commission is attempting to create a robust monitoring mechanism that leaves little room for irregularities. With such unprecedented observer coverage, West Bengal stands out as the most closely monitored State in the 2026 Assembly elections, reflecting both its political significance and

the Commission’s determination to ensure stringent electoral oversight.

The Commission has appointed 2012-batch IPS officer Pushpa as the Superintendent of Police (SP) of Barasat Police District. Meanwhile, 2013-batch IPS officer Ishani Paul has been appointed as SP of Diamond Harbour Police District, and 2013-batch officer Sachin has been made the SP of Murshidabad Police District.

The Commission has also appointed Jaspreet Singh as the SP of Coochbehar and 2017-batch IPS officer Kumar Sunny Raj as the SP of Hooghly Rural. 1997-batch IPS Officer Dr Rajesh Kumar Singh has been appointed as ADG South Bengal, while K Jayaraman has been appointed as ADG North Bengal.

The Commission has also posted 2003-batch IPS officer Dr Pranav Kumar as Police Commissioner of Asansol-Durgapur and 2005-batch IPS officer Akhilesh Kumar Chaturvedi as

Police Commissioner of Howrah. 2009-batch IPS officer Amit Kumar Singh has been posted as Police Commissioner of Barrackpore, and IPS officer of the same batch, Sunil Kumar Yadav, has been appointed as Police Commissioner of Chandannagar. In Assam, the poll body has removed five district police chiefs.

The SSPs of Majuli, South Salmara, Sadiya, Chirang and Dhemaji have been transferred. The poll body has directed that the officers who have been moved should not be posted in any election-related duty. The Commission has also asked the Chief Secretary of Assam to submit a compliance report by tomorrow.

Along with these transfers, the EC has sought the names of IAS officers from the 2010 to 2021 batches for consideration for deployment as DEOs. The Chief Secretary has been asked to send the list of eligible officers to the Commission for review.

■ States Focus ■



Rajasthan to vaccinate 2.32 crore cattle against FMD

The Rajasthan Government will vaccinate more than two crore cattle heads under the seventh phase of its foot-and-mouth disease (FMD) control programme, officials said on Tuesday. The seventh phase of the statewide campaign, which was launched by Animal Husbandry Minister Joram Kumawat from the Ramdev Gaushala in Bagru near Jaipur, aims to vaccinate 2.32 crore cows and buffaloes across all districts, officials said. Foot-and-mouth (FMD) is a contagious viral disease affecting livestock, including cattle, pigs, sheep, and goats, characterised by fever and blister-like sores on the mouth, tongue and hooves. Kumawat appealed to the livestock owners to ensure vaccination of all cattle heads to protect them from the infectious disease. "This will improve animal health and help increase the income of farmers," he said. According to an official statement, the minister directed the concerned officials and veterinarians to complete the vaccination drive in a time-bound manner to achieve the target of making the state free from the disease by 2030.



Goa pays tribute to Manohar Parrikar on death anniversary

Goa Governor P Ashok Gajapathi Raju, Chief Minister Pramod Sawant and other senior leaders on Tuesday paid tributes to former Defence Minister Manohar Parrikar on his death anniversary. Several leaders gathered at Parrikar's memorial at Miramar Beach, where he was laid to rest in 2019, to offer floral tributes. The governor recalled the key role Parrikar played in enabling the inclusion of women in defence training. He said the late leader had supported the idea of inducting girl cadets in a phased manner once the National Defence Academy (NDA) was opened to women.

LPG carrier Nanda Devi reaches Gujarat amid West Asia crisis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

India's second LPG carrier 'Nanda Devi' arrived safely at Vadinar port in Gujarat on Tuesday, carrying 46,500 metric tonnes of gas after navigating the Strait of Hormuz amid the West Asia conflict, an official said. The first ship, 'Shivalik', reached Mundra Port in Gujarat on Monday.

'Nanda Devi' has docked at Vadinar port in Devbhumi Dwarka district, and preparations were being made to shift the LPG (liquefied petroleum gas) to the daughter ship, Deendayal Port Authority Chairman Sushil Kumar Singh told reporters. "A consignment of 46,500 metric tonnes of LPG has been brought in; this cargo will be transferred to a vessel named BW Birch, which will subsequently proceed to discharge portions of the consignment at the ports of Ennore (Tamil Nadu) and Haldia (West Bengal) along the eastern coast," he said. "The transfer process takes place at a rate of 1,000 tonnes per hour; consequently, the entire operation is expected to take two days to complete," he added. The port authority at Vadinar is tasked with ensur-



Indian-flagged LPG carrier Nanda Devi arriving at Vadinar, Gujarat PTI

ing that these operations are executed with maximum efficiency, as per the directive of the Ministry of Ports, Singh said. "This constitutes a standard operational procedure that we have consistently carried out here at Vadinar. However, the current directive issued by the ministry mandates that incoming LPG vessels be accorded top priority; we must ensure that their transfer and discharge processes are completed as expeditiously as possible," he said.

All relevant operational parameters are to be monitored rigorously, with multiple agencies involved in the process, the official noted.

"We visited the vessel and met with its crew members. The 'daughter vessel' is currently en route; upon its arrival, it will berth alongside

LPG crisis threatens survival of street vendors and restaurants

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The cost of India's most affordable meals is rising sharply, with a nationwide LPG shortage forcing both street vendors and restaurants to increase prices, squeezing daily consumers and threatening small food businesses.

A survey conducted across 309 districts shows that more than half of consumers have seen food prices rise in just one week, pointing to a fast-spreading impact on urban food affordability. The findings reveal that 57 per cent of consumers who ate at restaurants or ordered food recently reported a noticeable increase in prices. In many cases, the hikes were steep, with one in five consumers saying prices had risen by more than 25 per cent.

Street food, often the cheapest option for millions, has not been spared. The survey found that 54 per cent of consumers



noticed price increases at street vendors, mostly in the range of 10 to 25 per cent. The sharp rise is being driven by a shortage of commercial LPG cylinders, a critical fuel for cooking in both small stalls and large kitchens. Vendors and restaurant owners say they are being forced to buy cylinders at inflated rates, sometimes as high as ₹400 per kilogram, or source them through unofficial channels.

To cope with rising costs,

many eateries have started passing the burden directly to customers. Some restaurants have added a temporary "LPG surcharge" of ₹15 or more per bill, while others have quietly raised menu prices.

The impact is visible across cities. Small vendors and roadside stalls, which depend on frequent LPG refills, are among the worst hit. Some have reduced operations or shut down temporarily due to irregular supply. Restaurants

are also adjusting. In several urban centres, kitchens are cutting down menus, reducing working hours, and removing dishes that require longer cooking or deep frying.

For many Indians, especially daily wage earners, students, and office workers, this shift is significant. Street food and low-cost eateries serve as a primary source of daily meals. Even a small increase in price directly affects household budgets.

The crisis is not limited to pricing. It is also changing how food is prepared. Many vendors have started switching to alternatives such as firewood, charcoal, kerosene, and electric stoves to keep their businesses running. However, these options are often less efficient and more expensive in the long run.

The shortage has been linked partly to global energy supply disruptions and tensions in West Asia, which have affected fuel availability and pricing.

Census 2027 to capture all 21 disability types: Athawale

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Minister of State for Social Justice and Empowerment, Ramdas Athawale on Tuesday described the upcoming Census 2027, the first after the enactment of the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (RPwD) Act, 2016, as a historic national opportunity to recognise all 21 categories of disabilities through trained enumeration and vastly improved data collection.

Speaking at the launch of India's first-ever handbook on disability for parliamentarians titled 'Beyond the Visible: A Handbook on



Disability Inclusion for Parliamentarians,' prepared by the National Centre for Promotion of Employment for Disabled People (NCPEDP), the Minister said accurate and disaggregated data will enable the government to design far more targeted and effective

interventions for persons with disabilities across the country.

The event, which also featured a high-level panel discussion on inclusive health coverage and political participation, was graced by Chief Guest Athawale and several distinguished Guests of

Honour including ET Mohammed Basheer, MP and Parliamentary Member of the Central Advisory Board on Disability; Eatala Rajender, MP, Lok Sabha; Dr Fauzia Khan, MP, Rajya Sabha; Dr Guru Prakash Paswan, National Spokesperson, BJP; Neha Joshi, Vice President, BJYM; Anish Gawande, National Spokesperson, NCP (SP).

Arman Ali, Executive Director, NCPEDP, said, "The Handbook is a commitment to ensure that Parliamentarians become active partners in breaking every barrier faced by persons with disabilities. This book will help translate the RPwD Act into real legislative action."

AAP successfully cleared agnipariksha: Kejriwal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Panaji

Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) leader Arvind Kejriwal on Tuesday said his party has successfully cleared the *agnipariksha* (trial by fire) with the court discharging him and 22 others in the excise policy case, and added that it was "not easy" as there were "difficulties at every step".

The former Delhi chief minister also dared Prime Minister Narendra Modi to hold Assembly elections in the national Capital, saying the BJP will not be able to win even 10 seats while the AAP will bag more than 60.

On February 27, a trial court discharged Kejriwal, former deputy CM Manish Sisodia and 21 others in the excise policy case, pulling up the CBI by saying its case was wholly unable to survive judicial scrutiny and stood discredited in its entirety.

The trial court had ruled that the alleged conspiracy was nothing more than a speculative construct resting on conjecture and surmise, devoid of any admissible evidence, and therefore, to compel the accused to face the rigours of a full-fledged criminal trial in the stark



absence of any legally admissible material did not serve the ends of justice. Talking about it, Kejriwal said, "Some people were asking why Kejriwal has been quiet for the last one year."

"There are politicians who are thick-skinned. But I am a common man like you. If someone says that Kejriwal is a dishonest person then I feel bad. I had decided that I will keep quiet till the court gives the verdict," he said.

Attacking the ruling BJP and the Centre, he alleged, "They put behind bars five of our leaders and grabbed power in Delhi. Today, I challenge PM Modi to hold the election now and you will find that the BJP will win not even 10 seats, while the AAP will bag more than 60 seats."

Funds worth ₹500 crore released for Punjab in FY 2025-26: Nadda in RS



Union Minister JP Nadda speaking in the Rajya Sabha during the second part of the Budget session of Parliament in New Delhi on Tuesday PTI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

During the 2025-26 fiscal, funds to the tune of ₹572.66 crore have been released to Punjab, Union Health Minister JP Nadda told the Rajya Sabha on Tuesday.

Nadda said public health is a State subject, hence, the primary responsibility of providing basic healthcare services to all the citizens lies with respective state and UT Governments.

He was responding to a question on the details of supplementary funds approved by the Union Government for Punjab under the National Health Mission (NHM) for the financial year 2025-26.

With the objective of attaining universal access to equitable, affordable and quality health care services, the Union Health Ministry is implementing NHM.

"During the FY 2025-26, funds to the tune of ₹572.66 crore have been released to Punjab," Nadda said.

The funds released under this scheme are used for upgrading existing sub-health centres and primary health centres in rural and urban areas to deliver 12 packages of basic

healthcare services. These primary healthcare services include reproductive and child health services, communicable diseases, Non-Communicable Diseases (NCDs) (screening and management for NCDs such as hypertension, diabetes and 3 common cancers of oral, breast and cervix).

It also includes an expanded package of services for mental health, ENT, ophthalmology, oral health, geriatric and palliative health care and trauma care etc.

Further, the major initiatives taken by the Government to improve maternal and child health services includes Janani Suraksha Yojana, Pradhan Mantri Surakshit Matritva Abhiyan, STOP Diarrhoea campaign, Anemia Mukh Bharat, Rashtriya Bal Swasthya Karyakram, Universal Immunization Programme, Universal Immunization WIN (U-WIN), Mission Indradhanush, the Union minister said.

The monitoring and evaluation of the progress of all states including Punjab is assessed, through review meetings, video conferences and field visits of senior officials, Nadda said.

Trouble makers will have to pay a heavy price: LG Sinha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

A day after the 'Spring festival' at the Tulip garden in Srinagar got off to a colourful start, the Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha Tuesday sent out a stern warning to trouble makers that any individual or group that seeks to threaten the peace, law and order, or the safety of innocent civilians in Jammu Kashmir will have to pay a very heavy price.

Addressing the Passing Out Parade of the Constables at the STC Talwara, in Reasi, LG Sinha said any attempt to disrupt public peace, undermine commercial activity, or incite violence shall be met with the full force of the law, and J&K Police is unequivocal in its commitment to safeguard order and stability, and shall pursue all necessary measures against such acts, without exception.

Congratulating the bravehearts of J&K Police on their successful completion of the tough training, the Lieutenant Governor called upon them to focus on protecting Jammu and Kashmir's achievements. "J&K Police has been



instrumental in forging a terror-free, crime-free UT where no insecurity overshadows civilian lives. The force has played a pivotal role in achieving remarkable milestones in good governance, innovation, social unity, and building a just society. We must uproot separatist elements that are trying to divide people and derail development. Let this serve as their stern warning," the Lieutenant Governor said.

"With all resources and resolve, J&K Police pursue zero tolerance to terrorism. We are working on a multi-pronged strategy with all the stakeholder agencies and soon J&K will be terror-free,"

the Lieutenant Governor said. A total of 430 Trainee Constables passed out after their basic training and all trainees were administered the Oath. On the occasion, the Lieutenant Governor awarded trophies to the trainee constables who excelled during their training: Johnny Victor (All-Round Best), Vishal Bharat (Second All-Round Best), Yogesh Sharma (Third All-Round Best), Pankaj Raina (Indoor Best), Touseef Ahmed Lone (Outdoor Best), Tahir Rashid Dar (Best Marksman), Tasleem Kosar (Parade Commander) and Sushant Sharma (Parade 2nd-in-Command).

The DGP, Nalin Prabhat and other senior officials were present on the occasion.

Wangchuk calls revocation of NSA detention a win-win

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Activist Sonam Wangchuk on Tuesday termed the revocation of his detention under the National Security Act (NSA) a win-win development and said the Centre has extended its hand to build trust for a meaningful dialogue with the people of Ladakh.

Making these assertions in his first public remarks here after being released from jail last Saturday, he also said the protests in Ladakh have been aimed at initiating a constructive dialogue process.

Addressing a press conference here along with his wife and HIAL co-founder Gitanjali J Angmo, Wangchuk said,

"We were sure of a victory in the court, but a win was not enough. I wanted a win-win," he said.

He described the government's move as an "extending of hand to build trust and to facilitate meaningful, constructive dialogue".

"They have offered a constructive, meaningful dialogue. This is what we have wanted, and we had to struggle so much, walk to Delhi, sit on 'anshan' (fast). All movements in Ladakh are for starting the dialogue process," he said.

"Usually, you see people picking up guns and the Government appealing for dialogue. Here, people are urging the Government to start a dialogue," he said.



Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk with spouse Gitanjali J Angmo during a press conference in New Delhi on Tuesday PTI

Asked about his next step, Wangchuk said he would travel to Ladakh and consult with leaders of the Leh Apex

Body (LAB) and the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KAD), which have been spearheading the agitation over the past

five years for statehood and extension of the Sixth Schedule to Ladakh.

On whether he would return to agitation, he said, "I have always said I don't want to sit on hunger strike; I am forced to do it. Now that the Government is extending its hand, we hope a good example is set."

Wangchuk, 59, was detained on September 26 last year under the stringent NSA, two days after violent protests during the agitation left four people dead. He was released from Jodhpur Central Jail on Saturday after the Union Government revoked his detention with immediate effect.

The LAB and KDA have

remained engaged in talks with the Ministry of Home Affairs over their key demands of statehood and Sixth Schedule inclusion, issues that have simmered since the region was carved out of Jammu and Kashmir as a Union Territory in 2019.

The outfits held rallies and shutdown on Monday to demand the next round of talks as promised during the high-powered committee meeting. The last meeting of the high-powered committee chaired by Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai took place on February 4, where both bodies demanded the release of Wangchuk and 70 other detainees.

Yoga 365 launched to make yoga integral part of lives

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With the countdown to International Day of Yoga (IDY) 2026 having already begun, the Union Ayush Ministry has launched Yoga 365, a nationwide campaign aimed at moving beyond a single-day celebration to encourage sustained engagement and habit throughout the year.

The initiative to make yoga an integral part of citizens' daily lives was formally unveiled during the launch of Yoga Mahotsav-2026, which marked the 100-day countdown to the 2026 edition of IDY on March 13.



"The Ministry of Ayush aims to take the spirit of that one-day celebration further —transforming yoga into a daily practice. This vision has taken shape as Yoga 365, a nationwide campaign to make yoga an integral part of citizens' daily lives," Union Ayush Minister Prataprao Jadhav said.

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Will accept court's decision in Bhojshala-Kamal Maula Mosque dispute: RSS leader



A senior RSS leader on Tuesday said that all facts related to the Bhojshala-Kamal Maula Mosque controversy have been presented before the Madhya Pradesh High Court, and the court's decision will be accepted. "We have no separate viewpoint in this matter," said Prakash Shastri, chief of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh's Malwa province, speaking to reporters here. As the matter was before the High Court, it would be inappropriate to comment on it, he said, adding, "All facts have been presented before the court. Whatever the court's decision may be, we will accept it." The Sangh leader was responding to the question whether the historical dispute was moving towards resolution in the light of the Archaeological Survey of India's (ASI) survey report. The ASI's more than 2,000-page report indicated that a massive structure dating back to the reign of the Parmar kings existed within the Bhojshala complex in Dhar district. Repurposed parts of the ancient structures were used in the later construction of the colonnades of the mosque, it said. The Hindus consider Bhojshala a temple dedicated to Goddess Saraswati, while the Muslim community claims that the structure, believed to date back to the 11th century, is a mosque.

Bail granted to man accused of circulating morphed video of PM on social media



Delhi court on Tuesday granted bail to a man accused of circulating a morphed video of Prime Minister Narendra Modi on social media, saying he satisfied the triple test for bail comprising flight risk, tampering of evidence and influencing witnesses. Additional Sessions Judge Saurabh Partap Singh Laler was hearing the bail plea of the accused against whom the special cell of the Delhi Police had registered an FIR. The accused, Vinod Tiwari, had been in jail since March 14. According to the prosecution, the present FIR was registered on the complaint of one Mohammed Abdullah, alleging that a Facebook account in the name of Vinod Tiwari was circulating an AI-generated and morphed video depicting the prime minister "making derogatory remarks, thereby having the potential to disturb public order and harmony".

Will examine correctness of 1978 verdict on definition of 'industry': SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A nine-judge Constitution bench of the Supreme Court on Tuesday said it will examine the legal correctness of the 1978 judgment of a seven-judge bench giving an expansive interpretation of the term "industry" to govern labour relations. On February 21, 1978, a seven-judge bench delivered a verdict on the definition of the term "industry" while deciding the plea of Bangalore Water Supply and Sewerage Board and expanded the definition which brought millions of employees in hospitals, educational institutions, clubs and Government welfare departments under the protection of the Industrial Disputes (ID) Act, 1947. On Tuesday, the nine-judge bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant commenced the hearing on a batch of peti-

tions to determine the legal correctness of the decades-old definition of "industry". The CJJ made it clear that the bench would not deal with the definition of term 'industry' referred to in the 1982 legislation as that law "never came into force" and hence, cannot be relied upon. He also said that the bench will not deal with the term as defined in the Industrial Relations Code, 2020, which became operative in 2025, as it may be challenged in court. "That does not mean we are helpless. There is a reference before us. We are directly examining the question whether the interpretation of the original provision itself in the Bangalore (case) was correct or not," the CJJ said. "If that interpretation was wrong, if that provision has been completely misconstrued by giving such a wide meaning, then we will correct our mistake," said the bench which also com-



Bring law recognising paternity leave: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday urged the Centre to come up with a law recognising paternity leave as a social security benefit, observing that parenthood is not a solitary function and while the mother is central to a child's development, it would be unjust to overlook the role of the father. The apex court's observations came while striking down a law under which a woman was eligible for maternity leave if she legally adopts a child below the age of three months. The court held that an adoptive mother should be entitled to maternity leave of 12 weeks, irrespective of the age of the adopted child. A bench of Justices J B Pardiwala and R Mahadevan also emphasised that a provision of paternity leave helps in dismantling gendered roles, encourages fathers to take an active role in child care, fosters a balanced understanding of parenting, and promotes gender equality within family and workplace.

While the role of a mother is undeniably central to a child's emotional, physical, and psychological development, it would be incomplete and unjust to overlook the equally significant role of a father, the bench said. The top court said parenthood is not a solitary function performed by one parent but rather a shared responsibility in which each parent contributes to the child's holistic development. It said that although the father is present at the periphery of infancy, he is not present in the intimate and irreplaceable way that society has always presumed the mother must be. "In light of the aforesaid discussion on the need of paternity leave, we urge the Union to come up with a provision recognising paternity leave as a social security benefit. "We emphasise that the duration of such leave must be determined in a manner that is responsive to the needs of both the parent and the child," the bench said. Observing that early months and years of a child's



life constitute a formative period during which emotional bonds, attachment and a sense of security begin to take shape, the top court said that during this stage, the presence of a father contributes significantly to the child's emotional and psychological well-being. What a father offers to a child in those nascent days cannot be scheduled for a convenient time or compensated for later, it said.

"In the aforesaid context, the absence of a father is rationalised by the hope of making up for lost time through devoted weekends. For the child, who needed to hear the voice and feel the warmth of a father in those early moments, the absence is not merely a matter of memory. "It affects the foundation upon which the child begins to build emotional security and attachment. The absence of a father during the forma-

tive years of a child's life, particularly due to employment constraints, deprives both the child and the parent of the opportunity to form these early bonds," the bench said. The top court said a father who remains physically near yet is compelled by professional obligations to remain disengaged from early caregiving roles cannot truly participate in the formative experiences of a child's infancy.

The court said the absence of paternity reinforces gendered roles in parenting, and another consequence is that even where a father is willing and desirous of contributing, he is left without a meaningful opportunity to do so. "When fathers are afforded the opportunity to take leave following the arrival of the child, they are able to support the mothers and share family responsibilities. This support extends to participating in the upbringing and caregiving of the child, assisting with household responsibilities, and remaining emotionally present during this demanding phase. "In such circumstances referred to above, a provision for paternity leave serves an important purpose by enabling fathers to participate meaningfully in the early stages of a child's life and development. "It helps in dismantling gendered roles, encourages fathers to take an active role in child care, fosters a balanced understanding of parenting, and promotes gender equality within family and workplace," the bench said.

Why details of bank accounts of deceased persons can't be disclosed to heirs: SC to Centre

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



The Supreme Court on Tuesday asked the Centre and the Reserve Bank of India why details of the bank accounts of deceased persons could not be disclosed to heirs, and said the Government must come up with a policy on the issue. A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta was hearing a PIL filed by journalist Sucheta Dalal, seeking a direction to set up a mechanism to inform the legal heirs of deceased depositors about the unclaimed deposits lying dormant in bank accounts. "Suppose a man has got 10 different accounts in different countries, he dies intestate, how do his heirs get the details? He may not have done the KYC..." "It's not a question of policy; we are not saying that the transfer is illegal. What we are saying is, what is wrong if we give the information to the legal heirs? You will have to come out with some policy," the bench remarked. During the hearing, advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for Dalal, submitted that the petitioner has sought directions for making the details of such unclaimed accounts public. He said the RBI had also recommended the need to have a "Centralised and Searchable Database" so that people can trace the accounts of their deceased parents. Additional Solicitor General N Venkataraman, appearing for the Centre, said if a genuine heir comes forward, the amount is refunded to them from the Depositor Education and Awareness

Fund. The Depositor Education and Awareness Fund, established by the RBI in 2014, holds unclaimed deposits from commercial and co-operative banks. The top court asked the Centre and the RBI to file fresh affidavits in the matter and posted the matter for hearing on May 5. The apex court had earlier asked the Finance Ministry to file its response to the PIL seeking directions to create a centralised database providing information about bank accounts, insurance, deposits and post office funds lying in accounts held by those who are no longer alive. The plea has also sought a direction to establish a procedure that eliminates unnecessary litigation while dealing with claims of legal heirs qua bank deposits, insurance, post office funds, etc. The plea said that the Depositors' Education and Awareness Fund had Rs 39,264.25 crore at the end of March 2021, up from Rs 33,114 crore on 31 March 2020 and a sharp rise from Rs 18,381 crore at the end of March 2019. The petition stated there is an urgent need to develop a centralised online database under the control of RBI that will provide information about the deceased account holder, including such details as the name, address and last date of transaction by the deceased account holder.

'No demolition without notice': MCD assures Delhi HC on Uttam Nagar residents' plea

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



The Municipal Corporation of Delhi on Tuesday told the Delhi High Court that it will not demolish any unauthorised construction in houses belonging to certain individuals allegedly involved in a clash in Uttam Nagar on the day of Holi that left a 26-year-old man dead without issuing prior notice to them. The civic body made the statement before Justice Amit Bansal on petitions filed by Jarina, mother of Imran, one of the accused, and Shahnaz, whose children were interrogated by police, apprehending demolition of their residential premises. In view of the stand of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), Justice Bansal closed the proceedings on the petitions. "Senior advocate Sanjay Poddar said

the MCD shall not take action against unauthorised constructions without issuing notice to the petitioners. He also submitted that any action shall be in accordance with the Supreme Court judgement (on demolitions)," the court said. The petitioners' counsel said they apprehended that the MCD would demolish their houses without following the due process of law.

Senior MCD counsel Poddar said his statement was only for the residential premises in question in the case. On March 11, the court had protected the petitioners' residential premises from demolition action for a week and asked them to file a fresh plea about their grievance. Several people, including a minor, have been apprehended in connection with the death of the 26-year-old man in a clash between two neighbouring families with long-standing disputes during Holi celebrations in Uttam Nagar on March 4. On March 8, the MCD razed a part of the house belonging to the family of the accused, saying it was built on a drain. In their earlier petitions, the petitioners sought directions to protect their residential premises at JJ Colony in Uttam Nagar from "arbitrary and illegal" demolitions by the MCD.

HC directs removal of content linking Union Minister Hardeep Puri's daughter to Jeffrey Epstein

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Himayani Puri

The Delhi High Court on Tuesday directed removal of social media content linking Union Minister Hardeep Singh Puri's daughter to convicted American sex offender Jeffrey Epstein within 24 hours. Justice Mini Pushkarna also restrained several users from publishing, circulating or disseminating such content on social media platforms in any manner. The judge, who was hearing a lawsuit by Himayani Puri, clarified that if the social media users did not remove the posts, the platforms shall take down or block access to such content. The court observed that Himayani Puri has a prima facie case in her favour and she will suffer irreparable

injury if interim relief was not granted. "Consequently, till the next date of hearing, the following directions are issued," the court said, while listing the case for further hearing in August. Senior advocate Mahesh Jethmalani, appearing for the plaintiff, said she has a "global reputation" to

protect as a finance professional and that the allegations against her were "completely false, reckless and malicious." In her lawsuit seeking Rs 10 crore as damages and an order to restrain several entities from disseminating defamatory content, Himayani Puri said there

was a "coordinated and malicious online campaign" to link her to Epstein and his crimes. She also sought an unconditional apology and retraction from the defendant entities. "Commencing on or around 22.02.2026, a series of false, misleading and defamatory posts, articles, videos and digital material were published, disseminated and amplified across social media and intermediary platforms including inter alia X, YouTube, Instagram, Facebook, LinkedIn, digital news portals and other web-based publications," the plea said. Himayani Puri asserted that she is an accomplished finance and investment professional, who is being targeted solely because she is the Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister's daughter.



principal Act?" it said. At the heart of the dispute is the 1978 ruling delivered by Justice V R Krishna Iyer as it expanded the definition of the term 'industry' and established the "Triple Test" to define it. According to the ID Act, the term 'industry' means any business, trade, undertaking,

manufacture or calling of employers and includes any calling, service, employment, handicraft, or industrial occupation or avocation of workmen. The 1978 verdict expanded the definition and provided the triple test and said that if there was "systematic activity" undertaken by an organ-

isation and there is cooperation between employer and employees in carrying out that activity and production of goods and services then the entity can be termed as 'industry' and workmen will be entitled to protection under the ID Act. This wide interpretation brought hospitals, educational institutions and even charitable organisations under the ambit of labour laws. Commencing the arguments, Attorney General R Venkataramani dealt with the issue of whether the "over-inclusive" definition has led to a "glut of litigation" and whether it unfairly categorises sovereign and welfare functions of the State as "industrial". The top law officer said that while the Triple Test is "logically correct" in a vacuum, its "indiscriminate application" has led to the over-inclusion of activities that do not resemble trade or business.

He argued that modern constitutional states perform welfare activities that, while not strictly "sovereign", like policing or defence, should perhaps not be treated as "industries". Justice Nagarathna said that the 1978 judgment was a product of the 1970s socialist era. "We are now in 2026. We have had many years of LPG (Liberalisation, Privatisation and Globalisation)," Justice Nagarathna said. She questioned whether the scope of "industry" should remain expansive or if a balance must be struck, given that many functions previously reserved for the State are now handled by the private sector. Justice Datta raised a procedural question regarding the validity of the reference itself. He questioned how a five-judge bench in the Jai Bir Singh case in 2005 could question the authoritative

judgment of 1978 of the seven-judge bench in the Bangalore Water Supply case. The hearing will continue on Wednesday. The 1978 verdict had come following a dispute that originated when several employees of the Bangalore Water Supply and Sewerage Board were penalised for alleged misconduct. The employees challenged the punishment before the Labour Court under the ID Act, claiming that the disciplinary action violated principles of natural justice. The Board raised a preliminary objection, arguing that it was a statutory body performing essential civic functions such as providing water supply and sewerage facilities and, therefore, did not qualify as an "industry" within the meaning of the Act. The labour court rejected the objection, a decision that was subsequently upheld by the Karnataka High Court.



Editor's
TAKE

The dangerous endgame of
the Iran-US-Israel war

President Trump insists that US and Israeli strikes have crippled Iran's military capability, yet Tehran's response suggests that the war is far from settled

It has been more than two weeks since the US attacked Iran with missiles and stealth bombers, hoping to end the war within days. But, given the way the war is progressing, US calculations have gone haywire. While Iran has borne the brunt of missile attacks – its supreme leader killed, its strategic targets hit, oil installations struck, and even the civilian population affected – yet it refuses to cave in or implode. On the contrary, it is showing resilience that no one had imagined. It has struck US bases in the Gulf, attacked Israel by penetrating the Iron Dome, and paralysed the USS Abraham Lincoln. Its missiles are smartly dodging interceptors and hitting targets at will. Its swarm fleet of drones is creating havoc, and this too after almost five decades of sanctions.

Meanwhile, the US looks isolated in the war, as no country—not even its allies in Europe, such as the UK, France, Germany, and Spain – is willing to toe its line. To make matters worse, Iran has choked the Strait of Hormuz, through which almost 25 per cent of world oil passes in commercial carriers. The regional war has escalated into a global crisis, as countries are running out of gas and crude oil with no end in sight.

So, two weeks on, the million barrel question is: who is actually winning? The answer, however, is not straight forward. In war, the first casualty is truth, as both sides claim victory and attempt to hold the moral high ground. From Washington's perspective, its campaign has been decisive and crippled Iran. The United States and Israel have launched extensive airstrikes against Iranian military infrastructure, including a major assault on Kharg Island-Iran's crucial energy hub in the Persian Gulf.

According to American officials, more than 90 military targets were destroyed in a single operation, severely weakening Iran's naval and missile capabilities. For President Donald Trump, this constitutes a strategic victory. His administration argues that Iran's command networks, air defences, and key bases have been decimated in record time. Tehran's strategy has shifted from direct confrontation to strategic denial – ensuring that even if it cannot win militarily, its adversaries cannot claim a stable victory either. By threatening shipping and restricting passage for adversarial vessels, Iran has managed to transform a regional war into a global economic crisis. Oil prices have surged above \$100 per barrel, financial markets have turned volatile, and governments across Europe and Asia are scrambling to secure energy supplies. This asymmetry explains the paradox of the current conflict. Militarily, the United States and Israel may have the upper hand. Strategically, however, Iran still holds a powerful card: escalation. The primary objective of the US assault was to annihilate the top leadership and effect a regime change, installing a puppet regime to gain total control of the Persian Gulf. This has not happened, and Iran has shown no inclination to surrender or negotiate, whereas the US and Israel are facing public wrath for having started a war they may not decisively win. Post-World War, the US has not won a war that can be called complete. With both sides digging their heels in, the chances are that the war may be prolonged, as the world pays the price for no fault of its own.

Speaker in the storm: The failed motion

In a Parliament often marked by acrimony, the episode revived an enduring question at the heart of Indian democracy: how to preserve the neutrality and authority of the Speaker while maintaining trust between the Government and the Opposition



KALYANI SHANKAR

The role of the Lok Sabha Speaker in promoting parliamentary stability and independence is incredibly important and deserves recognition. On March 11, 2026, the Opposition's impeachment motion against Speaker Om Birla was defeated by a voice vote, nearly four decades after the last attempt. With 119 MPs signing the notice, the Opposition highlighted the perceived bias in the Speaker's conduct. Removing a Speaker requires at least 272 votes in the 543-member House, and historically, no Speaker has ever been removed. The Speaker is back in his chair.

The repeated challenges to the Speaker underscore political tensions in the legislature, raising questions about the balance of power and mutual respect among legislators. Thus, the Speaker's role is essential to both legislative procedures and the fostering of trust in parliamentary democracy.

Following the unsuccessful impeachment motion, Speaker Birla reiterated his impartiality, asserting that the rules apply equally to all members, including the Prime Minister. He addressed the House to refute allegations of bias. He clarified that there is no mechanism to mute the Speaker's microphone. He emphasised, "This House is not a fair or a festival. We must follow the rules, and no one has the right to speak outside them, regardless of their position."

Union Home Minister Amit Shah criticised the Opposition for its unruly conduct in Parliament, highlighting Rahul Gandhi's low attendance-51 per cent in the 17th Lok Sabha and 52 per cent in the 16th Lok Sabha, compared to averages of 66 per cent and 80 per cent, respectively. The Opposition protested by chanting "Maafi maango," demanding an apology from the Home Minister.

The impeachment motion underscored the ruling party's substantial majority and reinforced the importance of parliamentary procedures. It highlighted the respect that the House warrants for its legislative processes.

Jagadambika Pal, a member of the BJP panel who presided over the session, called upon the Opposition to resume their seats to facilitate voting. Nevertheless, amid ongoing protests, he chose to conduct a voice vote in the House, which led to the resolution's rejection. The House was subsequently adjourned for the day.

Impeachment motions are infrequent occurrences in the history of India's parliamentary system. The attempt to remove Speaker Birla marks the fourth such effort, underscoring the



UNION HOME MINISTER AMIT SHAH CRITICISED THE LEADER OF THE OPPOSITION, RAHUL GANDHI, STATING THAT HE TRAVELS FOR PARTY PURPOSES AND PUBLICITY RATHER THAN ATTENDING PARLIAMENTARY SESSIONS

The writer is a popular columnist

dailypioneer

@kalyanishankar

The Pioneer

inherent challenges of this vital office. The Speaker's position is safeguarded by the House itself rather than the President, and removal can occur only by a majority vote. This underlines the office's independence and its critical role in maintaining parliamentary stability. The previous efforts included a 1954 motion against the first Speaker, GV Mavalankar, and the recent motion against Birla. These incidents highlight ongoing concerns regarding bias and parliamentary conduct.

Since independence, there have been three unsuccessful attempts to remove a Speaker of the Lok Sabha. The first was in 1954 against GV Mavalankar, the first Speaker. The motion was debated on December 18, with Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru and Leader of the Opposition AK Gopalan participating. MPs accused Mavalankar of disallowing relevant questions and mishandling adjournment notices.

In 1966, MPs accused Sardar Hukum Singh of obstructing inquiries that could embarrass the government and failing to submit privilege notices. The motion did not advance, as fewer than 50 MPs supported it.

CPI(M) MP Somnath Chatterjee proposed a resolution against Speaker Balram Jakhar. Key participants included Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi and P Chidambaram. The House voted against the motion. In the Rajya Sabha, attempts to remove Vice President and Chairman Jagdeep Dhankhar in 2024 have failed. Similarly, the 2020 notices to remove Deputy Chairman Harivansh Narayan Singh did not spark a debate.

The 'effective majority' requirement—defined as a majority of all sitting House members—establishes the threshold for removing a Speaker, ensuring that a signif-

icant consensus is necessary.

During the impeachment debate, Opposition leaders raised concerns about a vacant Deputy Speaker position, faulty microphones, limited speaking rights for Opposition members, and mass suspensions. These issues focus on the challenges facing parliamentary institutions and the Speaker's office.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah criticised the Leader of the Opposition, Rahul Gandhi, stating that he travels for party purposes and publicity rather than attending parliamentary sessions. "He skipped the President's speech, the Budget, and discussions on Article 370. During key parliamentary sessions, he travels abroad and claims he is not allowed to speak," Shah stated.

"According to the established history of this House, its proceedings are conducted based on mutual trust. The Speaker serves as a neutral custodian, representing both the ruling party and the Opposition. It was unfortunate for parliamentary politics that a resolution for the removal of the Speaker has been introduced," he added.

The Speaker's authority underscores the importance of impartiality and the challenges posed during contentious moments, such as impeachment debates, helping the audience grasp the office's significance to parliamentary stability. Modi, at the end of the impeachment debate, commended Om Birla for conducting Lok Sabha proceedings with "dedication, patience and impartiality". Now that the House has defeated the impeachment motion,

Even if the Lok Sabha is dissolved, Speaker Om Birla remains in office until the new House meets and elects a new Speaker.

PIC TALK

People visit the Indira Gandhi Memorial Tulip Garden after it opened to visitors in Srinagar.

PHOTO: PTI

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OIL BONDS INFLUENCE INDIA'S FUEL PRICE DEBATE

"Oil bonds" in India refer to special securities issued by the government to Oil Marketing Companies (OMCs) to compensate them for selling fuel below market prices, instead of providing direct cash subsidies. The central government has stated that its inability to significantly reduce taxes on petrol and diesel is partly due to the financial strain of servicing these bonds.

Opposition parties and critics argue that the revenue collected from fuel excise duties far exceeds the expenditure on servicing these bonds. In essence, oil bonds represent deferred liabilities that continue to influence fiscal decisions and have become a point of political debate over high fuel prices.

In fact, oil bonds acted as supportive buffers, enabling oil

companies to avoid sharp increases in fuel prices. The government has reported that repayments, including interest, will continue until 2026, with the total liability expected to reach around ₹2.6 lakh crore. These long-term instruments, typically spanning 15-20 years, are treated as "below the line" items in the Union Budget, thereby not impacting the fiscal deficit immediately but increasing overall public debt.

Such measures serve as economic shock absorbers, protecting consumers from sudden price spikes. They reflect policy decisions taken in the broader public interest, irrespective of the ruling dispensation.

CKS RAMANI | CHENNAI

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Svabhava: The nature that shapes who we are

AJIT KUMAR BISHNOI

2ND OPINION

What do we normally remember about someone? It is mostly how he behaved towards us — kindly, warmly, angrily, etc. Looks, etc, become a faint memory. How he made us feel is what one remembers most. Traits of nature stand out, and we decide to deal with such a person accordingly.

For example, if someone was friendly, we are likely to continue our relationship. Conversely, if he was an egoist, one will think twice before wanting to meet him again. We all have peculiarities, and others are quick to notice them. We may not be so aware of them ourselves.

What is 'svabhava' (nature) made of? Just as material nature consists of the three 'gunas' (modes), personal nature similarly has three modes. Every one of us has

a combination of goodness, passion and darkness in our nature. Whichever mode is in ascendancy at any time, we are likely to act accordingly. For example, if a person is in a good mode, he will act mostly nicely with others.

How do we get this personal nature? It is determined by the Divine Authority on the basis of our past 'karmas' (acts). As whatever is destined must manifest, nature also makes its presence felt. Since it will have some portion of darkness as well, we will have many flaws in our nature. People carry deep desires for lust, greed, anger, hate, etc.

The predominance of these defines a person. Surely, we are classified accordingly. A 'kshatriya' (warrior) is suited to defend a country, and a 'brahmin' is best suited for teaching and preaching. The soul in itself is pure, but nature is what defines him. This nature will always remain with the soul wherever he goes or whatever species he is born into.

Now the main question is about its improvement. To begin with, let me clarify that nature is very difficult to change, and all changes can only be slow. Until then, a person will behave according to his nature; a lustful person will act in a lustful manner. Attempts to act differently will most likely fail (The Bhagavad Gita 3.33). Are we, then, doomed? No, because God has not made us in that fashion. But only a very determined person

can effect changes in one's nature, especially because it requires taking help from God (7.14), this being part of fate.

Faith and nature are interlinked. Lord Krishna has made it quite clear: "Faith of all is according to one's nature only. Whatever faith he has, he is that only." (17.3) So the solution is clear.

One has to develop faith in God. And for that, one must begin practising spiritual disciplines such as chanting, meditation, etc., to establish a connection with God.

Then God comes into action and begins to guide and help. Our habits will begin to change for the better. Simultaneously, one must begin to associate with things rooted in goodness, such as consuming food in goodness. This, together with God's help, will change one's nature. Ultimately, our nature shapes our actions, relationships and destiny. While svabhava is difficult to change, it is not immutable. Through faith in God, sincere spiritual practice, and association with goodness, gradual transformation becomes possible. With divine guidance, even deeply ingrained tendencies can evolve towards purity, compassion and higher consciousness.

The writer is a spiritual teacher

Temporary fix for oil crisis

European Union foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas has reportedly discussed with United Nations Secretary-General António Guterres a proposal to facilitate oil and gas transport through the Strait of Hormuz by replicating a mechanism similar to the wartime Black Sea grain export deal. While such an arrangement may offer limited relief, it is unlikely to fully resolve the ongoing global energy crisis.

The Strait of Hormuz remains a far more critical choke point, handling nearly 20 per cent of global liquid petroleum consumption and over 15 million barrels of oil per day.

Any safe corridor established under such a framework would inevitably fall short of matching the capacity of normal tanker traffic.

At best, a Black Sea-type initiative could serve as a temporary crisis mitigation measure to prevent a complete disruption of global energy supplies. However, it cannot replace the substantial share of world seaborne oil trade that passes through the Strait of Hormuz.

A durable solution must therefore address broader geopolitical tensions rather than rely solely on interim logistical arrangements.

RANGANATHAN SIVAKUMAR | CHENNAI

Protests weaken election credibility

Apropos, "Midnight transfers by ECI in West Bengal trigger protests," March 17. Once election schedules are announced, the administrative machinery of a state formally comes under the supervision of the Election Commission of India. This arrangement is neither arbitrary nor political; it is a well-established constitutional mechanism designed to ensure free, fair, and impartial elections. The transfer and posting of officials during this period is a routine exercise intended to prevent bias, undue influence, or misuse of state resources. Such measures are essential to maintaining the integrity of the electoral process.

Against this backdrop, the street protests led by Mamata Banerjee raise pertinent concerns. When a lawful and time-tested procedure is in operation, public dissent from a sitting Chief Minister appears less about principle and more about political optics. Such actions risk undermining public confidence in democratic institutions while promoting a narrative of grievance. While political mobilisation is intrinsic to democracy, protesting established procedural norms may blur the distinction between governance and campaigning, thereby weakening institutional credibility.

N SADHASIVA REDDY | BENGALURU

Academic freedom requires responsibility

The Supreme Court's decision to close criminal proceedings against Ashoka University professor Ali Khan Mahmudabad offers an important moment to reflect on the balance between free expression and legal restraint in a democratic society. While social media posts may sometimes be misinterpreted or provoke strong reactions, the application of stringent criminal provisions should remain a measure of last resort.

Academic voices, even when critical or controversial, play a vital role in enriching public discourse. Universities must remain spaces for inquiry, debate, and intellectual independence. Subjecting scholars to criminal prosecution for expressing opinions risks creating a chilling effect that discourages open dialogue. At the same time, responsible expression is equally important, particularly on sensitive matters involving national institutions such as the armed forces. Public commentary must remain measured and mindful of broader societal implications.

The Supreme Court's balanced approach, closing the case while advising prudence, upholds both constitutional freedoms and social responsibility. Such equilibrium is essential for sustaining democratic values.

SANJAY CHOPRA | MOHALI

BJP’s Punjab Gambit: Redrawing the State’s political map

Punjab has long eluded the Bharatiya Janata Party. Yet, with the 2027 Assembly elections approaching, the party’s central leadership — led by Amit Shah — appears determined to change that equation by expanding its social base, rebuilding bridges with Sikh voters and farmers, and positioning itself as a long-term contender in the state

FIRST
Column



MONIKA
MALIK

Punjab has rarely been comfortable political territory for the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). Yet, as the state moves towards the 2027 Assembly elections, the party’s central leadership appears determined to rewrite that political equation. The strategy emerging from Amit Shah’s political messaging in Moga suggests a calculated attempt to reposition the BJP in a state where it has historically remained peripheral.

The significance lies not in the speech itself but in the political architecture behind it. The signals were unmistakable - the BJP’s Punjab campaign will be centrally directed, its messaging carefully crafted around Sikh sensitivities, and its social outreach widened far beyond the party’s traditional urban Hindu base.

This is less a conventional election campaign and more a long-term experiment to construct a new political constituency in Punjab.

One of the clearest messages from Shah’s intervention is that the BJP will not leave the Punjab battle solely to its state leadership. The campaign is likely to be driven by the national leadership, reflecting the party’s belief that Punjab requires a carefully controlled strategy rather than a routine state-level contest.

For the BJP, Punjab is politically delicate for multiple reasons. The aftershocks of the farm laws agitation continue to influence voter perceptions, especially in rural areas dominated by Sikh farmers. At the same time, the party’s traditional alliance architecture has collapsed, forcing it to redefine its role in the state’s political ecosystem.

Shah’s approach appears to be aimed at building the party’s legitimacy step by step rather than chasing immediate electoral victory.

Rebuilding bridges with Sikh voters

The BJP’s biggest structural challenge in Punjab has always been its limited acceptance among Sikh voters. Without making inroads into this electorate, the party cannot realistically compete in the majority of Assembly constituencies.

The emphasis on visible Sikh leadership



WHETHER THIS
STRATEGY
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ON MESSAGING
BUT ALSO ON THE
BJP’S ABILITY TO
BUILD A GENUINE
GRASSROOTS
PRESENCE IN
RURAL PUNJAB

The writer is Chief Reporter with *The Pioneer*, Chandigarh

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reflects an attempt to change that perception. The BJP now appears keen to project Sikh leaders prominently within the party structure, signalling that Sikh representation will not be tokenistic but central to its Punjab strategy.

Punjab’s electoral arithmetic explains the urgency of this effort. Sikh voters dominate roughly 70 to 75 of the state’s 117 Assembly constituencies. In regions such as Malwa and Majha, the Sikh electorate holds decisive influence in a majority of seats. For a party that has historically been viewed as urban-centric, building credibility in these constituencies is essential. The BJP’s ongoing induction of Sikh leaders and its effort to highlight their political visibility suggest a deliberate attempt to create a new leadership layer capable of engaging rural Punjab.

The farmer factor: Healing a political rupture

Even more challenging for the BJP is its strained relationship with farmers. The farm laws agitation, coupled with the

unfulfilled promise of a legal guarantee on minimum support price (MSP), created a deep political rupture between the saffron party and large sections of Punjab’s agrarian community. Repairing this relationship is central to the BJP’s electoral ambitions. By emphasising that the Central Government continues to work in the interest of farmers and dismissing fears surrounding international trade agreements, the party appears to be attempting a slow process of trust rebuilding. This effort is as much psychological as political. The BJP’s leaders know that rural hostility once prevented them from entering villages in Punjab. Any improvement in that perception, even marginal, could open political space for the party.

A crucial element of the BJP’s messaging is the emphasis on its rising vote share in Punjab. The party’s vote share rose from 6.6 per cent in the 2022 Assembly elections to more than 19 per cent in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls. Shah’s narrative frames

this increase as the beginning of a political trajectory that could eventually lead to power. The argument is designed less for immediate persuasion and more for long-term psychological impact. Within the party organisation, it seeks to instil confidence among workers who have long struggled in a difficult political environment. Among voters, it attempts to reposition the BJP as a growing political force rather than a marginal contender. In electoral politics, momentum can often become self-reinforcing. Shah’s strategy appears to rely on creating precisely that perception.

A new political agenda: Religious conversion

The BJP’s messaging in Punjab is also attempting to reshape the political agenda itself. By raising the issue of religious conversions and promising legislation to prevent them, the party has introduced a sensitive religious question into Punjab’s political discourse. The issue resonates particularly among Sikh groups concerned about conversion trends among marginalised communities. Simultaneously, the BJP is trying to claim ownership of governance issues that have long troubled the state - particularly the drug menace. By promising to eliminate drugs within two years, the party is attempting to position itself as a decisive alternative to governments that have repeatedly pledged action but struggled to deliver. These themes - identity, law and order, and governance - form the ideological backbone of the BJP’s emerging Punjab narrative.

The BJP’s strategy is not limited to Sikh outreach. It is also attempting to broaden its social coalition in Punjab by engaging other influential communities. One important component of this effort is outreach to Other Backward Classes. Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini, himself an OBC leader, has been repeatedly deployed in Punjab to connect with these voters. His frequent appearances in the state reflect a deliberate attempt to build a political bridge with communities that have historically remained outside the BJP’s core support base. Similarly, the party is making a visible effort to connect with Dalit voters, who constitute a significant share of Punjab’s population. Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s visit to Dera Ballan in Jalandhar on 1 February, immediately after presenting

the Union Budget in Parliament, was widely interpreted as a symbolic gesture towards the Ravidasia community. The dera is considered a nerve centre of Dalit politics in the state. These outreach efforts suggest that the BJP is attempting to build a multi-layered social coalition rather than relying on a single identity bloc.

Learning from the 2022 setback

The BJP’s current strategy also reflects lessons learned from its experience in the 2022 Assembly elections. After its alliance with the Akali Dal collapsed in 2020, the BJP effectively entered the contest almost alone. The party attempted to compensate by forming a coalition with breakaway factions - Capt Amarinder Singh’s Congress offshoot and Sukhdev Singh Dhindsa’s Akali faction. Yet, the arrangement proved politically ineffective, and the experiment ended in a disappointing electoral outcome.

That setback has forced the BJP to rethink its approach. Instead of relying on fragmented alliances, the party now appears focused on building its own organisational strength in the state.

The emerging signals suggest that the BJP is preparing to fight the next Assembly election largely on its own. This marks a significant shift from decades of politics in which the party functioned as the junior partner in the Akali-BJP alliance. Contesting independently indicates that the BJP now seeks to evolve from a supporting player into a principal political actor in Punjab. Such an ambition is undoubtedly risky. Punjab’s political landscape remains dominated by regional forces with deep social roots. For the BJP to challenge them, it will need far more than symbolic gestures or short-term campaign narratives.

What Amit Shah’s intervention ultimately reveals is that the BJP is preparing for a long political experiment in Punjab. The party is attempting to rebuild its relationship with Sikh voters, repair trust with farmers, cultivate OBC and Dalit support, and project itself as a credible governing alternative. Each of these objectives requires sustained political engagement over time.

Whether this strategy succeeds will depend not only on messaging but also on the BJP’s ability to build a genuine grass-roots presence in rural Punjab. For now, the blueprint has been drawn. The real test will lie in whether the party can translate this carefully crafted political design into electoral reality.

The India-EU free trade agreement: State that stands to gain the most



JASHAN
KAKKAR

SURBHI
SINGH

The India-EU Free Trade Agreement heralds a major reset in India’s trade playbook with one of its most valuable markets. With bilateral merchandise trade at USD 136.54 billion in FY25 and exports of USD 75.85 billion, yielding a USD 15.29 bn surplus, the agreement comes as the EU withdraws GSP preferences, exposing 87 per cent of India’s exports to tariffs. These withdrawals have been sharp in labour-intensive sectors such as textiles, apparel and leather. By eliminating duties on over 99 per cent of India’s export value, the FTA replaces uncertainty with predictable market access.

This stability matters as India’s exports to the EU have grown 16.4 per cent annually since 2020-21, driven by labour-intensive and engineering sectors. Preferential access under the FTA helps offset competitive disadvantages vis-à-vis rivals such as Bangladesh, Turkey and Pakistan in textiles and apparel - a European market of USD 263.5 billion where tariff asymmetries have constrained India’s share, as competitors have enjoyed lower tariffs on key apparel lines, eroding India’s price competitiveness despite comparable product quality. The EU will remove duties on nearly 97 per cent of tariff lines, covering over 99 per cent of trade value, with most labour-intensive exports gaining immediate relief. Few of India’s existing trade agreements deliver this level of coverage, underlining the deal’s strategic depth.

For India’s states, however, the real dividends of this expanded market access will depend on export capacity on the ground - few states are as consequential to this equation as Uttar Pradesh.

Uttar Pradesh at the heart of India’s EU Trade opportunity

The European Union has emerged as a critical export destination for Uttar Pradesh, placing the state firmly within India’s evolving trade engagement with Europe. Of India’s total exports to the EU, Uttar Pradesh contributed nearly USD 6.3 billion - around 8.3 per cent of the national total. After decades of trailing coastal states, Uttar Pradesh’s rise signals a quiet



rebalancing in India’s export geography and its growing integration into EU-facing trade.

Over the past decade, exports to the EU have grown at a CAGR of 8.44 per cent, signalling sustained engagement rather than a recent spike. This growth suggests that European demand for Uttar Pradesh’s products is already established; the FTA simply removes tariff frictions that have constrained scale. In that sense, the agreement magnifies an existing edge, making Uttar Pradesh a rare case of a state entering an FTA with an established foothold in the partner market.

Nearly 80 per cent of Uttar Pradesh’s EU-bound shipments are absorbed by six economies - Germany, Austria, France, the Netherlands, Spain and Italy. For a state exporting into such mature and regulation-heavy economies, stable and predictable market access is a prerequisite for long-term competitiveness.

Sectorally, the case sharpens: electrical machinery accounts for nearly 50 per cent of Uttar Pradesh’s EU-bound exports, followed by apparel, leather and footwear, and carpets - together forming 75 per cent of the basket worth USD 4.7 billion. These labour-intensive, MSME-dominated sectors are rooted in regional clusters such as the carpet belt of Mirzapur and the leather hubs of Kanpur and Agra, already integrated with European value chains. For Uttar Pradesh, therefore, the India-EU FTA is not merely about expanding trade volumes; it is about safeguarding employment, enabling small firms to scale, and anchoring the state’s manufacturing transition within global value chains.

Market access is not market entry!

The India-EU FTA’s impact will unfold not in negotiations, but on factory floors. Even as tariff barriers fall, Indian exporters, particularly MSMEs, will continue to confront some of the European Union’s most exacting regulatory

regimes. The Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) marks a decisive shift in market access, extending compliance beyond product quality to carbon accounting and sustainability disclosure. Compliance audits and emissions reporting will raise costs, hitting smaller firms hardest. For sectors such as electrical machinery, ceramics and certain metal products, where Uttar Pradesh has a growing footprint, carbon intensity will increasingly determine who can export competitively - not just who can produce cheaply.

To compete in the EU market, exporters must also meet strict regulatory standards on chemicals, product safety and manufacturing quality requirements that demand testing, traceability and continuous upgrades. With 97 per cent of India’s MSMEs classified as micro enterprises, compliance costs could constrain export growth. Existing support schemes remain too limited for this transition.

This is where the promise of the FTA intersects with the urgency of domestic reform. Without a sharper domestic regulatory and industrial policy push, preferential access to the EU will accrue to a narrow pool of firms already equipped to bear compliance costs. With the right state-level push, however, the India-EU FTA can do far more - forcing MSME upgrading, formalising supply chains, and positioning states like Uttar Pradesh as serious players in high-value global markets. This includes testing facilities, financing for cleaner technologies, and support for carbon accounting in export clusters. The agreement is signed; what remains is the harder task of making it count, especially for states like Uttar Pradesh that already have a foothold in Europe but now need to climb the quality and sustainability ladder.

The authors are a Research Associate and a Research Assistant, respectively, at Pahle India Foundation

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Dealing with Gutkha menace



SAMRAT
CHOWDHERY

DEREK
YACH

India’s attempt to ban gutkha is celebrated as a triumph of public health legislation. Over the past decade, the central and state governments systematically outlawed the toxic blend of chewing tobacco, areca nut and flavourings. Optimism surged when the Global Adult Tobacco Survey (GATS-2) projected a comforting 4.5 per cent decline in smokeless tobacco prevalence. But sweeping prohibitions rarely rewrite ground realities.

A recent working paper from the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister (EAC-PM) dismantles the narrative of a successful ban. Relying on the 2023-24 Household Consumption Expenditure Survey (HCES), Working Paper WVP/42/2026 tracks the financial outflow of families rather than relying on self-reported health surveys that are historically skewed by social stigma. The economic data reveals that, rather than declining, the footprint of gutkha has expanded aggressively over the past decade.

In rural India, the share of households reporting gutkha consumption skyrocketed from 5.3 per cent in 2011-12 to 30.4 per cent in 2023-24, a more than five-fold rise. This translates to a jump from 8.9 million to 59.6 million rural households buying the product. Urban centres experienced an identical explosion, as prevalence climbed from 3.1 per cent to 16.8 per cent over the same period. The burden of this unchecked expansion falls disproportionately on lower-income households, where prevalence rose even faster. Despite the ban, gutkha now accounts for 41 per cent of all rural tobacco expenditure, making it the single largest tobacco product by value. Prevalence exceeds 85 per cent among the poorest 40 per cent of rural households in the largest states, such as Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh, severely misallocating limited resources and pulling critical funds away from food and education.

The public health implications are grave. Gutkha is uniquely deadly, as it combines two highly potent Class I carcinogens: tobacco and areca nut. Regular use is associated with oral submucous fibrosis, leucoplakia, periodontal disease, and increased risks of cardiovascular disease. India already shoulders one of the highest global burdens of head-and-neck cancers, with tobacco and areca nut linked to over 90 per cent of cases. This rising tide of consumption threatens to accelerate the epidemic. The failure of the gutkha ban is the consequence of a flawed regulatory envi-

ronment. Prohibition has simply driven the industry to innovate its distribution through clever product unbundling. Vendors sell tobacco and areca nut (pan masala) sachets separately, allowing users to mix the gutkha components themselves at the point of sale. Combined with weak enforcement and aggressive surrogate advertising, the habit has become deeply normalised across the labour force as a cheap stimulant to endure gruelling work shifts. The resulting wave of chronic disease will inevitably strain public healthcare initiatives. Policymakers urgently need to pivot towards pragmatic, data-driven alternatives. The current model of strict prohibition and taxation has failed. Punitive taxes do not force low-income users to quit; they simply impoverish them further while enriching a massive illicit market, which is now valued at over \$3.3 billion, according to the latest industry data.

A mature regulatory strategy must embrace tobacco harm reduction. The primary objective should be migrating current users away from carcinogenic smokeless tobacco like gutkha. Enabling access to significantly lower-risk alternatives provides a realistic off-ramp, while decreasing pressure on state machinery.

Modern nicotine pouches, nicotine replacement therapies (NRTs), and cytisine-based cessation treatments address chemical dependency without the primary carcinogens. A harm reduction approach is far more effective than prohibition. We can look at global precedents to see this in action. Sweden is on track to become the first formally “smoke-free” nation, reducing its prevalence to near 5 per cent by embracing safer oral nicotine alternatives such as snus and tobacco-free pouches.

Predictive models for countries adopting harm reduction forecast significant public health dividends. Studies in regions such as Africa and Southeast Asia show that adopting safer alternatives could save hundreds of thousands of lives in single nations by 2060. Scaling these projections to India’s 267 million tobacco users indicates that millions of life-years could be saved by simply transitioning users to safer nicotine delivery systems.

We must expand access to these safer options alongside smart regulation, risk-proportionate taxation, and robust cessation support. Prohibition fails when demand and social acceptability remain high. Banning products without providing viable withdrawal plans traps millions of users in a deadly cycle of addiction and fuels a booming black market. Acknowledging a policy failure is difficult for any administration. But ignoring the evidence from national economic surveys guarantees a severe public health disaster. Shifting towards pragmatic harm reduction is the only realistic way to avert a massive future burden of preventable disease and death.

Samrat Chowdhery is an independent Tobacco Harm Reduction Advocate, Delhi, India. and Derek Yach is former WHO Executive Director, Global Health Consultant, Southport, USA

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Ensure optimum use of funds: Parliamentary panel to MoSPI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

A Parliamentary panel has asked the Statistics Ministry to ensure optimum utilisation of allocated funds and advised it to request supplementary demands, if needed.

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Finance, in its Thirty-Fifth Report — 'Demands for Grants (2026-27)' of the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation, noted the submission of the ministry that the budgetary allocations are not sufficient to meet the requirements of various schemes like the Support for Statistical Strengthening Scheme(SSS), among others.

The panel noted that the ministry has been allocated only ₹4,522.25 crore against its

projected Budgetary demand of ₹5,826.11 crore.

The ministry itself has admitted that reduced funding poses risks to the scheme's viability and will have strategic implications, such as the inability to fund front-loaded costs for IT infrastructure (tablets, laptops), mobilise manpower for field work, and conduct training/workshops for field staff and Directorate of Economics and Statistics (DES) staff in the first two quarters of 2026-27.

The committee further stated that this could lead to a loss of sub-national data granularity and hinder the digital transformation of statistical systems.

It has also been informed that the projected budgetary demand was higher due to the revamp and redesign of



the Support for Statistical Strengthening (SSS) Scheme, activities like training and awareness creation for the upcoming 8th Economic Census, the conduct of multiple surveys, including Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS), Household Income Surveys, CMS modules, and All India Debt and Investment Survey

(AIDIS), among others. It was observed that the increased projected outlay was also required to support Digital Transformation initiatives, the Data Innovation (DI) Lab initiative, and other miscellaneous expenditures.

Considering the importance of diverse programmes, the committee recommend

that the ministry proceed with its planned initiatives as per the projected trajectory and ensure optimal utilisation of the currently allocated funds.

If further financial requirements emerge to meet the physical targets, the ministry may seek additional funds through Supplementary

Demands for Grants, it stated.

The committee, considering the pivotal role of data in policy formulation, implementation, monitoring and research, have recommended that the ministry may explore the development and operationalisation of an integrated digital dashboard that consolidates key sectoral data from various ministries, departments, and agencies (MDAs).

Such a platform should aim to provide authentic, verified and periodically updated standardised data in a user-friendly format accessible to all, it stated.

The panel noted that discussions have begun between the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation and the Ministry of Women and Child Development to conduct a

National Child Survey under the Mission Vatsalya.

It has urged the ministry to expedite the National Child Survey and develop a child well-being statistical dashboard and National Child Index to monitor the condition of children across districts and states, and has suggested a tie-up with State Governments to engage panchayats and municipal bodies to facilitate localised data collection.

The panel noted challenges in the digital portal of the MPLAD Scheme and discrepancies in figures of expenditure reporting.

The committee have recommended improving the portal for real-time project tracking and simplifying the onboarding and replacement of implementing agen-

cies to ensure effective implementation of the scheme.

The committee, with regard to Infrastructure and Project Monitoring (IPMD), have recommended that the ministry systematically leverage its monitoring data to operationalise a structured escalation matrix.

Rather than a static threshold, this matrix should be calibrated on a dynamic basis.

Ministries and departments whose project delay rate either exceeds 50 per cent within a financial year and shows no year-on-year improvement or whose delay rate deteriorates significantly relative to the previous year, may be flagged by MoSPI to the Cabinet Secretariat/PMO for review under apex forums such as PRAGATI, it stated.

LPG consumption slumps 17% in March on war-related shortages

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Cooking gas LPG consumption in India fell by a steep 17.7 per cent in the first half of March on the back of supply disruptions due to war in West Asia, preliminary industry data showed.

LPG consumption fell to 1.147 million tonne during the first fortnight of March, 17.3 per cent lower than 1.387 million tonne consumed in the same period last year and 26.3 per cent lower than 1.557 million tonne demand in the first half of February.

India imports about 60 per cent of its LPG requirements, much of it via the Strait of Hormuz, which has been effectively shut following US and Israeli strikes on Iran



and Tehran's retaliation. With supplies from Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates disrupted, the Government has cut LPG supplies to commercial establishments like hotels, and industries to safeguard household cooking gas availability.

Preliminary sales data of three state-owned fuel retailers, who control roughly 90 per cent of the market,

showed LPG consumption during March 1 to March 15 was 16 per cent lower than the demand in the same period of 2024 and 10.6 per cent lower than March 1-15, 2023.

LPG consumption has grown at a steady 3-4 per cent annually in recent years, driven by Government efforts to replace firewood and other polluting fuels.

LPG shortage in food processing sector not much of concern for now: Paswan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Food Processing Industries Minister Chirag Paswan on Tuesday sought to reassure the sector over LPG supply disruptions, saying the shortage was not that much of a concern for now, even as the Government remains on alert over the escalating West Asia crisis.

Commercial LPG supply has been severely curtailed, capped at just 20 per cent of average monthly consumption for businesses, as the Government prioritises domestic household cooking gas in the wake of significant supply chain disruptions triggered by the ongoing conflict in West Asia.

"Right now, it is not that much of a concern. Yes, precautionary steps are being



taken, but then we need to keep an eye," Paswan told reporters on the sidelines of an ASSOCHAM event on nutraceuticals.

Offering reassurance to the industry, the minister said, "I assure that as of now, the situation is under control. But, yes, we need to keep an eye and keep a watch on the situation of the war. If it continues, then definitely further steps will need to be taken".

LPG is a critical input for India's food processing

sector, powering everything from deep fryers and ovens to drying and sterilisation units in plants that produce snacks, *namkeens*, biscuits, dairy products, and packaged foods. Its supply disruption has raised concerns about production continuity across a wide range of processed food categories.

The Government, Paswan said, is actively monitoring the situation to ensure LPG supply is maintained, given the war conditions in West Asia.

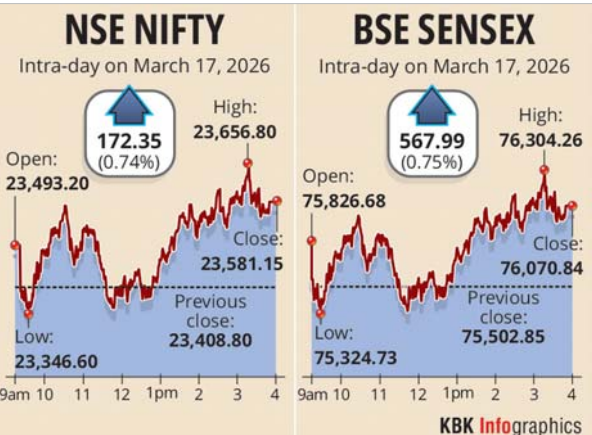
Stock markets rally for 2nd day; Sensex, Nifty climb nearly 1%

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Benchmark stock indices Sensex and Nifty rallied for the second consecutive day on Tuesday, closing higher by nearly 1 per cent following a rally in metal and auto shares and a positive trend in global markets. The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 567.99 points or 0.75 per cent to settle at 76,070.84. During the day, it surged 801.41 points or 1.06 per cent to 76,304.26.

The 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 172.35 points or 0.74 per cent to end at 23,581.15.

From the 30-Sensex firms, Eternal surged the most by



5.70 per cent. Tata Steel, Mahindra & Mahindra, Bharat Electronics, Larsen & Toubro, Bharti Airtel and Maruti were

also among the major gainers. Infosys, Bajaj Finance, ITC, Tata Consultancy Services and

HCL Tech were among the biggest laggards.

In Asian markets, South Korea's benchmark Kospi jumped 1.63 per cent, while Hong Kong's Hang Seng index ended marginally higher. Japan's Nikkei 225 index and Shanghai's SSE Composite index settled lower. Markets in Europe were trading higher. The US market ended higher on Monday.

"Indian equities extended their recovery for a second consecutive session, supported by easing volatility and selective sectoral strength, although underlying caution continues to shape market behaviour. A

key positive was the sharp decline in India VIX, which dropped 8 per cent to sub-20 levels," Hariprasad K, Research Analyst and Founder, Livelong Wealth, said. Sectorally, the rebound was led by the automobile space, with the Nifty Auto index gaining 2 per cent, he added. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped 2.44 per cent to \$102.7 per barrel.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth ₹9,365.52 crore on Monday, according to exchange data. Domestic Institutional Investors (DIIs), however, bought stocks worth ₹12,593.36 crore.

Rupee falls 12 paise to settle at record low of 92.40 against US dollar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The rupee declined 12 paise to settle at an all-time low of 92.40 (provisional) against the US dollar on Tuesday, pressured by rising crude oil prices and sustained outflow of foreign funds amid the West Asia crisis.

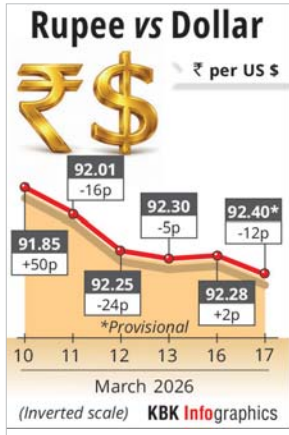
A positive trend in domestic equity markets also helped the domestic currency at the lower level, even as investors remained watchful of the US Federal Reserve's interest rate decision, forex traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the local unit opened at 92.35 and hit the lowest intra-day level of 92.47 against the greenback. The unit finally ended at a new lifetime low of 92.40 (provisional), registering a loss of 12 paise from the previous closing level.

Despite a marginal gain of 2 paise on Monday, the local unit ended the session at a near record low of 92.28 against the dollar.

The rupee, Asia's worst-performing currency, touched its lowest intra-day level of 92.47 for the first time on March 13, when it ended the session at 92.30 against the dollar.

Anuj Choudhary, Research



Analyst, Mirae Asset ShareKhan, said the rupee declined due to a surge in crude oil prices and continued FII outflows. However, a recovery in domestic markets and softening of the US dollar prevented a sharp fall in the rupee. He said that any hopes of reopening the Strait of Hormuz and intervention by the RBI may support the rupee at lower levels.

"Investors will also watch out for the FOMC, ECB, Bank of Japan and Bank of England's monetary policy this week. USD-INR spot price is expected to trade in a range of ₹92.10 to ₹92.75," Choudhary added.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies,

was trading 0.05 per cent higher at 99.52.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading 2.65 per cent higher at USD 102.86 per barrel in futures trade.

On the domestic equity market front, the Sensex gained 567.99 points, or 0.75 per cent, to settle at 76,070.84, while the Nifty climbed 172.35 points, or 0.74 per cent, to 23,581.15.

The latest Government data, released on Monday, showed the country's trade deficit narrowed to ₹27.1 billion in February compared to January.

Merchandise exports dropped marginally by 0.81 per cent to \$36.61 billion, while imports increased by 24.11 per cent to \$63.71 billion in February this year from \$51.33 billion recorded a year ago.

The country's wholesale price inflation rose to an 11-month high of 2.13 per cent in February, driven by an uptick in prices of food and non-food articles, even though vegetable prices eased on a month-on-month basis, another Government data showed on Monday.

Foreign institutional investors sold equities worth ₹9,365.52 crore on a net basis on Monday, according to exchange data.

India's youth growing and getting more educated: Report

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India has made substantial progress in expanding access to higher education for youth in the last four decades, helping them move from agriculture to industry and services, and reduced gender and caste-based disparities, a report said.

However, the 'State of Working India 2026' report stated that the challenges remain and the extent to which the large, increasingly educated, and aspirational cohort is absorbed into the labour market will determine whether India's demographic dividend translates into an



economic dividend. India has made substantial progress in expanding access to higher education for its young (15- to 29-year-old) population, ensuring a movement out of agriculture into industry and services, and

reduced gender and caste-based disparities, it stated.

"More young people today are educated, informed, and ambitious than ever before. These are real achievements of which we can be

proud," noted Indu Prasad, President, Azim Premji University in a statement. The report draws on official databases going back four decades to see how youth participation in education and employment has changed, how well this demographic dividend has been used and the challenges and opportunities that arise in integrating them into the workforce.

Rosa Abraham, lead author of the report and Associate Professor of Economics at Azim Premji University said, "The report traces the journey of a young worker — from education to job search and employment, and how this transition has evolved over the last 40 years."

India's chemicals industry to reach \$255 bn by 2030: McKinsey

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's chemicals industry is set to outpace economic growth and expand to \$230-255 billion by 2030, driven by emerging high-growth segments, according to a report by McKinsey & Company.

The sector, currently valued at \$155-165 billion, is projected to grow at a compound annual rate of 8-9 per cent despite global headwinds.

The report identified eight high-growth arenas — including semiconductors, electric vehicles and batteries, renewables, construction, aerospace and defence, auto components, bio-to-X and e-commerce — that could generate an additional \$30-35 billion in demand by 2030, growing at around 16 per cent annu-

ally. Construction-linked chemicals alone are expected to double to \$28 billion by 2030, supported by infrastructure and urban development.

India's chemicals sector has delivered a total shareholder return CAGR of about 17 per cent over the past decade, outperforming global peers and benchmark indices. However, the report highlighted a \$31 billion trade deficit in chemicals, particularly in inorganics and polymers, indicating significant import substitution opportunities.

To capitalise on the growth potential, the report recommended that companies scale up global operations, pursue partnerships and acquisitions, increase R&D spending, and adopt AI-led efficiencies. Strengthening



supply chains and balance sheets will also be critical as the industry navigates global volatility and shifts towards value-led growth, it added.

"India's chemicals industry is entering a defining

decade," said a McKinsey statement on the report.

The report, 'From Challenges to Possibilities: Leading India's Chemicals Industry Through Global Headwinds', projects the

chemical sector "to expand from USD 155-165 billion today to \$230-255 billion by 2030, potentially outpacing the GDP growth rate."

In order to identify the next wave of growth, McKinsey research has identified 18 distinctive arenas of growth at an India level. Of these, eight select arenas could unlock \$30-35 billion in incremental chemical demand by 2030.

"India's trade deficit highlights a substantial import substitution opportunity, particularly in inorganics and polymers: India's chemicals trade deficit currently stands at approximately \$31 billion (2025), concentrated in inorganics (\$12 billion) and polymers (\$13 billion) wherein there is an opportunity to build world-scale capacities in select value chains e.g.,

styrene, acetic acid, polyols," it said. To capture this growth, companies need strategic levers for value creation. It called for creating global operating capabilities in priority markets, institutionalising programmatic partnerships, turning innovation into a growth engine, strengthening balance sheets and building resilient supply chains.

Despite strong export growth over the past decade, India's share of global trade in chemicals remains limited at 3 per cent, compared to China's over 20 per cent, the European Union's more than 15 per cent, and the United States' over 10 per cent.

M&A intensity in Indian chemicals stands at just 0.9 per cent, compared with the national average of 2.5 per cent. With portfolio rationalization underway globally

and asset valuations resetting in Europe, Indian firms have a window to pursue inorganic growth and technology access, the report said.

India's chemical industry invests only 0.5 per cent of its revenue into R&D, significantly less than global peers such as Japan, the US, and the EU - presenting a critical area for enhancement.

McKinsey estimates that AI and advanced analytics could deliver 8-12 per cent EBITDA improvements across procurement, manufacturing, and supply chain functions, without heavy capital expenditure.

"Recent disruptions, including pandemic-related shutdowns and logistics bottlenecks, underscore the need for more resilient supply chains such as distributed warehousing, regional

inventory positioning, and vertical and horizontal integration or partnership arrangements," it said.

Nitika Nathani, Partner, McKinsey & Company, said the domestic demand base and geopolitical tailwinds create a meaningful opportunity to build global-scale platforms.

"However, the next phase of growth will depend on disciplined capital allocation, sharper portfolio choices, and sustained investment in innovation and operating excellence. Companies that prioritize structurally advantaged sectors and build global operating capabilities, can position the country not just as a fast-growing domestic market, but as a competitive global manufacturing hub."

FROM THE WORLD

ROME

Vatican court declares mistrial

The Vatican appeals tribunal declared a mistrial Tuesday in the Holy See's big "trial of the century," a stunning blow to both Pope Francis' legacy and Vatican prosecutors who had put a cardinal and several other people on trial over alleged financial crimes. In a 16-page ruling, the appeals court ruled that Francis and Vatican prosecutors both made procedural errors that nullified the original indictment and required a new trial. The court set a June 22 as the date for the new trial to begin. The ruling was a win for the defence and a huge setback to Vatican prosecutors, who have been scrambling to salvage their case. The prosecution and 2023 convictions against Cardinal Angelo Becciu and others had been held up by the late pope as evidence of his willingness to crack down on financial misconduct in the Holy See.

UK

Len Deighton dead at 97

Len Deighton, a prolific writer whose tough, stylish spy thrillers featured on bestseller lists for decades, has died. He was 97. Deighton's literary agent, Tim Bates, said he died Sunday. No cause of death was given. Deighton's first novel, "The IPCRESS File," helped set the tone of cool and gritty 1960s thrillers and was made into a film starring Michael Caine that helped launch both author and actor to long and stellar careers. "Len was a Titan," Bates said Tuesday. "He was not only one of the greatest spy and thriller writers of the 20th century but also one of our greatest writers in any genre." Born to a working-class family in a wealthy part of London in 1929 – his father was a chauffeur and his mother a part-time cook – Deighton grew up with a keen eye for the intricacies and absurdities of Britain's class system. He served in the Royal Air Force as part of Britain's then-mandatory national service.

Lebanon proposes first direct talks with Israel

KAREEM CHEHAYEB
■ Beirut

With airstrikes rocking Beirut and Israeli troops advancing against Hezbollah, Lebanon's Government has broken a taboo by proposing the first direct talks with Israel in decades. But Lebanese officials say they want the fighting to end first – and it might be too late for that.

Hezbollah's decision to enter the wider Iran war by firing rockets at Israel has led to the heavy Israeli bombardment of southern Lebanon and Beirut's southern suburbs, killing some 850 Lebanese and driving over a million people from their homes. The Iran-backed



Hezbollah views the latest war as an existential struggle, and Israel is threatening a wider ground invasion, the seizure of territory and the destruction of Lebanon's civilian infrastructure.

The United States, which has mediated during past flare-ups, has so shown no

interest in doing so this time around. Last week, Lebanese President Joseph Aoun offered to hold direct negotiations with Israel for the first time since the 1982 Israeli invasion during Lebanon's civil war. Aoun also asked for a boost in funding for Lebanese troops and reaf-

firmed his commitment to disarm Hezbollah, a long-standing Israeli and US demand. But Lebanon wants the fighting to end before any talks with Israel, according to three Lebanese diplomatic and Government officials familiar with the matter. They spoke on condition of anonymity as they were not authorised to speak to the press.

Israeli officials did not respond to requests for comment about the offer of talks. But Israeli Foreign Minister Gideon Saar, during a visit to an Israeli town hit by an Iranian missile, denied any talks were planned.

The agreement that ended Lebanon's 1975-1990 civil war called for the disarmament of

all armed groups, but Hezbollah alone kept its weapons, saying they were needed to protect Lebanon from Israel, which occupied the country's south until 2000. Successive Lebanese Governments, even those dominated by Hezbollah's political rivals, refused to directly confront the group, which was widely seen as more powerful than Lebanon's armed forces. There were fears that any attempt to disarm Hezbollah by force could rekindle the civil war.

That calculus started to change in 2024, when Israel killed most of Hezbollah's top leaders and pummelled its armed wing, potentially opening the door for

Lebanese authorities to exert greater control. Aoun, a former army commander, and Prime Minister Nawaf Salam, who both took office in early 2025, pledged to disarm Hezbollah, a position with wide support among Lebanon's war-weary population. In the months leading up to the war, the Government deployed troops across large parts of southern Lebanon and said it dismantled over 500 Hezbollah warehouses and military positions. But it did not confront the group directly.

When Hezbollah launched a volley of missiles at Israel days after the surprise US-Israeli bombing of Iran, the Lebanese Government condemned the militant group,

outlawed its activities, and arrested several militants it accused of illegal possession of weapons. But by then the country had been plunged into yet another war.

Hezbollah, which has launched waves of missiles and drones into northern Israel since that initial attack, still portrays itself as Lebanon's only viable defence. It accuses Israel of violating a 2024 US-brokered ceasefire agreement because it continued to launch regular airstrikes, which often killed civilians, and refused to withdraw from five strategic points along the border. Hezbollah also likely feels obligated to support Iran, its main sponsor, at a moment of peril. (AP)

Iran war pushes importers into energy triage

ANTON L DELGADO/ANIRUDDHA GHOSAL
■ Bangkok

The escalating war with Iran is pushing parts of the world into energy triage, forcing Governments to choose where to cut demand or absorb costs, while prioritising dwindling supplies.

Asia is the most exposed since it relies heavily on imported fuel, much of it shipped through the now-blocked Strait of Hormuz. The narrow passage offshore from Iran is the main route for shipping a fifth of global trade in crude oil and liquefied natural gas.

Governments in the region are scrambling to adjust - tallying oil reserves, conserving energy, competing for supplies and trying to blunt prices. That brings difficult trade-offs: saving power may slow business activity. Prioritising cooking gas for households can hurt restaurants and other businesses. "Even relatively modest



constraints on energy use can create a drag on industrial activity," said Linh Nguyen, with the consultancy Control Risks. She pointed to Vietnam's energy-intensive export industries and warned that higher fuel costs or conservation measures could quickly raise production costs or slow factory output.

Analysts warn the same hard choices could soon spread beyond Asia to fuel-importing economies in Africa

and elsewhere as countries compete for scarce supplies.

"The situation is common across the board," said Putra Adhiguna of the Jakarta-based Energy Shift Institute. "There is no easy decision for the short term."

With oil prices surging despite releases of some reserves, Southeast Asia is stretching dwindling energy reserves by urging households, businesses and Government agencies to slash power use. In the Philippines, officials have switched to a four-day work-week to cut back on fuel consumption and reduce the Government's energy use by a fifth. The office has been told to switch off computers during lunch breaks and keep the air conditioning no lower than 24°C (75°F).

Vietnam has urged people to work from home. While in Thailand, the prime minister has even asked officials to take the stairs instead of elevators. (AP)

China to provide humanitarian aid to Iran, other West Asian nations

KJM VARMA
■ Beijing

China on Tuesday said it will provide emergency humanitarian assistance to Iran, Lebanon and two other West Asian countries hit hard by the ongoing conflict in the region.

Speaking at a media briefing, Chinese foreign ministry spokesperson Lin Jian said that Beijing has decided to provide emergency humanitarian aid to Iran, Jordan, Lebanon, and Iraq in the hope of easing the humanitarian plight faced by local people. "The ongoing conflict has inflicted excruciating humanitarian disasters on



Lin Jian

(the) people of Iran and other regional countries. China deeply sympathises with people in relevant countries", Lin said. He was responding to a question about whether China is considering providing humanitarian assistance to the relevant countries, as the UN Refugee Agency recently said the crisis in West Asia has

constituted a major humanitarian emergency, and the affected regions already host nearly 25 million refugees, internally displaced persons and returnees.

Iran has suffered many innocent civilian casualties; about 800,000 people in Lebanon have been displaced; Jordan, Iraq and other countries have also been affected, Lin said. China will continue to make every effort to promote peace and end the fighting, facilitating the early restoration of regional peace and stability and preventing the further spread of the humanitarian crisis, he added. (PTI)

EU offers to pay Ukraine to fix oil pipeline

LORNE COOK
■ Brussels

Top European Union officials said on Tuesday they have offered to pay Ukraine to repair a damaged pipeline meant to carry crude oil to Hungary, in a bid to persuade the Government in Budapest to lift its veto on a massive aid package to the war-racked country.

Ukraine and Hungary have been locked in an escalating feud since Russian oil deliveries to Hungary and Slovakia were halted in January due to damage to the Druzhba pipeline, which crosses Ukrainian territory.

Ukrainian officials have blamed the damage on Russian drone attacks. Hungary's nationalist prime minister, Viktor Orban, has accused Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy of deliberately holding up oil supplies - claims that Zelenskyy denies.

In retaliation, Orban has vetoed a major 90-billion-euro (\$106 billion) EU loan to cover Ukraine's military and economic needs for two years. Hungary is also blocking a new round of EU sanctions against



Russia. EU leaders said in a statement Tuesday that the bloc "has offered Ukraine technical support and funding" to fix the pipeline.

"The Ukrainians have welcomed and accepted this offer. European experts are available immediately," European Council President Antonio Costa and European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen said. (AP)

Top US counterterrorism official resigns over Iran war, says Iran posed no imminent threat

SEUNG MIN KIM
■ Washington

Joe Kent, the director of the National Counterterrorism Centre, announced his resignation on Tuesday, saying he "cannot in good conscience" back the Trump administration's war in Iran.

Kent said on social media Iran "posed no imminent threat to our nation, and it is clear that we started this war due to pressure from Israel and its powerful American lobby."

There was no immediate comment from the White House. Kent, a former political candidate with connec-



Joe Kent

tions to right-wing extremists, was confirmed to his post last July on a 52-44 vote.

As head of the National Counterterrorism Centre, he was in charge of an agency tasked with analysing and

detecting terrorist threats.

Before entering President Donald Trump's administration, Kent ran two unsuccessful campaigns for Congress in Washington state. He also served in the military, seeing 11 deployments as a Green Beret, followed by work at the CIA.

Democrats strongly opposed Kent's confirmation, pointing to his past ties to far-right figures and conspiracy theories. During his 2022 congressional campaign, Kent paid Graham Jorgensen, a member of the far-right military group the Proud Boys, for consulting work. He also worked closely with Joey

Gibson, the founder of the Christian nationalist group Patriot Prayer, and attracted support from a variety of far-right figures.

During his Senate confirmation hearing, Kent also refused to distance himself from a conspiracy theory that federal agents instigated the January 6, 2021, attack at the Capitol, as well as false claims that Trump, a Republican, won the 2020 election over Democrat Joe Biden. Democrats grilled Kent on his participation in a group chat on Signal that was used by Trump's national security team to discuss sensitive military plans. (AP)

STATE BANK OF INDIA

E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE

HOME LOAN CENTRE-CUM-SARC II, CORRENTIUM BUILDING, GROUND FLOOR, SECTOR-62, NOIDA, DISTT.- GAUTAM BUDH NAGAR, U.P.-201301

NOTICE FOR E-AUCTION SALE ON 24.03.2026 FOR MOVABLE PROPERTY

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Movable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described movable property hypothecated /charged to the Secured Creditor, the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer State Bank of India, the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is Where is", "As is What is" and Whatever there is" on 24.03.2026, for recovery of bank due to the secured creditor as under:-

Interested bidder may deposit Pre-Bid EMD with BAANKNET before the close of e-Auction. Credit of Pre-Bid EMD shall be given to the bidder only after receipt of payment in BAANKNET's Bank Account and up-dation of such information in the e-auction website. This may take some time as per banking process and hence bidders, in their own interest, are advised to submit the pre-bid EMD amount well in advance to avoid any last minute problem.

Date / Time of E-Auction on 24.03.2026 for 6 Hours from 10:00 AM to 04:00 PM with unlimited extra. of 10 minute each.

S. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s)	Outstanding Dues for Recovery of which Property/ies is/ are being Sold	Vehicle Description	Reserve Price (Rs.) (below which property could not be sold) Earnest Money (EMD) 10% of the Reserve Price Bid Increment Amount	Name of the Authorised (Signatory)
1.	MS. MONIKA MISHRA	Rs.10,15,608.00 as on 17.03.2026 plus future Interest and other Charges etc. thereon	Make & Model: MAHINDRA BOLERO NEO N10(R) C.No.: UP14FU9738 Engine No.: XZPK699433 Chassis No.: MA1NA2XZXP6K94417 Date of Regn.: 09.11.2023 Kilometer Run: 49446 Fuel: Diesel	₹ 5,50,000.00 ₹ 55,000.00 ₹ 1,000.00 *GST as applicable	Mr. Binay Pathak (Chief Manager) Home Loan Centre-cum-SARC-II, Sector-62, Gautam Buddh Nagar, Noida, U.P.

Last Date of EMD Deposit on or before 23.03.2026 before 16:00 Hrs.
Account/ Wallet in which EMD to be remitted : Bidder's own wallet Registered with BAANKNET on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT/RETS. EMD of Reserve Price to be transferred by bidders by means of challan generated on his/her/their bidder account maintained with BAANKNET on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT from his /her/their bank. For any assistance, please call please call BAANKNET HELPPDESK: +91 8291220220, support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com and/or Authorized Officer.

TERMS AND CONDITIONS OF THE E-AUCTION ARE AS UNDER:

(1) E-Auction is being held on "As is where is", "as is what is basis" and "whatever there is basis" and will be conducted "On Line". The auction will be conducted through the Bank's approved service provider BAANKNET at their web portal: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing>

(2) Bank shall reserve the right to cancel/postpone the auction.

(3) The Vehicle are available for inspection during banking hours on 22.03.2026 From 11:00 AM to 04:00 PM., Contact Person: Mr.Rahul Pal / Mr. Rakesh (M/s Kuber Consultant) Mob No.: 9810807622 / 9868598282 (Resolution Agent) Address: G-27, Flat 104, Pankaj Tower 4 DDA Community Center, Vikas Puri, West Delhi-110018.

(4) *Successful bidder to pay GST as applicable on the successful bid amount, viz sale value.

(5) To the best of knowledge and information of the Authorized Officer there is no encumbrance on the property/ies. However the intending bidder should make their own independent inquiries regarding the encumbrances, title of the property/ies put on auction and claims/tights/dues/affecting the property prior to submitting their bid.

The e-Auction Advertisement does not constitute and will not be deemed to constitute any commitment or any representation of the Bank. The property is being sold with all the existing and future encumbrances whether known or unknown to the bank. The Authorized Officer shall not be responsible in any way for any third party claims/rights/ dues.

(6) The Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) of the successful bidder shall be retained towards part sale consideration and the EMD of the unsuccessful bidders shall be refunded. The Earnest Money Deposit shall not bear any Interest. The successful bidder shall have to deposit 25% of the sale price, immediately on acceptance of bid price by the Authorized Officer and the balance of the sale price on or before 15th day of the sale. Default in deposit of amount by the successful bidder would entail forfeiture of the whole money already deposited and property shall be put to the e-auction and the defaulting bidder shall have no claim/right in respect of property/amount.

(7) For detailed terms and conditions of the sale please refer to the link at the Bank's Service Provider's web portal: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> & e-auction website: <https://BAANKNET.com>

Date: 17.03.2026 Place: Noida Authorized Officer, State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre, RACPC 2, Noida

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is notified to the General public that I Mukesh Kumar S/o Sh. Ram Nandan Prasad Singh R/O H No. 1673 Sector-8, Faridabad, Haryana India do hereby solemnly affirm and state as follows: 1. A Independent Floor House Number 1637 sector 8 Faridabad, 2nd Floor, Haryana- 121006 was sold by Smt. Sita Matta W/o Sh. Vinod Kumar Matta, R/o H. No. 169, Sector 23, Faridabad, Haryana -121005 to Sh. Mukesh Kumar S/o Sh. Ram Nandan Prasad Singh & Mr. Piyush Bhardwaj S/o Sh. Mukesh Kumar both R/O H. No. 1673, Sector-8, Faridabad, Haryana-121006 2. The sale deed was made at Ballabhgarh on 3rd DAY OF MARCH, 2022 3. That above statement is true and correct. That it is my true and correct statement. If anyone has any objection please report to hsvp office sector 12 faridabad, haryana. Deponent, Piyush Bhardwaj

Change of Name

Public Notice: My daughter Avika Yadav (DOB: 31/03/2011) is mistakenly recorded as "Avika" in her birth certificate. Her correct name is "Avika Yadav," which shall be used for all purposes in future. Declarant: Jai Pratap Yadav. Address : J-276 Beta2 Greater Noida U.P.

EMILIE MEGNIEN, RIO YAMAT

■ Atlanta

Hundreds of flights were cancelled or delayed on Tuesday, one day after powerful storms swept across the eastern half of the country and upended air travel in a cross-section of cities.

Travellers have been facing additional jams at airport security checkpoints as a partial Government shutdown strains screener staffing. The disruptions come at an already challenging time for air travel, in part because the shutdown that began February 14 has pressured staffing at some security checkpoints.

At the same time, airports are crowded with spring break travellers and fans heading to March Madness games, the annual NCAA men's and women's college basketball tournaments.

More than 750 flights scheduled to fly into, out of or within the US have been called off as of early Tuesday, and about 1,300 were delayed, according to flight-tracking site FlightAware.

Flight delays and cancellations piled up Monday at some of the nation's largest airports, including those in New York, Chicago and Atlanta. The storm system that dumped heavy snow

Iran has permitted a Pakistani commercial oil tanker to pass through its side of the Strait of Hormuz and enter Pakistan's territorial waters in the Arabian Sea, an official said on Tuesday.

The ship, 'MT Karachi', carrying around 109,990 tonnes of crude oil will dock at the Karachi port trust on Wednesday, Pakistan National Shipping Corporation (PNSC) spokesperson Farooq Nizami said. The vessel successfully traversed the Iranian-controlled side of the Strait of Hormuz after receiving clearance from Iranian authorities, even as the conflict in the region has disrupted commercial air and sea traffic, he said. The tanker crossed the strait on March 15 after loading crude oil at Das Island in Abu Dhabi.

Hundreds of ships had been stranded in the narrow sea lane between Iran

FLIGHT CANCELLATIONS

After US storms dump snow

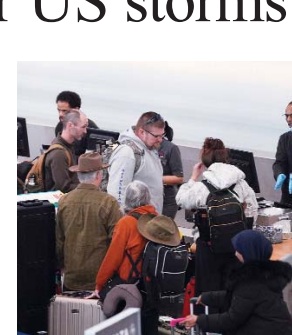
her Sunday night flight wasn't cancelled until early Monday.

"By that time the only place for us to sleep was the airport floor. So we're all tired and frustrated," she said, adding that the soonest she and her family could book another flight doesn't leave until Tuesday afternoon.

The nationwide cancellations on Monday included about 600 in and out of Chicago O'Hare International, more than 470 at Atlanta's Hartsfield-Jackson International and over 450 at LaGuardia Airport in New York City, according to Flight Aware. (AP)

FLIGHT CANCELLATIONS

After US storms dump snow



across the Midwest raced toward the East Coast with high winds reaching gusts near 50 mph (80 km) in parts of New York, the National Weather Service said. Kelly Price, who was trying to get home to Colorado after a family vacation in Orlando, Florida, said

Nizami said. Pakistan relies heavily on imported oil for its fuel and energy needs. Given the volatile security situation in the Gulf region, MT Karachi was provided full protection by a Pakistan Navy vessel during its journey to Karachi, Nizami said.

Iran allows Pakistani oil tanker through Hormuz

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Karachi

Iran has permitted a Pakistani commercial oil tanker to pass through its side of the Strait of Hormuz and enter Pakistan's territorial waters in the Arabian Sea, an official said on Tuesday.

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Hundreds of ships had been stranded in the narrow sea lane between Iran



and Oman since the US and Israel launched attacks on Iran, and Tehran targeted the region in retaliation.

MT Karachi is a DWT Aframax oil tanker that acquired early this year for \$74 million as part of efforts to expand Pakistan's national commercial fleet to boost energy transportation capacity,

Nizami said. Pakistan relies heavily on imported oil for its fuel and energy needs. Given the volatile security situation in the Gulf region, MT Karachi was provided full protection by a Pakistan Navy vessel during its journey to Karachi, Nizami said.

UN raises ethnic cleansing concerns in West Bank

JAMEY KEATEN
■ Geneva

The UN human rights chief's office expressed concerns about possible "ethnic cleansing" in a new report on Tuesday, saying that Israel has accelerated the expansion of settlements in large parts of the occupied West Bank and the forced displacement of more than 36,000 Palestinians.

The report from the office of Volker Turk, the UN high commissioner for human rights, covers a yearlong period through the end of October. It decries increased violence by Israeli settlers and security forces against Palestinians in the area. Turk alleged that Israeli authori-



ties were "playing the central role in directing, participating in or enabling this conduct," and the report denounced harassment, intimidation and destruction of farmland and homes of Palestinians.

Israel's Foreign Ministry

and the Israeli Embassy in Geneva didn't immediately comment. Much of the displacement of thousands has taken place in the northern West Bank, where Israel launched a broad military offensive in early 2025. Israel's Government says the

operation is aimed at stamping out militant groups active in the area.

The report says the displacement, "appears to indicate a concerted Israeli policy of mass forcible transfer throughout the occupied territory, aimed at permanent displacement, raising concerns of ethnic cleansing." At the same, Israel's hard-line Government has pressed ahead with an increase in new Israeli settlements across the West Bank.

The international community overwhelmingly considers settlements to be illegal, though the Trump administration has been more tolerant of the construction. Israel's Government is dominated by settler leaders and

their political allies. The rights office, which falls under the secretariat of UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres, said that Israeli authorities approved or moved forward on nearly 37,000 housing units in occupied east Jerusalem and more than 27,000 elsewhere in the West Bank.

Turk called for an immediate halt to the settlements and a reversal of their impact, along with the evacuation of all settlers and "an end to the occupation of the Palestinian territory."

The construction boom has been accompanied by an increase in settler violence against Palestinians. Israeli leaders have portrayed the violence as the work of a tiny

minority, but Palestinians and human rights groups say the Israeli army has done little to prevent the attacks and note that settlers are rarely held accountable. Earlier this month, three Palestinians were killed in a violent clash with settlers near Khirbet Abu Falah, east of Ramallah, and in a rare rebuke, the Israeli military strongly condemned the settler violence.

While outside the period covered by the UN report, the Palestinian Authority accused Israel of "exploiting the atmosphere of war" and the lack of international attention to issues in the West Bank to intensify intimidation, violence and forced displacement. (AP)

Budapest's Vintage freight trams celebrate 100 years



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Budapest

With the toot of a horn, the ring of a bell and the hiss of air brakes, an unusual rail vehicle pulls out of a depot in Budapest to serve the Hungarian Capital's public transit system, a job it has done for a century. The so-called freight trams, known as mukis, run on electricity provided by overhead wires and travel on Budapest's vast tram rail network, one of the busiest in the world. But unlike the hundreds of iconic yellow trams in the passenger fleet, they don't carry commuters. Acquired by the city in 1926, the wood-sided trams were initially products of necessity: They brought goods and raw materials to and from Budapest's factories after much of the local freight

infrastructure had been destroyed during World War I.

"Engineers at the time designed an electric drive system mainly using parts from vehicles damaged in the war, as well as parts from vehicles that had already been designated for scrapping," said Adam Zadravec, the head of tram vehicle development and technology at Budapest's public transit company BKV. "Their primary purpose was freight transport, but after World War II, these vehicles were also used for the removal of the war ruins," he said. Over time, the mukis' function changed as Hungary recovered. In the 1960s, some of the original 40 trams were equipped with a snowplough, enabling them to clear the city's tram tracks in winter, as they do today.

Suspected suicide bombers target Nigeria's Maiduguri, killing 23

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Maiduguri

At least 23 people were killed and more than 100 wounded in suspected suicide bombings on Monday late night that targeted Maiduguri city in northeastern Nigeria, police said Tuesday.

It was one of the deadliest attacks in the conflict-battered city in recent history.

Residents and emergency services earlier told that three explosions were reported in crowded places in Maiduguri, the Capital of Borno state, including in a major market and at the entrance of the University of Maiduguri Teaching Hospital. "Regrettably, a total of 23 persons lost their lives, while 108 others sustained varying degrees of injuries," Borno police spokesperson Nahum Kenneth Daso said in a statement that blamed the attacks on suspected suicide bombers.

No group has claimed responsibility for the attacks, but suspicion quickly fell on the Boko Haram jihadi group, which in 2009 launched an insurgency in northeastern Nigeria to enforce their radical interpretation of Shariah.

Boko Haram has since become stronger, with thousands of fighters and different factions, including the Islamic State West Africa Province, which is backed by the Islamic State group.

Maiduguri city has been at



Police officers seen at the scene of a bomb blast at a market in Maiduguri, Nigeria

AP

the heart of the deadly violence but has in recent years experienced relative peace even as the countryside is often battered by extremists.

The attack took place less than 24 hours after the Nigerian military repelled attacks by militants on the outskirts of Maiduguri, in what some residents say could have been planned as a distraction.

By Tuesday morning, there was heavy security deployment in the affected locations and along major roads in the city, but many public places remained closed amid heightened fear.

"Investigations are ongoing to further ascertain the circumstances surrounding the incidents and to bring perpetrators to justice," the Borno police command said. The first explosion was recorded at about 7.30 pm at the entrance of the teaching

hospital, while the second and third followed few minutes later at the popular Monday Market and nearby Post Office business hub, both located about 4 kilometres from the hospital.

Witnesses recounted the chaos that followed at the scenes and at hospitals as security forces and the emergency services quickly intervened.

"This attack has been one of the deadliest in Maiduguri in years," said Mohammed Hassan, a member of a volunteer group assisting security forces in fighting extremists. "We're in dire need of blood," he said of the situation hours after the attack.

The extremists have intensified their attacks against Nigerian military bases in recent weeks, killing several senior officers and soldiers, and stripping the bases of stocks of weaponry and ammunition.

Zelenskyy to discuss Russia-Ukraine war with British leader, NATO chief

JILL LAWLESS
■ London

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy was due in London on Tuesday for talks with UK Prime Minister Keir Starmer, the British Government said, as European countries look to keep international attention on Russia's invasion of Ukraine, while the unfolding Iran war engages world leaders.

Starmer's office said that NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte will also join the meeting at 10 Downing St. to discuss peacemaking efforts in Ukraine and "the need to maintain sanctions pressure



on Russia". The meeting comes days after the US temporarily waived some Russian oil sanctions in a bid to ease pressure on global supplies triggered by the war in the west Asia, which was sparked by the joint US-Israeli strikes on Iran starting on February 28. Zelenskyy criticised Washington's

move to ease sanctions, saying it would provide a windfall for Moscow to keep up its attacks on Ukraine.

US President Donald Trump says he wants to secure a peace deal that ends Europe's biggest conflict since World War II and has rattled the continent's leaders, who reckon that Russia could pose a credible security threat to the European Union by the end of the decade.

But US-brokered talks between delegations from Moscow and Kyiv, which so far have yielded no significant progress on key issues, have lost momentum amid the Middle East conflict. (AP)

Cuba's Island-wide blackout sparks energy crisis concerns

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Havana

Officials in Cuba reported an island-wide blackout Monday in the country of some 11 million people as its energy and economic crises deepen.

Cuba has blamed its woes on a US energy blockade after President Donald Trump in January warned of tariffs on any country that sells or provides oil to it.

The Ministry of Energy and Mines on X noted a "complete disconnection" of the country's electrical system and said it was investigating. President Miguel



Diaz-Canel on Friday said the island had not received oil shipments in more than three months and was operating on solar power, natural gas and thermoelectric plants, and the Government has had to postpone surgeries for tens of thousands of people. A massive outage

over a week ago affected the island's west, leaving millions without power.

Critical oil shipments from Venezuela were halted after the US attacked the South American country in early January and arrested its then-president, Nicolas Maduro. While Cuba produces 40 per cent of its petroleum and has been generating its own power, it hasn't been sufficient to meet demand as its electric grid continues to crumble.

On Friday, Diaz-Canel confirmed that Cuba was holding talks with the US Government as the problems continue to deepen.

Nepal PM urges NRN to strengthen unity

SHIRISH B PRADHAN
■ Kathmandu

Nepal's outgoing Prime Minister Sushila Karki called on Non-Resident Nepalis (NRN) worldwide to strengthen unity and actively contribute to Nepal's economic prosperity and development.

The Government alone cannot achieve the country's development goals, she said on Monday while addressing the 12th Global Conference and International General Assembly of the Non-Resident Nepali Association (NRNA), which concluded in Kathmandu.

Held under the theme "Our Unity, Base for Prosperity", the three-day conference brought together more than 1,000 members of the Nepali



Prime Minister Sushila Karki

diaspora representatives from across the globe.

The 12th edition of the Global Conference and International General Assembly of the NRNA also issued a 12-point declaration. NRNA is an umbrella organisation of around eight million Nepalese living abroad. Addressing the Conference, Karki said that the "Development and pros-

perity of Nepal cannot be achieved by the Government alone. Cooperation, investment, knowledge and innovation of all Nepalis-both in Nepal and abroad-are equally important."

Prime Minister emphasised investment, knowledge sharing, and cooperation, and called on the Himalayan nation's non-resident citizens worldwide to strengthen unity and actively contribute to Nepal's economic prosperity and development.

She also encouraged non-resident Nepalis to make use of Nepal's investment opportunities and contribute to economic growth, environmental protection and sustainable development. The Conference also

addressed the current ongoing conflict in West Asia in the wake of recent attacks by the US and Israel on Iran.

Starting February 28, the US and Israel launched a massive joint attack on Iran and with Tehran's retaliation, the conflict has extended to the entire Gulf region.

"We are deeply concerned and serious about the latest situation in the Middle East," the declaration issued by NRNA said.

"We express our commitment to strengthening cooperation with the Government of Nepal and international agencies to provide relief, rescue and rehabilitation assistance to Nepalis residing in various countries of the Middle East in times of crisis," it added. (PTI)

Chile's new far-right president launches work on border barrier

NAYARA BATSCHE
■ Santiago

Chilean President Jose Antonio Kast wasted no time. Less than a week after his inauguration, Chile's arch-conservative president began overseeing preparations to build a border barrier - part of his flagship campaign promise to block immigrants from crossing illegally.

From Chile's northern frontier area of Chacalluta, where legions of immigrants have slipped across the Peruvian border into one of the region's most prosperous nations, Kast vowed to implement what he calls his "Border Shield" plan.

Among other steps, it involves the construction of a physical barrier at the nation's northern border made up of ditches and fences and patrolled by drones and the military forces. So far, it doesn't look like much. A single bulldozer could be



Chile President Jose Antonio Kast

seen digging into the desert to carve out a trench. But Kast assured the public that "for all of Chile, this is a milestone."

"We have taken clear and concrete decisions to close our border to illegal immigration, drug trafficking and organised crime," he said. "We want to implement this without any delay." (AP)

Indian charged in Singapore for outraging modesty



GURDIP SINGH
■ Singapore

A Singapore court on Tuesday charged an Indian national for allegedly molesting and harassing an air stewardess on a flight from Bangkok to Singapore last month, a local media reported.

Akash Tiwari, 35, was charged with using criminal force to outrage the modesty of the victim on a Singapore Airlines flight after he allegedly initiated non-consensual physical contact with her.

The accused was also charged with causing distress by using threatening behaviour on the air stewardess, The Straits Times reported. According to court records, Tiwari has indicated that to plead not guilty to the charges.

His alleged offences took place on February 9 this year. The police said they were alerted to the incident at around 4:30 pm on the day of the incident.

Preliminary investigations revealed that the air stewardess was serving the man near his seat when he allegedly touched her inappropriately. She immediately warned the man to stop touching her and went to the galley to prepare for landing, police said. (PTI)

Hundreds of migrants vanishing in Mediterranean, authorities are withholding information

RENATA BRITO AND PAOLO SANTALUCIA
■ Rome

Bodies washing ashore day after day. Phone calls from relatives are going unanswered. Migrants' tents abandoned overnight. Migrants trying to reach Europe are vanishing in droves in what are known as "invisible shipwrecks", but Governments responsible for search and rescue are withholding information about what they know.

The beginning of 2026 ranks as the deadliest start to any year for people trying to cross the Mediterranean — an unprecedented 682 confirmed missing as of March 16 — according to the United Nations' International Organisation for Migration. But the real death toll is almost certainly much higher. Human rights groups are increasingly struggling to verify tolls as Italy, Tunisia and Malta have quietly restricted information on migrant



rescues and shipwrecks along the deadliest migration route in the world. The news barely makes headlines, in part because the lack of transparency prevents

journalists from confirming reports.

"It's a strategy of silence," said Matteo Villa, a researcher focusing on migration and data at the Italian Institute for

International Political Studies think tank. The organisation Refugees in Libya and other human rights groups have been sounding the alarm since late January, reporting more than 1,000 people missing after Cyclone Harry hit the region. But authorities have not confirmed, denied or corrected those reports.

In the weeks that followed the cyclone, more than 20 decomposing bodies washed ashore in Italy and Libya, while other human remains were spotted floating in the middle of the sea. For the families of missing migrants, not knowing their fate is excruciating.

"Europe should know that these people who got drowned in the sea have family members, have dreams, have passions," Josephus Thomas, a migrant from Sierra Leone and community leader in Tunisia's coastal town of El Amra, told AP.

Even the UN's migration agency is increasingly unable to verify cases of

migrants who die in what are known as "invisible shipwrecks" because of the growing lack of information.

Last year, at least 1,500 people were reported missing whose fates IOM could not confirm, said Julia Black, who leads the organisation's Missing Migrants Project. The issue persists in 2026.

"We started a new secondary data set of what we are calling unverifiable cases because it's just become so many," Black said. For this year, they already have more than 400 missing that they could not verify. Many humanitarian organisations that previously filled some of the information gaps are no longer able to do so because of the global wave of funding cuts and Government-imposed restrictions across the region. "We've seen the restriction of access for humanitarian actors, which is not right. And now we're seeing even the restriction of information," Black said. (AP)

PROSPECT



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma offers his prayers at Pitambari Peeth, Datiya, Madhya Pradesh on Tuesday

NCLT clears Adani's Jaiprakash takeover

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) on Tuesday approved Adani Enterprises Ltd's ₹14,535 crore bid to acquire Jaiprakash Associates Ltd through the insolvency process. In a regulatory filing, Jaiprakash Associates Ltd (JAL) informed that the NCLT, Allahabad bench, has "orally pronounced an order on March 17, 2026" approving the resolution plan submitted by Adani Enterprises Ltd.

In November last year, a Committee of Creditors (CoC) approved the resolution plan

by business tycoon Gautam Adani to acquire JAL.

Adani Enterprises won the approval of creditors of JAL for its ₹14,535 crore acquisition proposal for the bankrupt infrastructure group. It outbid Vedanta and Dalmia Bharat to win the bid for JAL. The COC of JAL, a company undergoing Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP) under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code 2016 (IBC), has approved the resolution plan submitted by Adani Enterprises Limited (AEL)," AEL had said in a stock exchange filing.

Adani got the maximum 89



Gautam Adani

per cent votes from creditors, followed by Dalmia Cement (Bharat) and Vedanta Group, it added. The JAL, which has high-quality assets and business interests spanning real estate, cement manufacturing, hospitality, power and engineering & construction, was admitted to the CIRP in June last year after it defaulted on payments of loans aggregating ₹57,185 crore.

JAL has major real estate projects like Jaypee Greens in Greater Noida, a part of Jaypee Greens Wishtown in Noida (both on the outskirts of the national Capital), and the Jaypee International

Sports City, located near the upcoming Jewar International Airport. It also has three commercial/industrial office spaces in Delhi-NCR, while its hotel division has five properties in Delhi-NCR, Mussoorie, and Agra. JAL has four cement plants in Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh, and a few leased limestone mines in Madhya Pradesh. It also has investments in subsidiaries, including Jaiprakash Power Ventures Ltd, Yamuna Expressway Tolling Ltd, Jaypee Infrastructure Development Ltd, and several other companies.

President Droupadi Murmu serves Akshaya Patra's 5 billionth meal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Akshaya Patra Foundation commemorated the milestone of serving 5 billion meals and its completion of 25 years of service to humanity at the Rashtrapati Bhavan Cultural Centre.

President Droupadi Murmu graced the event as the Chief Guest, and the Minister of Education Dharmendra Pradhan, was the Guest of Honour. The event was held in the august presence of Akshaya Patra's founders — Madhu Pandit Dasa, Chairman and President of ISKCON Bangalore, and Chanchalapati Dasa, Vice Chairman and Sr Vice President.

The theme of the event — 'Suposhit and Sushikshit

Bharat for Viksit Bharat' highlighted the collective efforts towards child nutrition and education for a developed India. The event was attended by Akshaya Patra's Board of Trustees, senior Government officials, distinguished leaders, public policy think tanks, philanthropists, partners, supporters and key stakeholders.

President gave gifts, served meals and in a heartfelt gesture, personally fed the children with her own hands. As an implementing partner of the Government of India's flagship PM POSHAN initiative, Akshaya Patra has been serving fresh, nutritious meals to millions of children studying in Government schools across India. The Foundation is currently feeding 2.35 million children

through its state-of-the-art kitchens in 78 locations across 16 States and 3 Union Territories of India, and aspires to feed 3 million children every day by 2030.

Speaking on the occasion, "Serving five billion meals in advancement of educational objectives is the remarkable achievement of The Akshaya Patra Foundation. The theme of this event, 'From a Well-Nourished and Well-Educated India to a Developed India', underscores the significance of a nourished and educated society in realizing our national resolve to build 'Viksit Bharat' by the year 2047. A safe and bright future for our children is not solely the responsibility of the Government, but a shared responsibility of us



President Murmu, Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, and Akshaya Patra founders Madhu Pandit Dasa and Chanchalapati Dasa serve meals to students at Rashtrapati Bhavan

all. When teachers, parents, social organisations, the corporate sector, and every segment of society work together, then we lay a strong foundation for the

coming generation. We must ensure that every child receives quality education, nutritious food, good health, and a clean and safe environment. These fundamen-

tals enable holistic development of children," Murmu said on occasion and commended Akshaya Patra Foundation for working continuously to address the issue of malnutrition among children and encourage them to pursue education by delivering mid-day meals to schools for past 25 years.

Pradhan in his address offered respects to Srila Prabhupada, whose inspiration gave rise to this selfless food distribution initiative, which has now grown into a mass movement.

Madhu Pandit Dasa said, "I express my heartfelt gratitude to the President for kindly gracing today's event. I also thank the Minister of Education and all other dignitaries for their presence. As we commemorate

Akshaya Patra's 25 years of service to humanity and the milestone of serving 5 billion meals, we reiterate our commitment to work towards Srila Prabhupada's noble vision that no one should ever go hungry. This event has encouraged everyone at Akshaya Patra to continue our services to children with even greater enthusiasm.

On the occasion Chanchalapati Dasa said, "It is a joyous occasion for Akshaya Patra as we have reached a significant milestone of serving 5 billion cumulative meals in our 25-year journey. We thank all our guests for taking time out of their schedules to participate in today's event. We are deeply grateful to the Government of India and various State and Union

Territories Governments for their constant support and encouragement in all our endeavours. We thank our donors, partners and well-wishers for joining us in our humble efforts to ensure child nutrition and education through freshly cooked, wholesome meals. On this occasion, we express our heartfelt appreciation to all the dedicated full-time missionaries and professionals of Akshaya Patra who have been working tirelessly every day for the welfare of society," he added.

Akshaya Patra achieved its first milestone of serving 1 billion meals cumulatively in just a span of 12 years. In 2012, the 1 billionth meal was served by Narayana Murthy, Founder of Infosys and philanthropist.

₹8,800 crore disbursed to Sahara depositors: Amit Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Cooperation Minister Amit Shah on Tuesday informed Parliament that ₹8,800 crore has been disbursed to over 40 lakh depositors of Sahara Group of Cooperative Societies till last month.

In a written reply to the Lok Sabha, the minister said that as of February, 2026, 1.45 crore applications and 4.06 crore claims have been made by the investors on the CRCS-Sahara Refund Portal.

"An amount of ₹8,783.55 crore has been disbursed to



40,33,448 investors of Sahara Group of Cooperative Societies," Shah said.

The refund process is being carried out in compliance with the orders of the Supreme Court.

"The applications received on the portal are processed in transparent manner, on proper identification and on submitting proof of their identity and deposits. The payment is deposited directly in Aadhaar-seeded bank account of genuine depositors," Shah said. Presently, payment of up to ₹50,000 is being disbursed to each

genuine depositor of Sahara Group of Cooperative Societies against verified claims through Aadhaar-seeded bank account.

Depositors have been asked to re-submit their applications in case of any deficiency in the application. The Supreme Court has ordered that an additional amount of ₹5,000 crore be transferred from 'Sahara-SEBI Refund Account' to Central Registrar of Cooperative Societies and granted extension for disbursement of refund to the depositors up to December 31, 2026.

IndiGo BluChip ties up with Adani airports for duty-free rewards

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

IndiGo, India's preferred airline, and Adani Airport Holdings Limited (AAHL), the country's largest private airport operator, have announced a strategic partnership enabling IndiGo BluChip members to earn points on duty-free shopping across AAHL-managed airports.

Under the partnership, members can earn five IndiGo BluChips for every ₹100 spent on duty-free products pre-booked through the Adani platform. Travellers can browse, reserve and pay for products online before departure, and collect their purchases conveniently at the airport.

Neetan Chopra, Chief Digital and Information Officer, IndiGo, said: "At IndiGo, we are continuously striving to enhance the value proposition of our loyalty programme. This partnership with Adani Duty Free strengthens our commitment to offering meaningful rewards beyond flights, making every step of the journey more beneficial for our customers. By combining IndiGo's extensive network with Adani's premium duty-free experience, we are delighted to bring greater convenience, choice and value to millions of travellers across India."



Suchit Bansal, Chief Executive Officer (CEO) — Non-Aero, AAHL, said: "We are transforming how travellers shop at airports by integrating digital discovery, pre-order convenience and seamless collection through the Adani platform. Our partnership with IndiGo brings together India's largest airline and the country's largest private airport operator to deliver a more connected and rewarding travel retail experience."

Customers can log in through a dedicated portal, link their IndiGo BluChip membership ID and receive earnings within 24–48 hours of completing their purchase, based on their spends. The initiative aims to deliver a smoother travel experience by combining digital convenience, loyalty benefits and airport retail, thereby elevating the overall journey.

Duty-free stores under the

programme are currently available at airports in Mumbai, Ahmedabad, Thiruvananthapuram, Jaipur, Mangaluru and Lucknow, with expansion planned for Lokpriya Gopinath Bordoloi International Airport (LGBIA) in Guwahati and the newly operational Navi Mumbai International Airport (NMIA).

IndiGo operates more than 27,000 daily flights connecting over 140 destinations worldwide, including 95+ domestic and 40+ international destinations, making it India's largest airline by fleet size and passenger traffic.

AAHL operates eight airports across India, including Mumbai, Ahmedabad, Lucknow, Mangaluru, Jaipur, Guwahati and Thiruvananthapuram, along with NMIA — one of India's largest greenfield airports — which began commercial operations on December 25, 2025.

Indian Army holds mega ex-servicemen rally in Nagaland

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kohima

The Indian Army's Red Shield Division, under the Spear Corps, organised a mega Ex-Servicemen (ESM) rally for Tri-Services veterans at the Kisama Heritage Village in Kohima on Tuesday. The event saw the participation of around 700 veterans, Veer Naris, and Next of Kin (NoK), alongside local residents and youth.

Nagaland Governor Nand Kishore Yadav graced the occasion as the Chief Guest. He was joined by Lieutenant General Abhijit S Pendharkar, GOC-in-C Spear Corps, Major General Shubhankar Basu, GOC Red Shield Division, and other



senior military officials.

The rally, supported by the Nagaland Government and the Ministry of Tourism, focused on resolving pension anomalies, providing medical aid, and extending financial support to the families of fallen heroes. In a gesture to boost local

infrastructure, a tourist bus was handed over to the State Tourism Department during the proceedings.

"The Indian Army remains steadfast in its commitment to the welfare and dignity of our veterans and their families," an official statement noted.



Several facilitation stalls were set up by medical, banking, insurance, and HR agencies to provide on-the-spot assistance regarding welfare schemes. The Army also distributed assistive equipment, including wheelchairs, hearing aids, and heat therapy devices.

The event featured vibrant cultural displays, including Mallakhamb by Maratha soldiers, Bhangra by Sikh troops, and Chendamelam by the Madras Regiment. Distinguished veterans were also felicitated for their service to the nation.

Indian Army and NDRF conduct joint flood relief training 'Exercise Jal Raksha'

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

"Stronger Together: Indian Army and NDRF join hands to enhance flood rescue preparedness and safeguard lives."

In view of the approaching monsoon season and the recurring flood challenges in the region, the Red Shield Gunners under the aegis of Spear Corps conducted Exercise Jal Raksha, a joint flood relief training activity in coordination with the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) on 16–17 March 2026 to enhance preparedness and strengthen inter-agency coordination for flood-related emergencies.

The training commenced with an equipment display and briefing by the Indian Army on the composition,



role and operational capabilities of Flood Relief Columns. Representatives from NDRF also briefed participants on the organisation, responsibilities and functioning of flood response teams.

A practical demonstration of flood relief equipment and rescue techniques was conducted to familiarise par-

ticipants with procedures adopted during flood emergencies.

On the second day, activities were conducted at Rupai and Tengapani Ghat and included ground and drone-based aerial reconnaissance, establishment of a Joint Command Post and execution of joint rescue and casualty evacuation drills

simulating flood emergency scenarios.

NDRF personnel demonstrated boat capsize drills and evacuation techniques, while Army medical teams showcased first aid and emergency medical relief procedures during disaster situations.

NCC cadets and members of the local populace also participated in the activity, gaining exposure to disaster response operations and witnessing first-hand the coordinated efforts of the Indian Army and NDRF in safeguarding lives during natural calamities.

Such joint training initiatives strengthen inter-agency coordination, operational synergy and preparedness, ensuring a swift and effective response during natural disasters.

Postal department launches premium services with 24-hour, 48-hour delivery guarantee

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Department of Posts on Tuesday rolled out three premium services, with 24-hour and 48-hour delivery guarantees for urgent and time-sensitive consignments, as it seeks to reinvent itself against a growing field of courier services that promise delivery within hours.

Launching the services — 24 Speed Post, 24 Speed Post Parcel, and 48 Speed Post — Communications Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia said India Post's revenue growth is encouraging, with a 20 per cent growth in the 11 months of FY26.

Initially, these services are being rolled out in six cities — Delhi, Mumbai, Chennai, Kolkata, Bengaluru, and Hyderabad — with the goal of



providing nationwide coverage by March 2027. The department will utilise dedicated processing and priority air transport to adhere to delivery timelines.

Scindia said the launch marks a moment of renewal for India Post and has out-

lined a massive underlying opportunity.

The e-commerce market, he said, is set to grow to ₹30 lakh crore by 2030, almost tripling from ₹11 lakh crore at present. "Today, parcels are only 5 per cent of our business. But it is our common

objective that parcel (service) has to become the growth engine of our enterprise. In the 11 months of this year (FY26), the parcel business has grown by over 44 per cent... But we have to push this engine even further. There is no reason why we should not become a full-fledged delivery engine," the minister noted.

The new offerings will feature OTP-verified deliveries and comprehensive end-to-end tracking paired with real-time SMS alerts, according to an official statement.

Businesses will have options of 'Book Now, Pay Later' (BNPL), centralised billing, and API integration. Additionally, free pickup for bulk shipments and a money-back guarantee, in case of a delayed delivery, will also be provided.

 BRIEFLY

Ridhima, Tvesa, Jasmine ready for battle in 6th leg of Hero WPG Tour



Ridhima Dilawari, Tvesa Malik and Jasmine Shekar, who have won four of the five events held so far this season on Hero Women's Pro Golf Tour, will lead a big field of 53 players in the sixth leg. Jasmine won the first leg this season, while Ridhima won the second and the fourth and Tvesa Malik took the top honours in the third leg. The strong field at the Jaypee Wishtown Golf Course will also see strong contenders like Amandeep Drall, a former Indian Open runner-up, Anvitha Narender, Seher Atwal, Neha Tripathi, Heena Kang, Jahanvi Bakshi, Vidhatri Urs and Saanvi Somu. The event will also feature seven amateurs in the field. The presence of amateurs has become significant as they have regularly been in contention in recent years. In fact, the fifth leg was won by an amateur Lavanya Gupta, who is not playing this week. The field includes amateur Mahreen Bhatia, who is the defending champion and won the last leg of the 2025 season at the same venue.

Fleetwood to defend DP World India Championship title



World number 3 Tommy Fleetwood will return to defend his title at the DP World India Championship at the Delhi Golf Club from October 15 to 18. Fleetwood triumphed over a world-class field in the inaugural edition last season to claim his eighth DP World Tour title, and he will once again tee it up in the highly anticipated USD 4,000,000 event. "I had an incredible week at the DP World India Championship last season," Fleetwood said in a release. "There is so much to enjoy about being in India, from the warmth of the people and the atmosphere in the city to the food and playing at such a challenging and strategic course. "But what made the week particularly special for me was having my family there to celebrate the win on Sunday." The victory in Delhi last year was a key part of an incredible end to the season for Fleetwood, who also won the FedExCup on the PGA TOUR and made his fourth appearance in the Ryder Cup, helping Team Europe defeat the USA on away soil for the first time since 2012. "Our thanks, of course, go to DP World, who are such huge supporters of our sport, for helping to grow the game in India with this tournament. "It was a pleasure to tee it up in the inaugural event as part of such an incredible field, and I look forward to more of the same in October." The Championship will be the eighth of nine events in the Back 9 phase of the 2026 Race to Dubai, building towards the season-ending Playoffs and culminating in the DP World Tour Championship in November at Jumeirah Golf Estates in Dubai.

Iranian women players granted asylum in Australia join practice session

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Brisbane

Two players from the Iranian women's football team have joined a practice session with a professional club in Brisbane in their first publicly-shared appearance since it emerged they had been granted asylum in Australia. Fatemeh Pasandideh and Atefeh Ramezanisadeh were pictured smiling and wearing the club's colours as they posed alongside a women's elite squad in photos posted to Instagram by the Brisbane Roar on Monday.

The update came as the rest of Iran's soccer delegation left Malaysia bound for Oman, apparently capping a tumultuous episode that saw

Australia's Government offering most of the squad humanitarian visas after the team was knocked out of the Women's Asian Cup. Seven women initially accepted the asylum offer before five changed their minds and said they would return to Iran. Brisbane Roar, which plays in Australia's elite A-League Women's domestic competition, posted a welcome to "Fateme and Atefeh" on Instagram, along with an emoji of a lioness, a nod to the name the Iranian players are known by.

"We remain committed to providing a supportive environment for them whilst they navigate the next stages," Brisbane Roar CEO Kaz Patafta wrote. Both

La Liga: Ciss' goal gives Rayo Vallecano draw with Levante

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Madrid

Pathe Ciss' controversial goal in stoppage time gave Rayo Vallecano a 1-1 draw and shattered visiting Levante's hopes on Monday of a rare win that would boost its chances of avoiding relegation from La Liga.

Levante started the night second from bottom in the table and went ahead when 20-year-old Carlos Espi headed the opener — his fourth goal in three games — four minutes before half-time. However, in the fourth



minute of second half added time, Ciss stole in at the back post to control a cross

and stroke the ball past goalkeeper Mathew Ryan. Although Levante claimed he

handled the ball before shooting, Ciss swore there was no touch. "It wasn't our day but we can't always get what we want," the Senegal midfielder said. "We suffered with a man less and maybe this point will be crucial at the season's end."

The man less was Nobel Mendy, who was shown a second yellow eight minutes after half-time.

The red card forced the home side into a reshuffle and it was more dangerous with 10 men than with 11 as Ciss' last-gasp equaliser proved.

Serie A: Fiorentina beats Cremonese

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Cremona

Fiorentina beat fellow Serie A struggler Cremonese 4-1 in its biggest away win of the season and moved four points clear of the relegation zone on Monday.

It was only the second time all season that Fiorentina scored more than three goals in one game and moved it into 16th place.

The loss extended Cremonese's winless run to 14 matches and left it third from last, four points behind Fiorentina and three behind Lecce. Pisa and Verona shared last place. Fabio Parisi put Fiorentina ahead with a fine solo effort after 25 minutes,



and Roberto Piccoli doubled the lead when he converted a perfect pass from Robin Gosens. Dodo made it 3-0 with a lovely solo goal early in the second half and although David Okereke pulled a goal back for Cremonese nearly an hour in, Albert Gudmundsson added the fourth for Fiorentina.

Igor Thiago celebrates Brazil call-up with goal

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ London

Igor Thiago celebrated his first call-up to the Brazil squad by scoring Brentford's second goal in a 2-2 thriller against Wolves in the Premier League on Monday.

Nearing half-time, the striker tapped into the empty net for his 19th league goal of the season. A few minutes earlier, Michael Kayode's glancing header put Brentford 1-0 up. It was his first goal in his 41st league appearance for the Bees. Adam Armstrong pulled a goal back for Wolves a minute before half-time to round off a thrilling half.

Wolves, the league's bottom side, equalised with 13 minutes left when Tolu



Arokodare headed home at the back post.

The result extended Wolves' unbeaten league run to three games but it remained bottom of the table, 12 points from safety.

"We know where we are in the league, it hasn't been good enough," Armstrong said, "but since I've come in

Champions League: Real Madrid, PSG and Bodö/Glimt protect 3-goal leads in round of 16

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

Protecting three-goal leads, Champions League heavyweights Real Madrid and Paris Saint-Germain (PSG) will look to clinch their places in the quarterfinals on Tuesday.

So, amazingly, will tiny Bodö/Glimt. There's a one-sided look to the first batch of second-leg matches to be completed in the round of 16, as Madrid and PSG arrive in England with a 3-0 lead over Manchester City and a 5-2 lead over Chelsea, respectively. This could be a tough week for the much-hyped Premier League, as all six of



its round-of-16 representatives failed to win across the first legs. Arsenal looks best

placed of the English teams to advance and will take on Bayer Leverkusen in London

on Tuesday with the score at 1-1. Then there's Bodö/Glimt, in its debut season in the Champions League and easily the least-heralded team to make it through to the knockout stage.

The Norwegian club leads Sporting Lisbon 3-0 from the first leg and is looking to complete another upset, having eliminated Inter Milan — last season's runner-up — in the playoff round and beaten Man City and Atletico Madrid in its final two matches of the first phase to avoid getting knocked out. No Norwegian club has reached the quarterfinals since Rosenborg in 1997.

No Neymar for Brazil's last friendlies

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Rio de Janeiro

Neymar was left out of Brazil's friendlies in the United States this month. The 34-year-old former captain has struggled to be fit since he tore his ACL in October 2023.

Brazil will play France in Boston on March 26 and Croatia in Orlando four days later. "This is a squad that takes into account players who are 100 per cent fit," Brazil coach Carlo Ancelotti said on Monday. "We had important injuries to players like Eder Militao, Bruno Guimaraes, Estevao and Rodrygo." Neymar didn't play



well on Sunday in Santos' 1-1 draw with Corinthians in the Brazilian league. Hours later, Neymar told media at an event in Sao Paulo he was "upset and sad" for not being in Brazil's squad for the two friendlies.

appointed to have let the game slip," Bees captain Jordan Henderson said. Just hours before kickoff, Brazil coach Carlo Ancelotti named Thiago in the squad for friendlies against France in Boston on March 26 and Croatia in Orlando four days later. The former Cruzeiro, Ludogorets and Brugge striker was one of nine forwards included in a 26-man list that featured Endrick of Lyon, Rayan of Bournemouth, and Joao Pedro of Chelsea but no Neymar, who has underperformed recently at Santos. He has excelled for Brentford this season and could have scored one or two more against Wolves. His 19-goal tally is the highest ever by a Brentford player in one Premier League season.

LA 2028 Olympic football to kick off 4 days early



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Los Angeles

Men's and women's football at the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics will begin four days before the opening ceremony and be played in seven cities around the United States.

The early start, approved by the IOC, allows teams two extra rest days during the tournament compared to previous Olympics. The schedule also includes additional rest days after the group stage and quarterfinals, giving teams time to travel. The matches will start on July 10, with the group stage and quarterfinals being played in New York, Columbus, Ohio, Nashville, Tennessee, and St. Louis.

The knockout rounds will move to California, taking place in San Jose, San Diego and Pasadena, with the gold medal matches at the historic Rose Bowl. The stadium hosted the 1994 men's World Cup final, the 1999 women's World Cup final and the 1984 Olympic gold-medal match. New York and Columbus will

host nine men's and women's matches on July 10-11, July 13-14 and July 16-17, as well as a men's quarterfinal on July 20. Nashville will also host nine matches, with group-stage games on the same dates and both men's and women's quarterfinals on July 20-21.

St. Louis will host eight matches on July 10-17, with a men's quarterfinal on July 20. San Jose will host seven matches, including women's group-stage games on July 11, 14 and 17 and a quarterfinal on July 21. San Diego will be the site of 11 matches, including women's group-stage games, a women's quarterfinal on July 21, men's and women's semifinals on July 24-25, and the bronze-medal matches on July 27-28.

The tournament ends at the Rose Bowl, which will host five matches, including a women's quarterfinal on July 21, men's and women's semifinals on July 24-25 and the gold-medal matches on July 28-29. The complete schedule will be released later this year.

WADA is weighing a rule to bar Trump and US officials from major events. Can it really do that?

EDDIE PELLASAP
■ New York

The idea sounds outlandish, if not downright impossible. Leaders at the World Anti-Doping Agency are considering adopting a rule that could bar President Donald Trump and all U.S. government officials from attending major international events - even if they take place on American soil. A few coming up are as big as they get: this summer's World Cup; the LA Olympics in 2028; the Winter Games in Utah in 2034.

This is not a fight of Trump's choosing, but rather one being pursued by WADA itself, which has been the subject of bipartisan and virtually universal disapproval in

Congress, in the Trump and Biden administrations and in the offices of the US Anti-Doping Agency for most of this decade.

The proposal, on the agenda for Tuesday's meeting of the WADA executive committee, is the latest and most extreme maneuver in a years-long exchange of rhetoric, threats and fighting between all parties. It stems from the US government's refusal to pay its annual WADA dues.

The US has held back a total of \$7.3 million over 2024 and 2025 in protest of WADA's handling of a number of issues over the years, most recently, a case involving Chinese swimmers who were allowed to compete despite testing positive for a banned

substance. WADA took Chinese regulators' word that the athletes had been accidentally contaminated.

WADA spokesman James Fitzgerald said the rule, if passed, would "not (be) applied retroactively so World Cup, LA and SLC Games would not be covered." However, the proposal, a copy of which was obtained by The Associated Press, does not include language to that effect. Fitzgerald did not respond to a series of follow-up questions sent Monday, including one asking how a rule being considered for passage this year would not be applied retroactively to events that have not taken place. Fitzgerald did say last week that the final decision



wasn't due until November, after the World Cup, though correspondence between WADA and European officials indicated that decision could come sooner.

What gives WADA the power to ban Trump?

Part of sending teams to

major international events, such as the Olympics and the World Cup, requires everyone involved to pledge to follow WADA's rules, whether they're directly related to doping or to administrative issues, the likes of which the latest proposal covers.

Sports organisations — for instance the IOC and the governing bodies of individual sports — are considered "signatories" to the WADA code. Governments are tethered to WADA as part of an agreement they sign with the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) Like sports organizations, the UNESCO arrangement includes the governments agreeing to pay dues and follow WADA's rules.

Could WADA really prevent Trump from attending an event in his own country?

It's hard to see how. Rahul Gupta - the drug czar during the Biden Administration who was every bit as critical of WADA as is his successor,

Sara Carter — called the idea "ludicrous."

"That's the responsibility of the government, not so much WADA," Gupta said. "It's clear that WADA attempting to propagate any rules-based system that interferes with a government, especially a host government — that would be a concern to any government."

While Trump has not weighed in on this specifically, Carter, his drug czar, said the US government "will continue to stand firm in our demand for accountability and transparency from WADA to ensure fair competition in sport."

After the latest news, Sen. Marsha Blackburn, R-Tenn., said on social media that the

proposal was "Further proof we're doing the right thing by demanding accountability and defunding WADA."

What is WADA's reason for proposing such a rule?

WADA runs on a budget of around \$57.5 million and the US chunk is significant, though hardly the only payment that has gone missing over the years. One analysis of dues payments, obtained by the AP, showed that only 49% of African countries had paid their WADA dues for 2025.

But no country has been more critical of WADA than the United States, which has floated the idea of holding back dues since 2020 and finally followed through two years ago. (AP)

Harshit to miss most of IPL due to injury

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Kolkata Knight Riders (KKR) pacer Harshit Rana is likely to miss a significant part of the upcoming IPL as he continues to recover from a knee surgery he underwent last month. According to a report by 'ESPNCricinfo', the BCCI is yet to fix a timeline for his return. Rana, who sustained a ligament strain in his right knee injury during India's T20 World Cup warm-up match against South Africa, is currently undergoing rehabilitation, with "no firm date of return earmarked by the BCCI medical team yet". The pacer had pulled up after delivering just one over in that game and was subse-



quently ruled out of the T20 World Cup following surgery. He was replaced by Mohammed Siraj, who played one match (against the USA) during India's title-winning campaign. Rana was on Sunday awarded the Best International Debutant award at the BCCI Naman Awards. His absence would come as a major setback for three-time IPL champions KKR, who are already grappling with multiple fitness concerns. Sri Lanka pacer Matheesha Pathirana has been nursing a calf strain sustained during the T20 World Cup, which had initially not been expected to affect his IPL availability. KKR are also without left-arm

seamer Mustafizur Rahman after the BCCI instructed it to release the Bangladeshi player amid strained geopolitical relations between India and Bangladesh earlier this year. The franchise has since signed Zimbabwe quick Blessing Muzarabani as a replacement. Muzarabani opted out of his Pakistan Super League stint with Islamabad United as he is set to join the squad here Tuesday. The KKR will begin their pre-season training here from Wednesday. KKR's other pace options include Vaibhav Arora, Akash Deep, Umran Malik, Kartik Tyagi, and all-rounders Cameron Green and Ramandeep Singh.

New Zealand beats South Africa by 68 runs in 2nd T20 and series level

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Hamilton

Devon Conway topped all scorers with 60 as New Zealand beat South Africa by 68 runs in the second Twenty20 to level their five-match series at 1-1 on Tuesday. New Zealand made 175-6 after being sent in on a pitch which became trickier as the evening wore on. South Africa was bowled out for 107 in 15.3 overs as pacers Ben Sears and Lockie Ferguson shared six wickets. Batters struggled for timing on a pitch which provided variable pace and bounce and all 10 South Africa wickets fell to catches. South Africa



lost its last six wickets for 40 runs and only George Linde stood against the collapse, scoring 33 from 12 balls with three fours and three sixes. Sears was New Zealand's travelling reserve at the recent T20 World Cup and took 3-14. Ferguson took 3-16, dismissing

Linde to end the innings. "I thought we bowled really well up to a point and then lost our way with the bat," South Africa captain Keshav Maharaj said. "We thought the dew was going to play a large factor in terms of changing the wicket."

MS Dhoni must bat no lower than number six or step aside: de Villiers

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

In a blunt assessment, South African batting legend AB de Villiers stated on Tuesday that MS Dhoni must bat no lower than number six in the upcoming IPL, as coming in at eight or nine does not do justice to his presence. Dhoni, 44, will turn out for his franchise Chennai Super Kings in the IPL starting March 28, and De Villiers urged the talisman to change his trend of batting way down the order in recent years. Touching upon Dhoni's role in the CSK setup this IPL season, De Villiers told JioHotstar, "It's very tricky



and not straightforward. Brands are built over years, and CSK have built this empire over many years with this MS Dhoni figure that's always been there. When you mention CSK, you immediately think of Dhoni. "I feel that in the last few years, his role has purely been about keeping that

brand as strong as possible. That's why I don't see a role for him batting at eight or nine and not really doing enough, like last season. "We know he can be impactful with the bat, but if he's batting that low and not captaining, it feels like he's almost just making up for a spot for the wrong reasons. There's still a place for him, but he needs to bat higher, at least at six, maybe even at five or four at times." De Villiers added, "It's a tricky situation, but Sanju Samson is the right guy to take over, and credit to Dhoni because he's hung around, waiting for the right person to come.

The more Tests we play, the better it will be for us: Pratika

AMIT ANAND AND HIMANK NEGI
■ New Delhi

India's top-order batter Pratika Rawal, who scored a fighting half-century on her Test debut in Australia earlier this month, has advocated for more women's Tests, saying the traditional format remains the "most beautiful" and the ultimate test of a cricketer's character. Pratika played a crucial role in helping India avoid an innings defeat in the one-off day-night Test on the Australia tour earlier this month, scoring a 137-ball 63 runs in the second innings. Speaking on the sidelines of the Sports Journalists Federation of India conference hosted by the Delhi

Sports Journalists Association here on Monday, the 25-year-old said Test cricket holds a special place for her. "Test cricket is the most beautiful format. Since childhood my father and coach have told me that performing well in this format is very important. When you are groomed in that manner, it naturally becomes your favourite format," she told PTI. Pratika added that she prepared herself for the format by watching videos of great Test batters such as Viv Richards, Sachin Tendulkar, Brian Lara and Ricky Ponting. "I have watched many videos of these great batters. The way they used to play in Test cricket has always inspired me," she said. Urging



for more women's Tests, Pratika said increasing the number of games would greatly benefit players. "The more Test matches we play, the better it will be. The experience of playing Test cricket not only improves you as a cricketer but also helps

you grow as an individual," she said. At the closing ceremony of the four-day golden jubilee national convention of the SJFI held at Arun Jaitley Stadium. Rohan Jaitley, president of the Delhi and District Cricket Association presented Pratika

with a cash award of ₹51 lakh. Uddhav Mohan, a member of India's Under-19 men's World Cup-winning team, was also honoured with a cash prize of ₹11 lakh. Pratika further said the recognition motivates players to perform better. "I'm extremely happy. It is wonderful when players receive recognition from time to time. I have played a lot of cricket in Delhi and to come here and receive an award from Rohan Sir is a proud moment for me," she said. Before being ruled out of last year's Women's World Cup due to injury, Pratika had scored 308 runs in six innings from seven matches, including a century, finishing fourth on the tournament's list of leading run-scorers. (PTI)

Fiery passion of youth fuelled India's title defence: Suryakumar

VIJAY JOSHI
■ New Delhi

The 2024 batch had "experienced enthusiasm" to push for a drought-ending ICC trophy, while it was the "fiery passion of youth" that fuelled India's unprecedented title defence of the T20 World Cup this year, skipper Suryakumar Yadav said, comparing the two champion squads. In a wide-ranging podcast interview with PTI, Suryakumar spoke on the subtle difference between the two trophy-winning squads. In 2024, he played under Rohit Sharma, and the squad also had the towering presence of Virat Kohli and Ravindra Jadeja. Those three stalwarts retired from the shortest



format following the triumph in Barbados, handing over the baton to the uninhibited Suryakumar and Co., who took India's T20 game to the

next level. "There was just a 'unniss bess ka farak' (minor difference) between the two teams. Woh experience wala josh tha, Idhar ekdum khoon

garam tha ladkon ka (that was experienced enthusiasm (in 2024), this was fiery passion)," that was how Suryakumar compared the two squads. India were overwhelming favourites heading into the 2026 edition at home, but the same cannot be said about the class of 2024, which had to overcome the mental demons on the way to an elusive ICC crown. "...in 2024, we had a lot of experience. And at that time, there was experience, and there were many good players. "There are good players even now, but then, at that time, our team had a lot of experience, and every-one was perfectly defined for their role," said Suryakumar when asked if

the 2026 squad was slightly superior to the one fielded in 2024. Suryakumar's team also had to deal with the higher expectations associated with playing at home. "This year, I can say that we had less experience but more (enthusiasm). All the guys are 25 to 27 years old. It was necessary to explain to them how it feels to win a World Cup in India, when people will cheer so much for you - 50,000 people, a lakh people, in the stadium. "What kind of feeling that would be, it was necessary to tell them a little bit. Otherwise, in my opinion, if you look at teams skill-wise, there's only a slight difference in the T20 format. But I feel, this time there was more enthusiasm." (PTI)

Couldn't get it in academics but cricket got me my 80 per cent score: SKY

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

It eluded him in academics but on the cricket field, Suryakumar Yadav has finally got his 80 per cent score. Basking in the glory of leading India to a historic defence of the T20 World Cup title just a few days ago, Suryakumar has an 80 per cent winning rate as national captain in the format. The Mumbaiaikaar was expectedly chuffed about the numbers but that he just could not manage academically. "I feel that the percentage I tried to achieve in school and college by studying, I'm getting that today in cricket here," he quipped when



asked to reflect on the success rate since taking over as T20 captain in 2024. Out of 52 games played in that period, the two-time T20 world champions have won 42 matches. "There (in school or college), I could never cross

(50-60 per cent). But definitely, it feels good to hear this (80 per cent winning rate) here. Although, I don't pay much attention to stats. But nobody likes to lose in any game. I also love winning all the games," he said. Suryakumar's father Ashok Kumar Yadav was an Electrical Engineer at the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre (BARC). But Suryakumar never felt inclined towards academics and his family was supportive enough to back his crick-eting ambitions. "...my family tried a lot to educate me first....(but) in a short time they got the idea that this boy is not interest-ed in studies.

Apologised to Mitchell for Arshdeep throwing incident: Suryakumar



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's T20 skipper Suryakumar Yadav has revealed that he personally apologised to New Zealand's Daryl Mitchell after he was hit by an Arshdeep Singh throw during the recent World Cup final as he wanted to set an example of good leadership. Arshdeep was fined 15 per cent of his match fee and handed a demerit point by the ICC for throwing the ball that hit Mitchell on his pads. The pacer did not immediately apologise which prompted Mitchell to confront him, leading to an intervention by Suryakumar and the on-field umpires. Arshdeep eventually issued a public apology and the two players shook hands

at the end of the match that India won by 96 runs to retain the trophy. Asked about the aggression on display in that moment during a podcast interview with PTI Videos, Suryakumar made light of the incident. "Heat of the moment mein kabhi kabhi ho jaata hai (It happens in the heat of the moment sometimes). At that time you don't fully understand what is happening. But later, I told paaji, that this is not how it happens. He then spoke to Mitchell and it was a light moment," the skipper said. "He took it in his stride. But it was very important for me to go and tell Daryl Mitchell myself, because as a leader, what example you set on the ground, that is also also very important.

When an honest question from wife changed course of SKY's career

VIJAY JOSHI
■ New Delhi

It was her matter-of-fact query that drove him to slog hard for a national call-up. And now that Suryakumar Yadav is a World Cup-winning captain, he can't praise his "brutally honest" wife Devisha enough for shaping the man he has become. It was in 2018 when Devisha asked Suryakumar a simple question: "If you want to play for India, how do you plan to do it?" Eight years since that "brutally honest conversation", Suryakumar led India to a successful T20 World Cup title defence. "We got married in 2016 when I was still playing for KKR. Everything was going

very smooth. I was playing well, enjoying and she looked at my journey and my routines till 2018 when I joined Mumbai Indians. I think we started doing things a little differently," Suryakumar recalled during a podcast interview with "PTI Videos". "She told me that all those who played with you in age group, a lot of them are now playing for India, what do you have in mind? I said: 'Mujhe bhi India khelna hai (I want to play for India too)'. 'Kaise khelege' (how do you plan to do it?), she asked. "It was a nice little conversation with her, not an argument but discussion. But yes, it was a discussion about how can you take one extra step forward in your endeav-



our. If I want to play for India and want to win games for India, how do I do it?" the 35-year-old revealed his career-changing tete-a-tete with the wife. Once a decision about taking that extra step towards realising the ultimate goal was taken, some hard life choices were also

on cards and as a couple Suryakumar and Devisha walked that path. "We had to cut down on a lot of things — from diet, to friends circles to weekends, rest on Saturday-Sunday, Monday to Friday work schedule, so we set the ball rolling and in 2018, I had a very good IPL season (512

runs) and also domestic cricket," he said. "That year, I got a chance to open for Mumbai Indians and I got runs too. Come 2019 and 2020, we kept doing the same thing and I was in a different mood. She saw that he has started enjoying even more, 2020 was even better (480 runs as finisher) and then in 2021 I got picked for India," Suryakumar added. The amiable skipper said Devisha remained behind the scenes to be his pillar of strength. "She has been a big influence behind the scenes in telling me honest things. If it is your partner, she will always be honest because all she would want is your growth because if you want to grow together, conversa-

tions have to be honest. "At times, it has been brutal too, but then it has been good. If I am where I am today, those conversations have gone a long way." Devisha never stepped into his cricketing world as that wasn't her domain but what she advised him on was life beyond cricket. "I give her 100 per cent credit because it is not that she gave me crick-eting advice but she told me a lot of things related to life. What do I do? How to approach a certain situation? How do I carry myself?" And last but not the least, she kept him grounded at home by telling him to leave cricket at the doorstep before entering the Yadav household. (PTI)

With squash on Olympics calendar, every player will have LA Games in mind: Anahat

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

India's top-ranked squash player, Anahat Singh, expects the 2028 Los Angeles Games to be the primary focus for every player over the next two years as the sport makes its Olympic debut there. Winning a medal at the Olympics is the dream of every player, Anahat said here on Tuesday. "It's obviously very exciting, (It) is the first time that



it is a part of the Olympics and all the athletes have been really looking forward to," Anahat said during a pre-tournament press conference for the JSW Indian Open. "Before this, the biggest event (one) could play was maybe the Commonwealth (Games), but now the Olympics is there, and it's of course, every athlete's dream to go and play in the Olympics and win a medal." "For the next few years,

that is going to be everyone's aim and in the long run, that is going to be on my mind as well, to make sure that I'm able to train up to the Olympics and possibly get a medal for the country," Anahat added. The JSW Indian Open is a PSA Copper event which will provide players an opportunity to earn ranking points while building momentum towards the Asian Games later this year. India's second highest ranked male player

Ramit Tandon said the inclusion of the sport into the Olympic programme has also attracted corporates. "It (Olympics) is the biggest sporting event in the world, so it's everyone's dream to be there. Apart from that, what our sports has benefitted from is JSW and (other) corporates getting on board after it has gone into the Olympics," he said. "We're having tournaments like this, which would not have happened if squash wasn't in the Olympics.